

THE SCHUBERT BIALGEBRA

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ABSTRACT. We introduce a *Schubert bialgebra* $\mathcal{A} = \bigoplus_{n \geq 0} \mathbb{Z}[x_1, \dots, x_n]$, in which polynomials in different numbers of variables multiply to zero and the coproduct splits the variables into two consecutive blocks, and study its graded dual $\mathcal{D}$, whose product is concatenation of weak compositions. The Schubert polynomials $\mathfrak{S}_u^n$ form a basis of $\mathcal{A}$; we give an explicit formula for the dual Schubert basis Ξ_u^n of $\mathcal{D}$ via a transition formula to an elementary symmetric basis, and show that the Schubert structure constants $c_{u,v}^w$ are the coefficients of the coproduct of $\mathcal{D}$ in the dual Schubert basis. The product of $\mathcal{D}$ is then lifted to an associative product $\boxplus$ on the free abelian group $\mathcal{BRC}$ of bounded RC graphs, built from a transition map $\mathcal{Z}$ on RC graphs that realizes the Lascoux–Schützenberger transition formula and generalizes Little’s bumping algorithm. Quotienting $\mathcal{BRC}$ by ideals coming from Demazure crystal equivalence, Nadeau–Tewari forest equivalence, and quasi-Yamanouchi equivalence yields manifestly positive Littlewood–Richardson rules for the dual Schubert, dual key, dual forest, and dual slide bases of $\mathcal{D}$. Read on $\mathcal{A}$, these are branching rules: enumerative formulas for splitting a Schubert, key, forest, or slide polynomial across two blocks of variables, and in the Schubert case they compute the Levi branching coefficients of Ressayre–Richmond for $\mathrm{GL}_p \times \mathrm{GL}_q \hookrightarrow \mathrm{GL}_{p+q}$.

1. INTRODUCTION

Schubert polynomials $\mathfrak{S}_u$, $u \in S_\infty$, form a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of $\mathbb{Z}[x_1, x_2, \dots]$ whose structure constants $c_{u,v}^w$ are the intersection numbers of Schubert varieties in the flag variety. A positive combinatorial formula for the $c_{u,v}^w$ in general remains open. A related, and more tractable, family of coefficients arises when one asks not how Schubert polynomials multiply but how they *split*: expanding $\mathfrak{S}_w(x_1, \dots, x_{p+q})$ in the basis $\{\mathfrak{S}_u(x_1, \dots, x_p) \mathfrak{S}_v(x_{p+1}, \dots, x_{p+q})\}$ produces the branching coefficients for the Levi subgroup $\mathrm{GL}_p \times \mathrm{GL}_q \hookrightarrow \mathrm{GL}_{p+q}$ studied in the branching Schubert calculus of Ressayre–Richmond [31]. This paper introduces an algebraic framework in which these splitting problems become multiplication problems in the dual of a bialgebra, and a combinatorial framework, a ring of RC graphs, in which they acquire manifestly positive enumerative solutions for the Schubert basis and for the key, forest, and slide bases as well.

The Schubert bialgebra and its dual. In initial sections, we introduce a bialgebra $\mathcal{A}$ that we call the Schubert bialgebra. This bialgebra has a basis of Schubert polynomials $\mathfrak{S}_u^n$ for $u \in S_\infty$, where the last descent of u is not past index n . The structure constants for multiplication in this basis are the same as the structure constants for multiplication of Schubert polynomials. The difference from the usual realm of study of Schubert polynomials, which is the polynomial ring in infinitely many variables, is that this algebra is graded into length components that interact trivially. That is,

$$\mathcal{A} = \bigoplus_{n=0}^{\infty} \mathbb{Z}[x_1, \dots, x_n].$$

This allows us to consistently define a “splitting” coproduct that is compatible with the usual product of polynomials but actively requires the triviality of products between length components to achieve a bialgebra structure.

We focus primarily on the dual $\mathcal{D}$ of this algebra, where the product is derived from this splitting (deconcatenation) coproduct on $\mathcal{A}$. Specifically, let Comp_n be the set of weak compositions of length n . Then, additively,

$$\mathcal{D} = \bigoplus_{n=0}^{\infty} \mathbb{Z}^{\oplus \mathrm{Comp}_n}$$

and multiplicatively the product of two basis elements indexed by $a \in \mathrm{Comp}_p$ and $b \in \mathrm{Comp}_q$ is the basis element indexed by the concatenation of a and b , which is an element of Comp_{p+q} . We will denote this

product by $\sqcup$, writing $a \sqcup b$ for the concatenation. The coproduct on $\mathcal{D}$ is given by splitting sums of exponents, that is to say

$$\Delta(c) = \sum_{a+b=c} a \otimes b$$

where a and b are weak compositions of the same length as c and $a + b$ denotes the pointwise sum. The counit is given by $\varepsilon(c) = 0$ unless c is the empty composition, in which case $\varepsilon(c) = 1$. With these definitions, $\mathcal{A}$ and $\mathcal{D}$ are dual bialgebras over $\mathbb{Z}$ (with $\mathcal{A}$ non-unital: the constant $1 \in \mathcal{A}_n$ is a unit for $\mathcal{A}_n$ only), a fact that is straightforward to verify. Neither $\mathcal{A}$ nor $\mathcal{D}$ is connected, and neither is a Hopf algebra. A “Littlewood–Richardson rule” for a basis of the dual algebra is equivalent to a branching/splitting formula for the corresponding polynomial basis under the partition of variables into two blocks $\{x_1, \dots, x_p\}$ and $\{x_{p+1}, \dots, x_{p+q}\}$.

The algebraic structure of $\mathcal{D}$ is not itself new; what is new is the product on the dual Schubert basis Ξ_u^n of $\mathcal{D}$ indexed by $u \in S_\infty$ and n at least as large as the last descent of u , defined by

$$\langle \Xi_u^m, \mathfrak{S}_v^n \rangle = \delta_{u,v} \delta_{m,n}$$

where we take $\langle -, - \rangle$ to be the pairing where for each composition $c \in \text{Comp}_n$,

$$\langle c, x^a \rangle = \delta_{c,a}$$

where a is any composition. (It is worth pointing out that c and c padded with an additional 0 are considered different here.) We present an explicit formula for the dual Schubert basis in $\mathcal{D}$ with integer coefficients.

A dual basis to the Schubert polynomials is not new either: Postnikov and Stanley [29] introduced a family of dual Schubert polynomials $\mathfrak{D}_w$ in the polynomial ring with respect to a particular integral pairing, characterized by a formula that mimics the action of divided difference operators on Schubert polynomials. The relationship between the two bases is that the coefficients of $\mathfrak{D}_u$ in the divided power algebra are, up to a scalar factor, the same as the coefficients of Ξ_u^n in the weak composition basis.

In addition, the dual forest basis $\{\mathfrak{P}_a^*\}$ of $\mathcal{D}$ is defined by $\langle \mathfrak{P}_a^*, \mathfrak{P}_b \rangle = \delta_{a,b}$. As we record in Proposition 6.2.2, this dual basis coincides, up to a divided-power normalization, with the volume polynomials of Nadeau–Spink–Tewari [25] and, geometrically, with the Kronecker dual of the homology basis $\{[X(F)]\} \subset H_\bullet(\text{QFl}_n)$ of Bergeron–Gagnon–Nadeau–Spink–Tewari [4]. We also consider the dual bases of key polynomials and slide polynomials.

Littlewood–Richardson rules for dual bases. Each of these dual bases in fact has nonnegative structure constants with $\sqcup$, for which we also give rules in terms of RC graphs. For an RC graph R with n rows and an integer $0 \leq p \leq n$, we associate to R two RC graphs $\text{clip}^p(R) \in \mathcal{RC}_p$ and $\text{trim}^p(R) \in \mathcal{RC}_{n-p}$, which the reader should picture as a decomposition of R across the horizontal cut between rows p and $p+1$. The map trim^p is simple: it discards the top p rows and keeps the remaining $n-p$ rows (suitably reindexed). The map clip^p is subtler. It is built by iterating an auxiliary map $\mathcal{Z} : \mathcal{RC}_n^0 \rightarrow \mathcal{RC}_{n-1}$ (Definition 4.3.1), where $\mathcal{RC}_n^0$ denotes the set of RC graphs whose last row is empty. The map $\mathcal{Z}$ realizes, on the level of RC graphs, the Lascoux–Schützenberger transition formula for Schubert polynomials (see [21]), and ends up being a generalization of the main result of [20], though this was not intentional. The whole construction preserves a wealth of additional structure (crystal operators, forest invariants) that we exploit later. Indeed, the product of $\mathcal{D}$ is lifted to a product $\sqcup$ on the free abelian group $\mathcal{BRC}$ of bounded RC graphs using clip^p and trim^p , for which $\mathcal{D}$ is a quotient (§4). The nonnegativity of the structure constants of all of these bases of $\mathcal{D}$ is a consequence of this quotient structure.

For the dual Schubert basis $\{\Xi_u^n\}$ for permutations u with last descent at most n , we have the following result.

Theorem 1.1 (LR rule for dual Schubert polynomials). *Suppose $u, v \in S_\infty$ and $p, q \geq 0$ are integers such that the last descent of u is at most p and the last descent of v is at most q . Define integers $d_{u,v}^w(p, q)$ by the equation*

$$\Xi_u^p \sqcup \Xi_v^q = \sum_w d_{u,v}^w(p, q) \Xi_w^{p+q}.$$

Then for any fixed choices of RC graphs $U \in \mathcal{RC}_p(u)$, $V \in \mathcal{RC}_q(v)$, and a permutation $w \in S_\infty$, we have that $d_{u,v}^w(p, q)$ is the number of RC graphs $R \in \mathcal{RC}_{p+q}(w)$ such that $\text{clip}^p(R) = U$ and $\text{trim}^p(R) = V$, and is in particular nonnegative.

Cast as a splitting rule for $\mathfrak{S}_w$, Theorem 1.1 fits the framework of *branching Schubert calculus* of Ressayre–Richmond [31] for the Levi inclusion $\mathrm{GL}_P \times \mathrm{GL}_Q \hookrightarrow \mathrm{GL}_{P+Q}$ (with $P = B$): the Ressayre–Richmond branching coefficients d_w^w in this case are exactly our $d_{u,v}^w(p, q)$, and Theorem 1.1 supplies for them an explicit positive cardinality formula. The associativity of $\sqcup$ encodes the compatibility of these splittings across all $p, q \geq 0$ simultaneously, packaging the entire family of Levi comorphisms into the single algebra $(\mathcal{D}, \sqcup)$.

The dual forest basis has nonnegative structure constants for the same structural reason. The coefficient $f_{a,b}^c$ in $\mathfrak{P}_a^* \sqcup \mathfrak{P}_b^* = \sum_c f_{a,b}^c \mathfrak{P}_c^*$ counts, within the forest equivalence class of composition c , the RC graphs whose row-splitting lands in forest-classes of compositions a and b ; the count is well-defined on equivalence classes and is nonnegative (Theorem 6.4). Read on the quasisymmetric flag variety QFl_n of Bergeron–Gagnon–Nadeau–Spink–Tewari [4], whose cohomology has the forest polynomials as a basis, this is a branching rule for the variable-splitting comorphism $H^\bullet(\mathrm{QFl}_{p+q}) \rightarrow H^\bullet(\mathrm{QFl}_p) \otimes H^\bullet(\mathrm{QFl}_q)$ (§6.3).

The key polynomials κ_a (Demazure characters in type A) form a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of $\mathbb{Z}[x_1, x_2, \dots]$ indexed by weak compositions; we defer definitions to §5. The dual key basis $\{\kappa_a^*\}$ of $\mathcal{D}$ is defined by $\langle \kappa_a^*, \kappa_b \rangle = \delta_{a,b}$; its structure as a bialgebra basis appears to be new. The dual key rule (Theorem 5.4) has the same shape as the dual Schubert and dual forest rules but replaces forest equivalence classes with Demazure crystal components: $k_{a,b}^c$ counts, within the crystal component of highest weight c , those RC graphs whose row-splitting produces highest-weight pieces of compositions a and b . We later found that nonnegativity of the $k_{a,b}^c$ also follows from Mathieu’s existence theorem for excellent filtrations on tensor products of Demazure modules [23]; an explicit positive combinatorial rule had not previously appeared.

In a similar vein, the dual slide basis $\{\mathfrak{F}_a^*\}$ of $\mathcal{D}$ is defined by $\langle \mathfrak{F}_a^*, \mathfrak{F}_b \rangle = \delta_{a,b}$, where $\mathfrak{F}_b$ is the slide polynomial of Assaf–Searles [2]. We give a Littlewood–Richardson rule for this basis as well.

These formulas bear a striking similarity to each other, which is no coincidence: they are all consequences of the same underlying machinery, and in particular of the same maps $\mathbf{clip}^p$ and $\mathbf{trim}^p$ on RC graphs. A general “dual LR rule factory” is given in Theorem 7.3, which gives a recipe for producing such rules whenever one has a family of polynomials with a positive combinatorial formula in terms of RC graphs that is compatible with the maps $\mathbf{clip}^p$ and $\mathbf{trim}^p$. The dual Schubert, dual key, dual forest, and dual slide bases all fit into this framework, and thus yield the four rules above as special cases.

Further directions. Beyond this, there is potentially much to explore. For example, the coproduct of $\mathcal{D}$ has as its structure constants the structure constants of Schubert polynomials, which have evaded expression in terms of positive formulas for decades, and at the time of this writing no positive, combinatorial formula is known for the structure constants of Schubert polynomials that applies in all cases. At the very least, this coproduct is a new potential method of attack on this and related problems, since, to our knowledge, it was previously unknown. An expression for Ξ_w^n in the composition basis leads to a simple, purely mechanical method for computing all $c_{u,v}^w$ (generalized Littlewood–Richardson coefficients for Schubert polynomials) by leveraging the extremely simple form the coproduct takes on the weak composition basis, as well as a neat positive formula for the expansion of a weak composition $[a]$ in the Schubert basis.

For the reader familiar with bumpless pipe dreams [17], we state as a conjecture that our apparently complex transition algorithm for RC graphs can be realized almost trivially for bumpless pipe dreams. Specifically, while (reduced) bumpless pipe dreams are typically defined in such a way that they cannot deviate from a square shape, there is indeed a consistent way to remove rows from a bumpless pipe dream unambiguously. This was observed by Yu in [38, Lemma 3.18] in the definition of a k -row BPD. Weigandt in [37] defines a transition formula $\mathbf{t} : \mathrm{BPD}_n \rightarrow \mathrm{BPD}_{n-1}$, and while the image is realized as square, it agrees with Yu’s notion of an $n - 1$ -row BPD.

Gao and Huang in [10] defined a natural bijection between RC graphs and bumpless pipe dreams: given a bumpless pipe dream B with n rows, we define $\phi(B)$ to be the corresponding RC graph under this bijection.

Conjecture 1.2. *Let B be a k -row reduced bumpless pipe dream such that row k has no blanks (“weighty tiles”). Then*

$$\mathcal{Z}(\phi(B)) = \phi(\mathbf{t}(B))$$

This simplicity does not come for free, however; the $\mathbf{trim}^p$ operation on BPDs is no longer trivial.

We conjecture a far stronger result that would result in a generalization of the Schubert bialgebra to K -theory. Let $\mathrm{MBPD}(n)$ denote the set of n -row marked bumpless pipe dreams and let $\mathrm{Pipe}(n)$ denote the set of n -row not-necessarily-reduced pipe dreams. Huang, Shimozono, and Yu in [14] present a bijection $\Phi : \mathrm{MBPD}(n) \rightarrow \mathrm{Pipe}(n)$.

For $P \in \text{Pipe}(n)$ and $p \leq n$, let

$$\text{clip}^p(P) = \Phi(\mathbf{t}^{n-p}(\Phi^{-1}(P))).$$

Define a function $\boxplus : \text{Pipe}(m) \times \text{Pipe}(n) \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}^{\text{Pipe}(m+n)}$ by

$$P \boxplus Q = \sum_{R \in \text{Pipe}(m+n), \text{clip}^m(R)=P, \text{trim}^m(R)=Q} R.$$

Then

Conjecture 1.3. *Define*

$$\text{BPIPE} = \bigoplus_{n=0}^{\infty} \mathbb{Z}^{\text{Pipe}(n)}.$$

Then we have the following:

- $\boxplus : \text{Pipe}(n) \times \text{Pipe}(m) \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}^{\text{Pipe}(n+m)}$ *extends to an associative product on BPIPE for which it is a graded ring.*
- *The map $\mathbf{f} : \text{BPIPE} \rightarrow \mathcal{BRC}$ such that*

$$\mathbf{f}(P) = \begin{cases} P & \text{if } P \text{ is reduced} \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

induces a surjective homomorphism of rings

$$\mathbf{f} : (\text{BPIPE}, \boxplus) \rightarrow (\mathcal{BRC}, \boxplus).$$

- *Let G_w^n for $w \in S_\infty$ be the basis of $\mathcal{D}$ dual to the basis of Grothendieck polynomials (with the n representing the max number of variables). Then the map $\text{BPIPE} \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$ defined on the n -row pipe dream $P \in \text{Pipe}(w, n)$ for $w \in S_\infty$ by*

$$P \mapsto G_w^n$$

extends to a surjective homomorphism of rings.

In effect this would generalize Little's bumping algorithm to the 0-Hecke words of permutations that come from pipe dreams representing the monomials of Grothendieck polynomials, yielding word-level combinatorial transition algorithm.

Outline of the paper. Sections 2 and 3 establish the algebraic foundations: §2 (The Schubert Bialgebra and its dual) constructs $\mathcal{A}$, identifies its Schubert basis $\mathfrak{S}_u^n$, and exhibits the elementary basis $\mathcal{E}_n$ of $\mathcal{A}_n$; §3 (The dual algebra) builds the graded dual $\mathcal{D}$, identifies the dual Schubert basis Ξ_u^n , and records the coproduct.

Section 4 (The ring of bounded RC graphs) defines the module $\mathcal{BRC}$ of bounded RC graphs, the row-decomposition maps $\mathcal{Z}$, clip^p , trim^p , and the associative product $\boxplus$ on $\mathcal{BRC}$; this culminates in Theorem 1.1, the Littlewood–Richardson rule for the dual Schubert basis.

Sections 5–7 produce three further LR rules by quotienting $\mathcal{BRC}$ by successively coarser equivalence relations. Section 5 (The ring of RC graph crystals) imports the Demazure crystal structure on RC graphs from [1] and identifies an ideal $\Theta \subset \mathcal{BRC}$ whose quotient yields Theorem 5.4, the LR rule for the dual key basis. Section 6 (The ring of forest classes of RC graphs) does the analogous construction for the forest invariant of [26], producing an ideal $\Gamma \subset \mathcal{BRC}$ whose quotient yields Theorem 6.4, the LR rule for the dual forest basis, and interprets it as a branching rule on the quasisymmetric flag variety. Section 7 (Product rule for dual slide polynomials) introduces the quasi-Yamanouchi map $\mathbb{QY}$ and the corresponding ideal $\Sigma \subset \mathcal{BRC}$, yielding Theorem 7.2, a positive product rule for the dual slide basis; the section closes with Theorem 7.3, a general ideal-quotient Littlewood–Richardson template that unifies all four rules under a single set of axioms on an equivalence relation $\sim$ on $\mathcal{BRC}$.

The appendix is devoted to the proof of Proposition 2.1.6, which would otherwise be distracting.

2. THE SCHUBERT BIALGEBRA AND ITS DUAL

2.1. Some preliminaries.

Definition 2.1.1 (Two Pieri relations $\xrightarrow{k}$ and $\xRightarrow{k}$). The relations $\xrightarrow{k}$ and $\xRightarrow{k}$ are defined on S_∞ as follows, with different notation, in [35]. For $v, w \in S_\infty$, we have $v \xrightarrow{k} w$ if there is a sequence of transpositions $t_{a_1 b_1}, \dots, t_{a_m b_m}$ such that the following hold:

- (1) $a_i \leq k < b_i$ for all i .
- (2) $\ell(ut_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_m b_m}) = \ell(u) + i$ for all i .
- (3) $w = ut_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_m b_m}$.
- (4) The integers $a_1, \dots, a_m$ are pairwise distinct.

For $\xRightarrow{k}$, only (4) changes:

- (4') The integers $b_1, \dots, b_m$ are pairwise distinct.

Notice that necessarily $m \leq k$ for $\xrightarrow{k}$, but there is no upper bound on m for $\xRightarrow{k}$. This reflects the fact that the following theorem holds:

Theorem 2.1 ([35, Theorem 1]). *Let $p \geq 0$, $k > 0$ be integers and let u be a permutation.*

I. *We have the formula*

$$\mathfrak{S}_u(x) h_{p,k}(x) = \sum_{\substack{u \xRightarrow{k} w \\ \ell(u,w)=p}} \mathfrak{S}_w(x)$$

where $h_{p,k}(x)$ is the complete homogeneous symmetric polynomial of degree p in the first k variables.

II. *We have the formula*

$$\mathfrak{S}_u(x) e_{p,k}(x) = \sum_{\substack{u \xrightarrow{k} w \\ \ell(u,w)=p}} \mathfrak{S}_w(x)$$

where $e_{p,k}(x)$ is the elementary symmetric polynomial of degree p in the first k variables.

Definition 2.1.2 (Divided differences and skew divided differences). For $i \geq 1$ let s_i act on polynomials in x by exchanging x_i and x_{i+1} , and define the divided difference operator

$$\partial^i = \frac{1}{x_i - x_{i+1}} (1 - s_i).$$

The ∂^i satisfy the nil-Coxeter relations, so for $w \in S_\infty$ with reduced word $w = s_{i_1} \cdots s_{i_k}$ the operator $\partial^w = \partial^{i_1} \cdots \partial^{i_k}$ is well defined. We write δ^i and δ^w for the same operators acting on the y variables of a double Schubert polynomial, so $\delta^i = \frac{1}{y_i - y_{i+1}} (1 - s_i)$ with s_i now exchanging y_i and y_{i+1} . On double Schubert polynomials,

$$\partial^i \mathfrak{S}_w(x; y) = \begin{cases} \mathfrak{S}_{ws_i}(x; y) & \text{if } \ell(ws_i) < \ell(w), \\ 0 & \text{otherwise,} \end{cases} \quad \delta^i \mathfrak{S}_w(x; y) = \begin{cases} -\mathfrak{S}_{s_i w}(x; y) & \text{if } \ell(s_i w) < \ell(w), \\ 0 & \text{otherwise,} \end{cases}$$

so that $\delta^v \mathfrak{S}_w(x; y) = (-1)^{\ell(v)} \mathfrak{S}_{vw}(x; y)$ whenever $\ell(vw) = \ell(w) - \ell(v)$. Since each δ^i changes sign under the substitution $y \mapsto -y$, the signs cancel on $\mathfrak{S}_w(x; -y)$:

$$\delta^v [\mathfrak{S}_w(x; -y)] = \mathfrak{S}_{vw}(x; -y) \quad \text{whenever } \ell(vw) = \ell(w) - \ell(v).$$

The *skew divided difference operators* δ_u^w for $u \leq w$ in Bruhat order were defined originally in [21]; we use the conventions of [32], in which they are characterized by the Leibniz formula

$$\delta^w(pq) = \sum_{u \leq w} \delta^u(p) \delta_u^w(q)$$

for arbitrary polynomials p and q , together with its iterated form $\delta_u^w(pq) = \sum_{u \leq v \leq w} \delta_u^v(p) \delta_v^w(q)$. The operators ∂_u^w on the x variables are defined identically.

Definition 2.1.3 (Lehmer code, dual code, dominant permutations). For a permutation $w \in S_\infty$, the (*right*) *Lehmer code* of w is the sequence $\mathbf{c}(w) = (c_1, c_2, \dots)$ defined by

$$c_i = \#\{j > i : w(j) < w(i)\}.$$

This is a weak composition with $\sum_i c_i = \ell(w)$, and the map $w \mapsto \mathbf{c}(w)$ is a bijection from S_∞ onto the set of weak compositions of finite support. We will sometimes write $\mathbf{c}_i(w) := c_i$. The *dual code* of w is

$$\mathbf{c}^*(w) := \mathbf{c}(w^{-1}).$$

A permutation $\mu \in S_\infty$ is called *dominant* if $\mathbf{c}(\mu)$ is a partition (a weakly decreasing sequence of nonnegative integers, padded by 0s). For a partition λ , we write $\mathfrak{d}_\lambda$ for the dominant permutation with

$$\mathbf{c}^*(\mathfrak{d}_\lambda) = \lambda.$$

Definition 2.1.4 (Pulling out variables from double Schubert polynomials, the relation $\searrow^i$). For a permutation v' such that $v' \in S_n$, define

$$\varphi_{i,n}(v')(j) = \begin{cases} v'(j) & \text{if } j < i \\ n+1 & \text{if } j = i \\ v'(j-1) & \text{if } i < j \leq n+1 \\ j & \text{if } j > n+1 \end{cases}$$

Now fix $v \in S_n$ and $i \geq 1$ an integer, we define a relation $\searrow^i$ by declaring that $v \searrow^i v'$ if

$$v \xRightarrow{i} \varphi_{i,n}(v')$$

Equivalently, $v \searrow^i v'$ if whenever $v \in S_n$ and n is minimal, we have that v satisfies the relation $\xRightarrow{i}$ with respect to the permutation obtained from v' by inserting $n+1$ at position i . We note that this concept was introduced by Bergeron and Sottile in [6].

If $v \searrow^i v'$, we define a set of integers $Q_i(v', v)$ by

$$Q_i(v', v) = \{v(j) \mid j > i \text{ and } v'(j-1) = v(j)\}$$

Given the fact that any element of S_∞ fixes all but finitely many positive integers, it follows that $Q_i(v', v)$ is a finite set.

The permutations v' such that $v \searrow^i v'$ arise when pulling a variable out of a Schubert polynomial and expressing the coefficients of the powers of this variable as Schubert polynomials in the remaining variables, as is done in [5], from which this definition essentially comes.

Definition 2.1.5 (Upward shifting of permutations, maximum right descent). For a permutation $v \in S_\infty$, we define $\uparrow v$ to be the permutation defined by

$$\uparrow v(i) = \begin{cases} v(i-1) + 1 & \text{if } i > 1 \\ 1 & \text{if } i = 1 \end{cases}$$

Recursively, we define $\uparrow^k(v)$ to be $\uparrow(\uparrow^{k-1}(v))$. In the literature, this is sometimes written as

$$\uparrow^k v = 1^k \times v$$

For a permutation w , we define $\mathbf{m}(w)$ to be the maximum right descent of w . That is

$$\mathbf{m}(w) = \max\{i \mid w(i) > w(i+1)\}$$

The next proposition specializes, in the case of ordinary Schubert polynomial $\mathfrak{S}_v(x)$, to a formula that isolates a chosen index i : one can express $\mathfrak{S}_v(x)$ as a sum of terms of the form $x_i^p \mathfrak{S}_{v'}(x^{(i)})$, thereby effectively extracting the variable x_i and leaving Schubert polynomials in the remaining variables [6, Theorem 5.1]. Proposition 2.1.6 is the double Schubert polynomial version of this, which, as far as we know, is new.

Proposition 2.1.6. *Let $v \in S_\infty$ and let $i > 0$ be an integer. Then we have*

$$\mathfrak{S}_v(x; y) = \sum_{\substack{i \\ v \searrow v'}} \mathfrak{S}_{v'}(x^{(i)}; y) \prod_{b \in Q_i(v', v)} (x_i - y_b)$$

See the Appendix for a proof.

2.2. Definition. We define a commutative algebra $\mathcal{A}$ over the integers as follows. For each $n \geq 0$, define $\mathcal{A}_n$ to be the polynomial ring over $\mathbb{Z}$ in the variables $x_1, \dots, x_n$ (so $\mathcal{A}_0 = \mathbb{Z}$). Then define

$$\mathcal{A} = \bigoplus_{n=0}^{\infty} \mathcal{A}_n$$

The multiplication within each $\mathcal{A}_n$ is the usual multiplication of polynomials, and if $a \in \mathcal{A}_m$ and $b \in \mathcal{A}_n$ with $m \neq n$, then

$$ab = 0.$$

That is, $\mathcal{A}$ is the direct sum of the rings $\mathcal{A}_n$, including $\mathcal{A}_0$; it is a commutative ring without unit, and the constant polynomial $1 \in \mathcal{A}_n$ is a unit for the summand $\mathcal{A}_n$ only. The $\mathbb{Z}$ -module structure is the evident one.

Remark (Fat identities). The constant polynomial $1 \in \mathcal{A}_n$ acts as a unit on $\mathcal{A}_n$ itself but is *not* a unit of $\mathcal{A}$ as a whole: by the rule above it annihilates every $\mathcal{A}_m$ with $m \neq n$. We will refer to these length- n units informally as “fat identities”; $\mathcal{A}$ itself has no unit. This is the conceptual hinge that makes $\mathcal{A}$ a bialgebra rather than a Hopf algebra. The triviality of cross-length products is what allows the deconcatenation coproduct Δ defined below to be a homomorphism of rings (if $1 \in \mathcal{A}_0$ acted as a global unit, Δ would fail to be multiplicative already on $x_1 \cdot x_1 x_2 = 0$); conversely, it forces $\mathcal{A}$ to fail to be connected, so $\mathcal{A}$ admits no antipode.

Each $\mathcal{A}_n$ has a basis consisting of elements x_a , where a is a weak composition of length n , and the notation indicates that

$$x_a = x_1^{a_1} \cdots x_n^{a_n}$$

The direct sum therefore has a basis that can canonically be identified with the union of these.

We define a coproduct $\Delta : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathcal{A} \otimes \mathcal{A}$ on the basis element x_c by

$$\Delta(x_c) = \sum_{ab=c} x_a \otimes x_b$$

where the equation $ab = c$ indicates that a concatenated with b is equal to c . We also define a counit $\varepsilon : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$ by $\varepsilon(x_a) = 0$ unless a is the empty composition.

Lemma 2.2.1. *With Δ and ε , $\mathcal{A}$ is a coassociative, counital coalgebra.*

Proof. We have

$$\Delta(x_d^n) = \sum x_a^p \otimes x_c^q$$

Applying Δ to either tensor factor results in

$$\sum x_a^p \otimes x_b^q \otimes x_c^r$$

The symmetry of this is exactly the coassociativity condition. Seeing that we may choose $p = n$ or $q = n$, the definition of the counit gives us the result that $\mathcal{A}$ is counital as well under Δ and ε . $\square$

Lemma 2.2.2. *$\Delta : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathcal{A} \otimes \mathcal{A}$ is a homomorphism of rings.*

Proof. Let a, b be weak compositions of lengths m and n , and for a weak composition c of length r and $0 \leq k \leq r$ write $c_{\leq k}$ and $c_{> k}$ for the first k and the remaining $r - k$ entries of c . Then

$$\Delta(x_a) \Delta(x_b) = \sum_{j=0}^m \sum_{k=0}^n x_{a_{\leq j}} x_{b_{\leq k}} \otimes x_{a_{> j}} x_{b_{> k}}.$$

The (j, k) term vanishes unless $j = k$ and $m - j = n - k$, that is, unless $m = n$ and $j = k$. Hence $\Delta(x_a)\Delta(x_b) = 0 = \Delta(x_ax_b)$ when $m \neq n$, while for $m = n$

$$\Delta(x_a)\Delta(x_b) = \sum_{k=0}^n x_{a \leq k + b \leq k} \otimes x_{a > k + b > k} = \sum_{k=0}^n x_{(a+b) \leq k} \otimes x_{(a+b) > k} = \Delta(x_{a+b}) = \Delta(x_ax_b).$$

□

Lemma 2.2.3. $\nabla : \mathcal{A} \otimes \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathcal{A}$ is a homomorphism of coalgebras.

Proof. Consider the basis element $x_a \otimes x_b$ of $\mathcal{A} \otimes \mathcal{A}$. The product is

$$x_{a+b}$$

Applying Δ results in

$$\sum_{a'b'=a+b} x_{a'} \otimes x_{b'}$$

Conversely, applying $\Delta \otimes \Delta$ yields

$$\sum_{a_1 a_2 = a, b_1 b_2 = b} x_{a_1} \otimes x_{a_2} \otimes x_{b_1} \otimes x_{b_2}$$

and applying $\nabla \otimes \nabla$ yields

$$\sum x_{a_1+b_1} \otimes x_{a_2+b_2}$$

The definition of ∇ ensures that a_1 and b_1 are the same length for a nonzero term, and similarly for a_2 and b_2 . Setting $a_1 + b_1 = a'$, $a_2 + b_2 = b'$ yields the result. □

Corollary 2.2.4. $\mathcal{A}$ is a bialgebra over $\mathbb{Z}$.

$\mathcal{A}$ is afforded a grading into finite-rank components by observing that each $\mathcal{A}_n$ itself is a graded ring with each homogeneous component being a finitely generated free module. Considering the pair (n, d) , where n is the number of variables and d is the degree, as a $\mathbb{Z}^2$ grading, we may take the graded dual module $\mathcal{D}$, which, by virtue of the grading, is isomorphic as a free module to $\mathcal{A}$. We identify the dual basis element x_a^* with the sequence of nonnegative integers a . That is,

$$\langle a, x_b \rangle = \delta_{ab}.$$

Inspection of the coproduct reveals that the product of a and b in $\mathcal{D}$ is simply the concatenation ab . Hence $\mathcal{D}$ is isomorphic to the free associative algebra on a countable set indexed by nonnegative integers.

$\mathcal{D}$ also has a coproduct compatible with its product, namely

$$c \mapsto \sum_{a+b=c} a \otimes b$$

Thus $\mathcal{A}$ and $\mathcal{D}$ are dual bialgebras.

Calling $\mathcal{A}$ the “Schubert bialgebra” may seem unnecessarily grandiose; however, the reason will become clear below.

2.3. The Schubert basis. In $\mathcal{A}$, each $\mathcal{A}_n$ has a basis of Schubert polynomials $\mathfrak{S}_u^n$, where the largest right descent of u is at most n , ensuring that $\mathfrak{S}_u(x)$ has at most n variables. Schubert polynomials limited to a specific number of variables have well-defined structure constants $c_{u,v}^w$, independent of n , given by

$$\mathfrak{S}_u^n \mathfrak{S}_v^n = \sum_w c_{u,v}^w \mathfrak{S}_w^n$$

These are known to be nonnegative integers by virtue of the fact that they count points of transverse intersections of generic translates of Schubert varieties; however, except in special cases no positive combinatorial formula is known.

2.4. The elementary basis. An n -elementary weak composition is a finite sequence of nonnegative integers $\alpha = (\alpha_1, \alpha_2, \dots, \alpha_N)$ such that $\alpha_i \leq i$ for all $i < n$ and $\alpha_i \leq n$ for all $i \geq n$, satisfying the additional restriction that $\alpha_i \geq \alpha_{i+1}$ if $i \geq n$.

An n -elementary monomial is an element of $\mathcal{A}_n$ of the following form:

$$e_{\alpha_1}^1 \cdots e_{\alpha_n}^n e_{\alpha_{n+1}}^n \cdots e_{\alpha_m}^n$$

where α is an n -elementary weak composition. Define $\mathcal{E}_n$ to be the set of n -elementary monomials.

Proposition 2.4.1. $\mathcal{E}_n$ forms a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis for $\mathcal{A}_n$, and $\bigcup_n \mathcal{E}_n$ forms a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis for $\mathcal{A}$.

Proof. It is a theorem of Macdonald that the polynomial ring $\mathbb{Z}[x_1, \dots, x_n]$ is a free module over Λ_n with basis the Schubert polynomials $\mathfrak{S}_u(x)$ such that $u \in S_n$. These Schubert polynomials are uniquely expressed in terms of strict elementary symmetric monomials with fewer than n variables. Since Λ_n is a polynomial ring in the $e_{i,n}$ by the standard characterization of Λ_n as a polynomial ring in $e_1, \dots, e_n$, Λ_n has a basis of monomials e_λ^n as λ ranges over all partitions with parts bounded by n . The multiplicative combination of these two bases is therefore a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of $\mathcal{A}_n$ by freeness of the module. This is exactly the description of the monomials e_α^n for α an n -elementary weak composition. $\square$

We can ask for transition formulas between the Schubert and the elementary basis. From elementary to Schubert, we may use Sottile's Pieri formula iteratively [35], which provides a positive formula for multiplying a Schubert polynomial by an elementary symmetric polynomial. That is,

$$e_\alpha^n = \sum_{1 \xrightarrow{1,2,\dots,n} \alpha u} \mathfrak{S}_u^n$$

For the reverse transition, we need a lemma on the skew divided difference operators δ_u^w of Definition 2.1.2. Recall that $\delta^i = \frac{1}{y_i - y_{i+1}}(1 - s_i)$ acts on the y variables, that $\delta^w = \delta^{i_1} \cdots \delta^{i_k}$ for a reduced word $w = s_{i_1} \cdots s_{i_k}$, and that the skew operators are characterized by the Leibniz formula $\delta^w(pq) = \sum_{u \leq w} \delta^u(p) \delta_u^w(q)$. The lemma computes the application of a skew divided difference operator of degree $-n$ to a polynomial of degree n , which yields an integer for integer-coefficient polynomials. Specifically, it is a formula for application of such an operator with $\ell(u, w) = n$ to y_p^n for some $p > 0$.

Definition 2.4.2. For $u, w \in S_\infty$ such that $u \leq w$, we define $\mathcal{C}^{(p)}(u, w)$ to be the set of saturated chains C in the Bruhat interval $[u, w]$ of the form

$$u = u_0 \prec u_1 \prec \cdots \prec u_n = w$$

such that $u_{i-1}(p) \neq u_i(p)$ for all i . We also define $\sigma(C)$ to be the number of indices i for which the index $j \neq p$ such that $u_{i-1}(j) \neq u_i(j)$ satisfies $j < p$.

Lemma 2.4.3. Let $n \geq 0$ be an integer, let $p > 0$ be an integer, and let $u, w \in S_\infty$ be permutations such that $\ell(u, w) = n$. Then we have that

$$\delta_u^w(y_p^n) = \sum_{C \in \mathcal{C}^{(p)}(u, w)} (-1)^{\sigma(C)}.$$

Proof. Consider the case where $\ell(u, w) = 1$. Then there is a transposition t_{ij} such that $w = ut_{ij}$. Assume that $i < j$. If $p \notin \{i, j\}$, then $\delta_u^w(y_p) = 0$. If $p = i$, then $\delta_u^w(y_p) = \delta^{ij}(y_p) = 1$. If instead $j = p$, then $\delta_u^w(y_p) = \delta^{ij}(y_p) = -1$. In all cases, the result holds.

Now, consider the case where $\ell(u, w) = n > 1$. We have that

$$y_p^n = y_p \cdot y_p^{n-1}$$

Applying the Leibniz formula, we have

$$\delta_u^w(y_p^n) = \sum_{u \prec u'} \delta_{u'}^{u'}(y_p) \delta_{u'}^w(y_p^{n-1})$$

By the above, $\delta_{u'}^{u'}(y_p)$ is nonzero if and only if $u \prec u'$ is a cover in the Bruhat order such that $u(p) \neq u'(p)$. In this case, $\delta_{u'}^{u'}(y_p)$ is either 1 or -1 depending on the number of indices $j < p$ such that $u(j) \neq u'(j)$, which

is either 0 or 1, respectively. By induction,

$$\delta_{u'}^w(y_p^{n-1}) = \sum_{C' \in \mathcal{C}^{(p)}(u', w)} (-1)^{\sigma(C')}.$$

Hence,

$$\delta_u^{u'}(y_p) \delta_{u'}^w(y_p^{n-1}) = \begin{cases} - \sum_{C' \in \mathcal{C}^{(p)}(u', w)} (-1)^{\sigma(C')} & \text{if } u(j) \neq u'(j) \text{ for some } j < p \\ \sum_{C' \in \mathcal{C}^{(p)}(u', w)} (-1)^{\sigma(C')} & \text{otherwise,} \end{cases}$$

which, by definition, is

$$\sum_{C = C' \cup \{u\}, C' \in \mathcal{C}^{(p)}(u', w)} (-1)^{\sigma(C)}$$

Summing over all u' such that $u \prec u' \leq w$, we obtain the result. $\square$

Using a minor sleight of hand, this affords us an explicit formula for transition of a Schubert polynomial into the elementary basis. We first name the combinatorial data that will index the terms of the formula.

Definition 2.4.4. For $k, p > 0$ let

$$E_k(x; y_p) = \prod_{i=1}^k (x_i - y_p),$$

which is a factorial elementary symmetric polynomial, a special case of a double Schubert polynomial.

Lemma 2.4.5. Let $u, w \in S_\infty$ satisfy $u \leq w$ and let $p > 0, k > 0$ be integers. Then we have

$$\delta_u^w(E_k(x; -y_p)) = \sum_{C \in \mathcal{C}^{(p)}(u, w)} (-1)^{\sigma(C)} e_{k-\ell(u, w)}^k + \mathcal{O}(y_p)$$

Proof. This follows from the observation that

$$E_k(x; -y_p) = \sum_{i=0}^k e_{k-i}^k y_p^i$$

and Lemma 2.4.3. $\square$

Definition 2.4.6. Fix $w \in S_\infty$ with $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq n$. Let

$$\lambda = (n, n, \dots, n, n-1, \dots, 1)$$

be the partition with parts $n-1, n-2, \dots, 1$ preceded by some number of parts equal to n , chosen large enough that $\ell(w\lambda^{-1}) = |\lambda| - \ell(w)$, where w_λ is the dominant permutation with $\mathbf{c}^*(w_\lambda) = \lambda$. Write $N = \ell(\lambda)$.

A *path* for w is a sequence $P = (C_1, \dots, C_N)$ of chains $C_i \in \mathcal{C}^{(i)}(u_{i-1}, u_i)$ for some sequence of permutations $1 = u_0 \leq u_1 \leq \dots \leq u_N = w\lambda^{-1}$; denote the set of such paths by $\text{Path}_\lambda(w)$. For $P \in \text{Path}_\lambda(w)$ set

$$\sigma(P) = \sum_{i=1}^N \sigma(C_i), \quad \alpha(P) = (\lambda_{N+1-i} - |C_{N+1-i}|)_{i=1}^N,$$

so that $\alpha(P)$ is an n -elementary weak composition. Finally, for each weak composition α define

$$E_w^{\alpha; n} = \sum_{\substack{P \in \text{Path}_\lambda(w) \\ \alpha(P) = \alpha}} (-1)^{\sigma(P)}.$$

Theorem 2.2 (Transition to the elementary basis). *For each w with $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq n$, we have*

$$\mathfrak{S}_w^n = \sum_{\alpha} E_w^{\alpha; n} e_{\alpha}^n.$$

In particular, since $\mathcal{E}_n$ is a basis of $\mathcal{A}_n$, the integers $E_w^{\alpha; n}$ do not depend on the number of parts equal to n in λ (identifying α with its extensions by trailing zeros).

Proof. Let λ , w_λ , and N be as in Definition 2.4.6. By [21, (6.14)], the double Schubert polynomial of the dominant permutation w_λ factors as

$$\mathfrak{S}_{w_\lambda}(x; -y) = \prod_{i=1}^N E_{\lambda_i}(x; -y_i).$$

Recall from Definition 2.1.2 that δ^v acts on the y variables with $\delta^v \mathfrak{S}_w(x; y) = (-1)^{\ell(v)} \mathfrak{S}_{vw}(x; y)$ whenever $\ell(vw) = \ell(w) - \ell(v)$, and that the sign disappears on $\mathfrak{S}_w(x; -y)$ because each δ^i is odd under $y \mapsto -y$: $\delta^v[\mathfrak{S}_w(x; -y)] = \mathfrak{S}_{vw}(x; -y)$. By the choice of λ , this gives

$$\mathfrak{S}_w(x; -y) = \delta^{ww_\lambda^{-1}} \prod_{i=1}^N E_{\lambda_i}(x; -y_i),$$

with $\delta^{ww_\lambda^{-1}}$ acting on the variables y_i appearing in the product. Expand the right-hand side using the Leibniz formula iterated across the N factors: the result is a sum over sequences $1 = u_0 \leq u_1 \leq \dots \leq u_N = ww_\lambda^{-1}$ of the products $\prod_i \delta_{u_{i-1}}^{u_i} E_{\lambda_i}(x; -y_i)$. Setting $y_i = 0$ for all i and invoking Lemma 2.4.5 for each factor, this becomes

$$\mathfrak{S}_w(x) = \sum_{P=(C_1, \dots, C_N)} (-1)^{\sigma(C_1) + \dots + \sigma(C_N)} e_{\lambda_1 - |C_1|}^{\lambda_1} e_{\lambda_2 - |C_2|}^{\lambda_2} \dots e_{\lambda_N - |C_N|}^{\lambda_N},$$

the sum running over $P \in \text{Path}_\lambda(w)$. The monomial in the P -th term is $e_{\alpha(P)}^n$, and collecting terms by $\alpha(P)$ gives the stated expansion with coefficients $E_w^{\alpha; n}$. $\square$

These numbers are stable for fixed w as soon as the number of variables is at least as large as the value of n such that $w \in S_n$, and are well-studied but poorly understood.

Example 2.4.7. Let $n = 5$ and let w be the permutation such that $\mathbf{c}(w) = (0, 2, 0, 2, 3)$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathfrak{S}_w^n = & e_{(0,0,0,0,5,1,1)}^5 - e_{(0,0,0,0,4,2,1)}^5 + e_{(0,0,0,0,4,3)}^5 - e_{(0,1,0,0,4,1,1)}^5 + e_{(0,1,0,0,3,2,1)}^5 \\ & + e_{(0,1,0,0,5,1)}^5 - e_{(0,1,0,0,3,3)}^5 \end{aligned}$$

Remark. This transition formula from the Schubert basis to the elementary basis can be used to obtain an extremely efficient formula for multiplication of Schubert polynomials. If we want to compute $\mathfrak{S}_u^n \mathfrak{S}_v^n$, we can first express $\mathfrak{S}_v^n$ in the elementary basis using Theorem 2.2. Then we can multiply by $\mathfrak{S}_u^n$ by iterating the Pieri formula. This is the method used in the python package `schubmult` written by the author [34]. In fact, there is also a version for double Schubert polynomials, quantum Schubert polynomials, and quantum double Schubert polynomials, which we will not go into here but are implemented in the same package.

3. THE DUAL ALGEBRA

We examine the graded dual algebra $\mathcal{D}$ more closely now. This is a graded ring generated by countably many elements that we denote by $[i]$, where i is a nonnegative integer. The product, as mentioned previously, is concatenation of sequences. Thus

$$[a_1 \dots a_p][b_1 \dots b_q] = [a_1 \dots a_p b_1 \dots b_q]$$

It is not hard to see that $\mathcal{D}$ is a free algebra on these generators. Thus the set of sequences $[a_1 \dots a_n]$ forms a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis for $\mathcal{D}$. We may realize this as the dual of $\mathcal{A}$ by declaring that

$$\langle [a_1 \dots a_n], x_1^{b_1} \dots x_n^{b_n} \rangle = \prod_i \delta_{a_i, b_i}$$

We have a $\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z}$ grading such that

$$\deg([a_1 \dots a_n]) = (n, -a_1 - a_2 - \dots - a_n)$$

The set of elements such that $\deg(a) = (n, -)$ is $\mathcal{D}_n$, dual as a graded module to $\mathcal{A}_n$.

3.1. The dual Schubert basis. There is a basis Ξ_u^n dual to the Schubert basis for $\mathcal{D}_n$. Specifically, with the unique pairing $\langle -, - \rangle : \mathcal{D} \times \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$ such that

$$\langle \alpha, x_\beta \rangle = \delta_{\alpha\beta}$$

we define Ξ_u^n to be the unique basis of $\mathcal{D}_n$ such that

$$\langle \Xi_u^n, \mathfrak{S}_v^n \rangle = \delta_{uv}$$

We characterize it with an explicit formula, in terms of the chains $\mathcal{C}^{(p)}(u, w)$ and the statistic σ of §2.4.

Definition 3.1.1. Let $u \in S_\infty$ with $\mathbf{m}(u) \leq n$. A *dual path* for (u, n) is a sequence $P = (C_1, \dots, C_n)$ of chains $C_i \in \mathcal{C}^{(i)}(u_{i-1}, u_i)$ for some sequence of permutations $1 = u_0 \leq u_1 \leq \dots \leq u_n = u$; write $\text{Path}^n(u)$ for the set of dual paths. For $P \in \text{Path}^n(u)$ set

$$\sigma(P) = \sum_{i=1}^n \sigma(C_i), \quad |P| = (|C_1|, \dots, |C_n|),$$

so that $|P|$ is a weak composition of length n with $||P|| = \ell(u)$.

Theorem 3.1. For each permutation u and integer n with $\mathbf{m}(u) \leq n$,

$$\Xi_u^n = \sum_{P \in \text{Path}^n(u)} (-1)^{\sigma(P)} [|P|].$$

That is, the coefficient of $[\alpha]$ in Ξ_u^n is the signed number of dual paths P for (u, n) with $|C_i| = \alpha_i$ for all i .

Proof. By definition, the coefficient of $[\alpha]$ in Ξ_u^n is the coefficient $c_{\alpha, u}$ of $\mathfrak{S}_u^n$ in the Schubert expansion of x_α . Since $\partial^u \mathfrak{S}_v = \delta_{u, v}$ for $\ell(v) = \ell(u)$ and ∂^u kills polynomials of degree less than $\ell(u)$ [21], we have $c_{\alpha, u} = \partial^u(x_\alpha)$ when $|\alpha| = \ell(u)$, and $c_{\alpha, u} = 0$ otherwise. Writing $x_\alpha = x_1^{\alpha_1} \cdots x_n^{\alpha_n}$ and applying the Leibniz formula of Definition 2.1.2 (in its x -variable form) iteratively across the n factors,

$$\partial^u(x_\alpha) = \sum_{1=u_0 \leq u_1 \leq \dots \leq u_n = u} \prod_{i=1}^n \partial_{u_{i-1}}^{u_i}(x_i^{\alpha_i}).$$

Each factor $\partial_{u_{i-1}}^{u_i}(x_i^{\alpha_i})$ is homogeneous of degree $\alpha_i - \ell(u_{i-1}, u_i)$ (zero if this is negative), and the degrees sum to $|\alpha| - \ell(u) = 0$, so a term is a nonzero constant only if $\ell(u_{i-1}, u_i) = \alpha_i$ for every i . For such terms Lemma 2.4.3, which holds verbatim for $\partial_u^w(x_p^k)$, gives $\partial_{u_{i-1}}^{u_i}(x_i^{\alpha_i}) = \sum_{C_i \in \mathcal{C}^{(i)}(u_{i-1}, u_i)} (-1)^{\sigma(C_i)}$. Multiplying out yields the sum over dual paths P with $|P| = \alpha$ of $(-1)^{\sigma(P)}$. $\square$

Remark. Theorem 3.1 can also be derived from the Cauchy formula $\mathfrak{S}_\mu(x; -y) = \sum_v \mathfrak{S}_v(x) \mathfrak{S}_{v\mu^{-1}}(y)$ for a dominant permutation μ with $\mathbf{c}(\mu)$ strictly decreasing and $\mathbf{c}_n(\mu) \geq \ell(u)$, $\mathbf{c}_{n+1}(\mu) = 0$, by expanding $\mathfrak{S}_{u\mu^{-1}}(y)$ in the products $\prod_i e_{\mathbf{c}_i(\mu) - \alpha_i}^{(\mu)}(y)$ exactly as in the proof of Theorem 2.2; the coefficients so obtained are independent of μ .

This is not stable for fixed u as n increases, and this is expected.

Example 3.1.2. Suppose $w = [1, 4, 5, 2, 3]$. Then

$$\Xi_w^3 = [022] - [013]$$

If we choose $[1, 3, 5, 7, 2, 4, 6]$ instead, we have

$$\Xi_{1357246}^4 = [0015] - [0033] - [0114] + [0123]$$

For $w = [4, 2, 7, 1, 3, 5, 6]$,

$$\Xi_{4271356}^3 = -[026] + [035] + [125] - [134] + [206] - [215] - [305] + [314]$$

Thus the product structure of $\mathcal{D}$ encodes splitting of the Schubert polynomial into two sets of variables. In particular,

Lemma 3.1.3. Let $a \geq 0$ be an integer and $w \in S_\infty$. Then we have

$$[a] \cdot \Xi_w^n = \sum_{\substack{w' \searrow w \\ \ell(w, w')=a}} \Xi_{w'}^{n+1}$$

Proof. This follows from Proposition 2.1.6 with $i = 1$. $\square$

More generally, the product of $\mathcal{D}$ is dual to splitting the variables of $\mathcal{A}$ into two consecutive blocks. For permutations w, u, v with $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq p + q$, $\mathbf{m}(u) \leq p$, $\mathbf{m}(v) \leq q$, define the *branching coefficients* $b_{u,v}^w(p, q)$ by

$$(3.1.1) \quad \mathfrak{S}_w(x_1, \dots, x_{p+q}) = \sum_{u,v} b_{u,v}^w(p, q) \mathfrak{S}_u(x_1, \dots, x_p) \mathfrak{S}_v(x_{p+1}, \dots, x_{p+q});$$

these are well defined since the products $\mathfrak{S}_u(x_1, \dots, x_p) \mathfrak{S}_v(x_{p+1}, \dots, x_{p+q})$ form a basis of $\mathbb{Z}[x_1, \dots, x_{p+q}]$.

Lemma 3.1.4. *With notation as above,*

$$\Xi_u^p \sqcup \Xi_v^q = \sum_w b_{u,v}^w(p, q) \Xi_w^{p+q}.$$

Proof. For $\alpha \in \mathcal{D}_p$, $\beta \in \mathcal{D}_q$ and $f \in \mathcal{A}_{p+q}$ we have $\langle \alpha \sqcup \beta, f \rangle = \langle \alpha \otimes \beta, \Delta_{p,q}(f) \rangle$, where $\Delta_{p,q} : \mathcal{A}_{p+q} \rightarrow \mathcal{A}_p \otimes \mathcal{A}_q$ is the component of Δ ; indeed both sides equal $\delta_{ab,c}$ on $\alpha = [a]$, $\beta = [b]$, $f = x_c$. Identifying $\mathcal{A}_p \otimes \mathcal{A}_q$ with polynomials in the two blocks of variables, $\Delta_{p,q}(f) = f(x_1, \dots, x_{p+q})$ read as a polynomial in $(x_1, \dots, x_p)$ and $(x_{p+1}, \dots, x_{p+q})$, so $\Delta_{p,q}(\mathfrak{S}_w^{p+q}) = \sum_{u,v} b_{u,v}^w(p, q) \mathfrak{S}_u^p \otimes \mathfrak{S}_v^q$ by (3.1.1). Hence the coefficient of Ξ_w^{p+q} in $\Xi_u^p \sqcup \Xi_v^q$ is

$$\langle \Xi_u^p \sqcup \Xi_v^q, \mathfrak{S}_w^{p+q} \rangle = \langle \Xi_u^p \otimes \Xi_v^q, \Delta_{p,q}(\mathfrak{S}_w^{p+q}) \rangle = b_{u,v}^w(p, q). \quad \square$$

3.2. The coproduct. Consider the coproduct dual to the product on $\mathcal{A}$. We will denote it by

$$\Delta^* : \mathcal{D} \rightarrow \mathcal{D} \otimes \mathcal{D},$$

and we recall that it is characterized by the pairing identity

$$\langle \Delta^*(\alpha), x \otimes y \rangle = \langle \alpha, xy \rangle$$

for all $\alpha \in \mathcal{D}$ and $x, y \in \mathcal{A}$. Since the product on $\mathcal{A}$ preserves the length grading (multiplication of polynomials within a fixed $\mathcal{A}_n$, zero across $\mathcal{A}_p \otimes \mathcal{A}_q$ for $p \neq q$ with $p, q > 0$), Δ^* sends $\mathcal{D}_n$ into $\mathcal{D}_n \otimes \mathcal{D}_n$ for each n .

The Schubert structure constants now reappear as the coefficients of Δ^* in the dual Schubert basis.

Theorem 3.2 (Schubert LR coefficients as dual Schubert coproduct). *Let $w \in S_\infty$ with $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq n$. Then in $\mathcal{D}_n \otimes \mathcal{D}_n$,*

$$\Delta^*(\Xi_w^n) = \sum_{u,v} c_{u,v}^w \Xi_u^n \otimes \Xi_v^n,$$

where $c_{u,v}^w$ are the Schubert structure constants $\mathfrak{S}_u^n \mathfrak{S}_v^n = \sum_w c_{u,v}^w \mathfrak{S}_w^n$, and the sum runs over pairs $u, v \in S_\infty$ with $\mathbf{m}(u), \mathbf{m}(v) \leq n$.

Proof. Expand $\Delta^*(\Xi_w^n) = \sum_{u,v} \lambda_{u,v} \Xi_u^n \otimes \Xi_v^n$ in the basis $\{\Xi_u^n \otimes \Xi_v^n\}$ of $\mathcal{D}_n \otimes \mathcal{D}_n$. Pairing with $\mathfrak{S}_u^n \otimes \mathfrak{S}_v^n$ and using the defining identity of Δ^* ,

$$\lambda_{u,v} = \langle \Delta^*(\Xi_w^n), \mathfrak{S}_u^n \otimes \mathfrak{S}_v^n \rangle = \langle \Xi_w^n, \mathfrak{S}_u^n \mathfrak{S}_v^n \rangle = \langle \Xi_w^n, \sum_z c_{u,v}^z \mathfrak{S}_z^n \rangle = c_{u,v}^w. \quad \square$$

Remark. In particular, the Schubert Littlewood–Richardson coefficients are the structure constants of the coproduct Δ^* on $\mathcal{D}$ in the dual Schubert basis. Thus the otherwise mysterious nonnegativity of $c_{u,v}^w$ has the bialgebra-theoretic content that Δ^* has nonnegative integer coefficients in the basis $\{\Xi_u^n\}$. The same argument applies verbatim to any basis of $\mathcal{A}$ with nonnegative structure constants, such as the forest polynomials of §6: the structure constants of Δ^* in the corresponding dual basis are the structure constants of the original basis.

Example 3.2.1. Take $w = 24135 \in S_5$ (so $\mathbf{m}(w) = 2$) and $n = 2$. Then in $\mathcal{D}_2 \otimes \mathcal{D}_2$,

$$\begin{aligned} \Delta^*(\Xi_{24135}^2) &= 1 \otimes \Xi_{2413}^2 + \Xi_{2413}^2 \otimes 1 \\ &\quad + \Xi_{132}^2 \otimes \Xi_{1423}^2 + \Xi_{1423}^2 \otimes \Xi_{132}^2 \\ &\quad + \Xi_{132}^2 \otimes \Xi_{231}^2 + \Xi_{231}^2 \otimes \Xi_{132}^2 \\ &\quad + \Xi_{21}^2 \otimes \Xi_{1423}^2 + \Xi_{1423}^2 \otimes \Xi_{21}^2. \end{aligned}$$

By Theorem 3.2, the coefficient of $\Xi_u^2 \otimes \Xi_v^2$ is the Schubert structure constant $c_{u,v}^{24135}$; for instance, $c_{132,1423}^{24135} = c_{21,1423}^{24135} = 1$, while $c_{u,v}^{24135} = 0$ for every pair (u, v) not appearing above.

4. THE RING OF BOUNDED RC GRAPHS

4.1. The module of bounded RC graphs.

Definition 4.1.1. Let $R \subseteq \mathbb{P} \times \mathbb{P}$ be a finite set. To each such set we associate an element w_R of S_∞ as follows. Given a pair (i, j) where $i, j > 0$ are integers, define $s(i, j) = s_{i+j-1}$. Totally order the grid such that $(i, j) < (a, b)$ if and only if $i < a$ or $i = a$ and $j > b$ (in other words, lexicographical order, except that the order on the second coordinate is reversed). By this ordering, index R as $r_1, r_2, \dots, r_m$ in increasing order. Then

$$w_R = s_{r_1} \cdots s_{r_m}$$

If $\ell(w_R) = m$, then we say that R is an *RC-graph*.

A *bounded RC-graph* is an RC-graph R together with a specified number of rows $n \geq \max\{i : (i, j) \in R \text{ for some } j\}$, with the added condition that $\mathbf{m}(w_R) \leq n$. The definition is as an ordered pair (R, n) , but it will be far more convenient to abuse notation and consider the number of rows a property of R itself. To denote the number of rows, we define the *height* of R to be $\mathbf{ht}(R) = n$. A bounded RC graph has an associated weight vector $\mathbf{wt}(R)$ where $\mathbf{wt}_i(R)$ is the number of elements in row i .

To a bounded RC graph R with $\mathbf{ht}(R) \geq 1$, we define the *trim* operation $\mathbf{trim}(R)$ to be the bounded RC graph with height $\mathbf{ht}(R) - 1$ and underlying set $\{(i - 1, j) : (i, j) \in R, i \geq 2\}$. We also define

$$\uparrow^m R = \{(i + m, j) : (i, j) \in R\}$$

Let $\mathcal{BRC}$ be the free abelian group spanned by all bounded RC graphs. If $\mathcal{BRC}_n$ is the subgroup spanned by all bounded RC graphs R with $\mathbf{ht}(R) = n$, then we have a grading

$$\mathcal{BRC} = \bigoplus_{n=0}^{\infty} \mathcal{BRC}_n$$

There is an evident evaluation map $\text{ev} : \mathcal{BRC} \rightarrow \mathcal{A}$ defined on basis elements as

$$\text{ev}(R) = x_{\mathbf{wt}(R)}$$

which is a surjective homomorphism of graded modules. There is also a map $\alpha : \mathcal{BRC} \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$ defined by

$$\alpha(R) = \Xi_{w_R}^{\mathbf{ht}(R)}$$

which is also a surjective homomorphism of graded modules. In addition, there is the weight map $\omega : \mathcal{BRC} \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$ defined by

$$\omega(R) = [\mathbf{wt}(R)]$$

which is similarly a surjective homomorphism of graded modules.

We can define elements $\mathcal{S}_w(n)$ as

$$\mathcal{S}_w(n) = \sum_{\substack{w_R = w \\ \mathbf{ht}(R) = n}} R$$

For a generating element $[a]$ of $\mathcal{D}$ and a bounded RC graph R , we define

$$[a] \cdot R = \sum_{\substack{\mathbf{trim}(R') = R \\ \mathbf{wt}_1(R') = a}} R'$$

which is an element of $\mathcal{BRC}$. By virtue of the fact that $\mathcal{D}$ is a free algebra generated by these elements, it is nearly a trivial observation that this is a left module action on $\mathcal{BRC}$. The consequences of this, however, are not at all trivial.

Lemma 4.1.2 ([3, Corollary 3.11]). *We have that the set $\{w' \mid w \stackrel{1}{\searrow} w'\}$ is equal to the set of permutations w' such that there exists a permutation $v = s_{a_1} \cdots s_{a_m}$ for some integers $a_1 > a_2 > \cdots > a_m \geq 1$ such that $w = v \uparrow w'$.*

Lemma 4.1.3. *Let v be a permutation. If $v \stackrel{1}{\searrow} v'$, let $a_1, \dots, a_k$ be the elements of $Q_1(v', v)$ in decreasing order. Then*

$$v = s_{a_1} \cdots s_{a_k} \uparrow v'$$

Proof. Suppose $v \in S_n$. We have by definition that there is a sequence of integers $b_1, \dots, b_p$, all distinct and greater than 1, such that

$$vt_{1,b_1} \cdots t_{1,b_p}(1) = n + 1$$

and

$$vt_{1,b_1} \cdots t_{1,b_p}(i + 1) = v'(i)$$

for all $i < n - 1$. This means that

$$vt_{1,b_1} \cdots t_{1,b_p} = s_n s_{n-1} \cdots s_1 \uparrow v'$$

This is because if $v'' = \uparrow v'$, then

$$v''(1) = 1$$

and

$$v''(i) = v(i - 1) + 1$$

The cycle $s_n \cdots s_1$ sends $1 \mapsto n + 1$ and $i \mapsto i - 1$ if $1 < i \leq n + 1$, hence

$$vt_{1,b_1} \cdots t_{1,b_p} = s_n s_{n-1} \cdots s_1 \uparrow v'$$

In particular,

$$v = s_n s_{n-1} \cdots s_1 \uparrow v' t_{1,b_p} \cdots t_{1,b_1}$$

This results in the factorization

$$v = s_n \cdots s_1 t_{1,v'(b_p-1)+1} \cdots t_{1,v'(b_1-1)+1} \uparrow v'$$

The value $v'(b_j - 1)$ necessarily decreases as j decreases, since applying the corresponding reflection in the reverse order strictly increases the length with each application. Consequently, multiplying $s_n \cdots s_1$ on the right by these reflections removes the simple reflections $s_{v'(b_p-1)}, \dots, s_{v'(b_1-1)}$. The indices removed are precisely the complement of the elements of $Q_1(v', v)$, hence the elements of $Q_1(v', v)$ in decreasing order are what remain, as desired. $\square$

Definition 4.1.4. For a set of positive integers $A = \{a_1, \dots, a_m\}$ with $a_1 > a_2 > \cdots > a_m \geq 1$ and a positive integer i , define

$$\text{row}_i(A) = \{(i, a_j) \mid a_j \in A\}$$

Theorem 4.1. Let $a \geq 0$ be an integer and let $R \in \mathcal{BRC}$. Then

$$[a] \cdot R = \sum_{\substack{w' \searrow^1 w_R \\ \ell(w_R, w') = a}} (\text{row}_1(Q_1(w_R, w')) \cup \uparrow R)$$

where the right side denotes bounded RC graphs with $\text{ht}(R) + 1$ rows.

Proof. If $\text{trim}(R') = R$, then by definition $w_{R'} = s_{a_1} \cdots s_{a_m} \uparrow w_R$. It follows by Lemma 4.1.2 then $w_{R'} \searrow^1 w_R$. By Lemma 4.1.3, the integers $a_1, \dots, a_m$ are precisely the elements of $Q_1(w_R, w_{R'})$ in decreasing order. This establishes the result. $\square$

Lemma 4.1.5. Let $a \geq 0$ be an integer and let $w \in S_\infty$. For any valid n , we have

$$[a] \cdot \mathcal{S}_w(n) = \sum_{\substack{w \searrow^1 w' \\ \ell(w, w') = a}} \mathcal{S}_{w'}(n + 1)$$

Proof. Theorem 4.1 establishes an explicit bijection between $[a] \cdot R$ and the set of bounded RC graphs R' such that $w_{R'} \searrow^1 w_R$ and $\ell(w_R, w_{R'}) = a$. The result follows by summing over all R such that $w_R = w$ and $\text{ht}(R) = n$. $\square$

Let t be an indeterminate commuting with all elements of $\mathcal{D}$. Write

$$\mathfrak{S}_{\mathcal{D}}(t) = \sum_{a=0}^{\infty} [a] t^a$$

Define

$$\mathfrak{S}_{\mathcal{D}}(x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n) = \mathfrak{S}_{\mathcal{D}}(x_1) \mathfrak{S}_{\mathcal{D}}(x_2) \cdots \mathfrak{S}_{\mathcal{D}}(x_n)$$

Theorem 4.2. *Let $\emptyset \in \mathcal{BRC}$ denote the empty bounded RC graph with $\text{ht}(\emptyset) = 0$. Then*

$$\mathfrak{S}_{\mathcal{D}}(x_1, \dots, x_n) \cdot \emptyset = \sum_{\substack{w \in S_{\infty} \\ \text{mw} \leq n}} \mathfrak{S}_w(x_1, \dots, x_n) \mathcal{S}_w(n)$$

Proof. The result for $n = 1$ is Lemma 4.1.5 together with Theorem 4.1. The general result follows by induction on n . Consider the inductive hypothesis

$$\mathfrak{S}_{\mathcal{D}}(x_2, \dots, x_n) \cdot \emptyset = \sum_{w \in S_{\infty}} \mathfrak{S}_w(x_2, \dots, x_n) \mathcal{S}_w(n-1)$$

Then applying $\mathfrak{S}_{\mathcal{D}}(x_1)$ to both sides, we have

$$\mathfrak{S}_{\mathcal{D}}(x_1) \mathfrak{S}_{\mathcal{D}}(x_2, \dots, x_n) \cdot \emptyset = \sum_{w \in S_{\infty}} \mathfrak{S}_w(x_2, \dots, x_n) \mathfrak{S}_{\mathcal{D}}(x_1) \mathcal{S}_w(n-1)$$

which is equal to

$$\sum_{a=0}^{\infty} \sum_{w \in S_{\infty}} x_1^a \mathfrak{S}_w(x_2, \dots, x_n)[a] \mathcal{S}_w(n-1)$$

Applying Lemma 3.1.3 to each term, we have

$$\sum_{a=0}^{\infty} \sum_{w \in S_{\infty}} x_1^a \mathfrak{S}_w(x_2, \dots, x_n) \sum_{\substack{w' \xrightarrow{1} w \\ \ell(w, w')=a}} \mathcal{S}_{w'}(n)$$

Bringing the polynomial inside the inner sum, this is

$$\sum_{w' \in S_{\infty}} \left(\sum_{w: w' \xrightarrow{1} w} x_1^{\ell(w, w')} \mathfrak{S}_w(x_2, \dots, x_n) \right) \mathcal{S}_{w'}(n)$$

which simplifies to

$$\sum_{w' \in S_{\infty}} \mathfrak{S}_{w'}(x_1, \dots, x_n) \mathcal{S}_{w'}(n)$$

as desired. □

Corollary 4.1.6. *For each $w \in S_{\infty}$ and valid n , we have*

$$\text{ev}(\mathcal{S}_w(n)) = \mathfrak{S}_w^n(x_1, \dots, x_n)$$

4.2. The pipe dream visualization and roots. Given a pair of positive integers i, j and an RC graph R , define

$$R[i, j] = \{(a, b) \in R \mid (a, b) > (i, j)\}$$

Given an RC graph R and a pair of positive integers i, j , we define an ordered pair

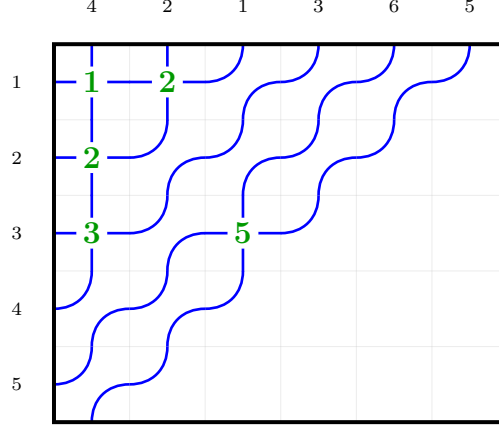
$$\mathbf{rt}_R(i, j) = (w_{R[i, j]}^{-1}(i + j - 1), w_{R[i, j]}^{-1}(i + j))$$

There is a common visualization of RC graphs as pipe dreams. In this visualization, we draw an infinite grid in the first quadrant, and in each position (i, j) we draw either a crossing (if $(i, j) \in R$) or an elbow (if $(i, j) \notin R$). Then we draw pipes entering from the left edge of the grid, with the pipe entering at row i labeled i . The pipes travel through the grid, turning at elbows and crossing at crossings, and exit at the top of the grid, which is labeled with the same number.

A modification to this common visualization that we use has the following additional features:

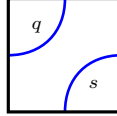
- We write the index of the simple reflections corresponding to the crossings in the grid area itself. Thus, at position (i, j) we write the number $i + j - 1$ if there is a crossing at that position.
- For a bounded RC graph R with $\text{ht}(R) = n$, we only draw the first n pipes entering from the left side of the grid and clip features outside of the first n rows. The pipes exiting at the top are still labeled since the width is not limited.
- *Note:* The labels at the top are not of the permutation w_R , but rather of the permutation w_R^{-1} .

FIGURE 1. The pipe dream visualization of the bounded RC graph R with $\text{ht}(R) = 5$ where $R = \{(1, 1), (1, 2), (2, 1), (3, 1), (3, 3)\}$



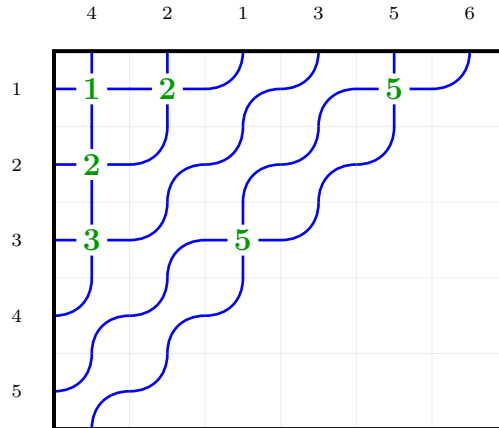
See Figure 1 for an example of this visualization.

The main benefit of this is that visualizing $\text{rt}_R(i, j)$ is easy. The pipes that pass through position (i, j) are labeled s and q for some $s, q > 0$. For a positive root in an unoccupied square, we will have the following labeling, where $q < s$:



We observe that in the above RC graph, the position $(1, 5)$ does not have this configuration. Placing a crossing there would create a negative root, and the pipes would cross twice. *Note that this results in a collection of ordered pairs that is not an RC graph, if such a crossing exists.* For a valid RC graphs, only positive roots occur as crossings, and this happens if and only if pipes cross at most once.

FIGURE 2. An invalid set of crossings causing pipes to cross more than once, caused by inserting a crossing at a negative root



4.3. Zeroing out the last row. We proceed now to define a product on $\mathcal{BRC}$ turning it into a ring. To do this, we need to be able to define a function $\mathcal{Z} : \mathcal{BRC} \rightarrow \mathcal{BRC}$ trimming empty rows from the bottom instead of from the top. This is far more complicated.

See Figure 3 for an example of the zeroing operation (Algorithm 3).

Algorithm 1 Basic monk insertion $i \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} R$

-
- 1: **Input:** An RC graph R , parameter k , and an integer i with $1 \leq i \leq k$.
 - 2: **Output:** A modified RC graph R' with $\text{wt}_j(R') = \text{wt}_j(R)$ for $j \neq i$ and $\text{wt}_i(R') = \text{wt}_i(R) + 1$ such that $w_R \xrightarrow{k} w_{R'}$.
 - 3: Find leftmost position $(i, j) \notin R$ in row i such that if $\text{rt}_R(i, j) = (a, b)$, then $a \leq k < b$.
 - 4: $R \leftarrow R \cup \{(i, j)\}$
 - 5: **if** there exists $(i', j') \in R$ with $\text{rt}_R(i', j') \in \Phi^-$ **then**
 - 6: $R \leftarrow R \setminus \{(i', j')\}$
 - 7: Return to step 3 substituting $i = i'$.
 - 8: **end if**
 - 9: **return** R
-

Algorithm 2 Pseudo-Pieri insertion $I \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} R$

-
- 1: **Input:** An RC graph R , parameter k , and sequence $I = \{i_1, \dots, i_m\}$ with $k \geq i_1 \geq i_2 \geq \dots \geq i_m \geq 1$.
 - 2: **Output:** A modified RC graph R' with $\text{wt}_i(R') = \text{wt}_i(R)$ for $i \notin I$ and $\text{wt}_i(R') = \text{wt}_i(R) + \#\{j \mid i_j = i\}$ for $i \in I$ such that $w_R \xrightarrow{k} w_{R'}$.
 - 3: **Initialize:** Let $L \leftarrow []$ (empty list of pairs (a, b) where $a \leq k < b$), and $U \leftarrow []$ (empty list of positions).
 - 4: **for** each $i \in (i_1, \dots, i_m)$ **do**
 - 5: Find leftmost position $(i, j) \notin R$ in row i satisfying $j > j'$ for all $(i, j') \in U$ such that either:
 - 6: a) $\text{rt}_R(i, j) = (s, q)$ where $s \leq k < q$ and $q \notin \{b \mid (a, b) \in L\}$.
 - 7: b) $\text{rt}_R(i, j) = (b_r, q)$ where $q > k$, $b_r < q$, and $q \notin \{b \mid (a, b) \in L\}$.
 - 8: $R \leftarrow R \cup \{(i, j)\}$ and $U \leftarrow U \cup \{(i, j)\}$
 - 9: Update L by adding (s, q) or replacing (a_r, b_r) with (a_r, q) and (a_r, b_r) .
 - 10: **if** there exists $(i', j') \in R$ with $\text{rt}_R(i', j') \in \Phi^-$ **then**
 - 11: $R \leftarrow R \setminus \{(i', j')\}$
 - 12: Let $\text{rt}_R(i', j') = (q, s)$
 - 13: **if** $(s, q) \in L$ **then**
 - 14: Remove (s, q) from L
 - 15: **else**
 - 16: Remove (a_r, q) from L , where $(a_r, q), (a_r, s) \in L$
 - 17: **end if**
 - 18: Return to step 5 to insert i' .
 - 19: **end if**
 - 20: **end for**
 - 21: **return** R
-

Note that Algorithm 2 is *not* a realization of Sottile's Pieri formula for complete symmetric polynomials, despite preserving the relevant Bruhat relation. This is because the map

$$\left(\binom{k}{p} \right) \times \mathcal{RC}(w) \rightarrow \mathcal{RC}(n)$$

given by

$$(I, R) \mapsto I \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} R$$

need not be injective.

Definition 4.3.1. Let R be an RC graph with $\text{ht}(R) = n$ such that row n is empty. We define $\mathcal{Z}(R)$ to be the output of Algorithm 3, an RC graph with $n - 1$ rows, on input R .

Lemma 4.3.2. Given an RC graph R , an integer k , and $k \geq i_1 \geq \dots \geq i_m \geq 1$, Algorithm 2 produces a valid RC graph R' satisfying

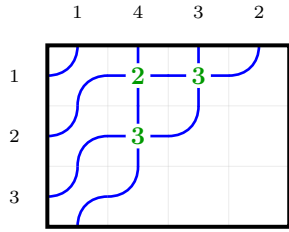
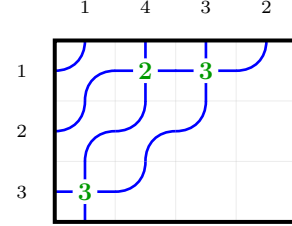
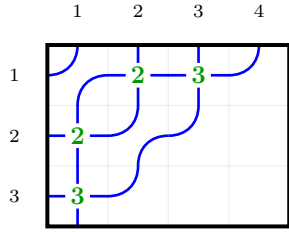
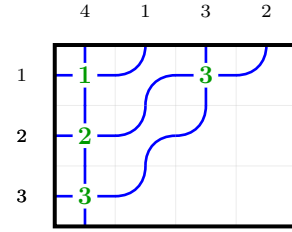
$$\text{wt}_i(R') = \text{wt}_i(R) + \#\{j \mid i_j = i\}$$

Algorithm 3 Map $\mathcal{Z}(R)$ zeroing out last row

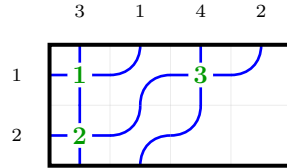
```

1: Input: A bounded RC graph  $R$  with  $\text{ht}(R) = n$  and row  $n$  empty.
2: Output: A bounded RC graph  $R'$  with  $\text{ht}(R') = n - 1$ ,  $|R'| = |R|$  (same number of crossings), and
    $w_R \xrightarrow{n} w_{R'}$ .
3: if  $R$  with last row removed is a valid bounded RC graph then
4:   return  $R$  with last row removed
5: else
6:   Let  $R_0 \leftarrow R$ .
7:   Find the maximal  $p$  and sequence  $\{(i_m, j_m)\}_{m=1}^p$  such that:
8:      $\text{rt}_{R_{m-1}}(i_m, j_m) = (n + m - 1, n + m)$  for each  $m$ , where  $R_m = R_{m-1} \setminus \{(i_m, j_m)\}$  for each  $m \geq 1$ .
9:      $R^- \leftarrow R \setminus \{(i_1, j_1), \dots, (i_p, j_p)\}$ .
10:    Let  $I \leftarrow (i_1, i_2, \dots, i_p)$ .
11:     $D \leftarrow R^- \cup \{(n, 1), (n, 2), \dots, (n, p)\}$ .
12:     $D' \leftarrow I \xrightarrow{n-1} D$ 
13:     $R' \leftarrow \{(i, j) \in D' \mid i < n\}$  as a bounded RC graph with  $n - 1$  rows.
14:   return  $R'$ .
15: end if

```

(a) Initial RC graph R (b) After deleting $(2, 2)$ with $\text{rt}_R(2, 2) = \alpha_3$ and moving to row 3(c) After insertion with $i_1 = 2$ 

(d) After rectification

(e) Final result $\mathcal{Z}(R) = (R', 2)$ after removing row 3FIGURE 3. Step-by-step computation of $\mathcal{Z}(R)$ for $R = \{(1, 2), (1, 3), (2, 2)\}$.

and

$$w_R \xrightarrow{k} w_{R'}$$

Proof. Set $R_0 = R$ to be the initial RC graph. We claim that given R and L at the start of iteration p of the main loop, we have that R is a valid RC graph satisfying

$$\mathbf{wt}_i(R) = \mathbf{wt}_i(R_0) + \#\{j \leq p-1 \mid i_j = i\}$$

and

$$w_R = w_{R_0} t_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_{p-1} b_{p-1}}$$

where $L = [(a_1, b_1), \dots, (a_p, b_p)]$. This is clear for $p = 1$. For larger p , suppose we are inserting at row i_p . If we are in case (a) of Step 5, then adding (i_p, j) to R adds the root $t_s - t_q$ to the inversion set of w_R , and multiplying by t_{sq} gives the desired result. If we are in case (b) of Step 5, then adding (i_p, j) to R results in multiplication by $t_{b_r q}$. This commutes past the other reflections to meet $t_{a_r b_r}$. We thus have the situation

$$t_{a_r b_r} t_{b_r q} = t_{a_r q} t_{a_r b_r}$$

This ensures that the product remains as desired if the RC graph is valid. However, the condition that the RC graph R be valid is not guaranteed after this step, so we must rectify. Suppose we must rectify at row $i-1$. We find a negative root $(i-1, j')$ which must have been created by the insertion, and hence by the strong exchange property equal to $\mathbf{rt}_R(i, j)$ that was inserted. Removing this root (from both the graph and from L) returns us to the original permutation at the beginning of the iteration, and performing the insert at row $i-1$ adds a new positive root, giving the desired result on the permutation. The weight is unchanged since we removed and added one crossing in row $i-1$. If the algorithm ends here, we have instead multiplied by the new reflection obtained in the ultimate insert step. Otherwise, repeating this process for all necessary rectifications completes the proof of the claim. The claim iterated to $p = m+1$ yields the desired result, and the method of updating L ensures that the b_j are all distinct, so that $w_R \xrightarrow{k} w_{R'}$. $\square$

Lemma 4.3.3. *Given a bounded RC graph R with $\mathbf{ht}(R) = n$ such that row n is empty, Algorithm 3 produces a valid bounded RC graph R' with $\mathbf{ht}(R') = n-1$ satisfying*

$$\mathbf{wt}(R') = \mathbf{wt}(R)$$

Proof. Stripping out the crossings at roots $(n, n+1), (n+1, n+2), \dots, (n+p-1, n+p)$ removes exactly one crossing from each of rows $i_1, i_2, \dots, i_p$, and moving them to the last row to obtain R_1 ensures that $w_R = w_{R_1}$. By construction, the portion of the RC graph in rows with index less than n is valid (meaning its max descent is at most $n-1$). Applying Algorithm 2 to insert at rows $i_1, i_2, \dots, i_p$ adds different crossings to preserve the number of elements in each row without adding descents past index n in the permutation, by Lemma 4.3.2. Removing row n then yields a valid bounded RC graph R' with $|R'| = n-1$ and the desired properties. $\square$

Theorem 4.3. *Let w be a permutation with last descent at most n . Let $\mathcal{RC}(w, n)^0$ be the set of bounded RC graphs R with $\mathbf{ht}(R) = n$ such that $w_R = w$ and row n is empty. Then*

$$\mathcal{Z} : \mathcal{RC}(w, n)^0 \rightarrow \bigcup_{\substack{w \xrightarrow{n} w' \\ \ell(w') = \ell(w)}} \mathcal{RC}(w', n-1)$$

is a weight-preserving bijection.

To prove Theorem 4.3 for $n = 2$, we may characterize the bounded RC graphs R with $|R| = 2$ such that row 2 is empty and $\mathbf{m}(w_R) = 2$ as those for permutations $w = s_k s_{k-1} \cdots s_2$ for some $k > 1$. Algorithm 3 in this case moves the entirety of the crossings in row 1 to row 2. The procedure then inserts $k-1$ crossings into row 1 in order from left to right, which must have roots $t_q - t_s$ such that $q = 1$. Thus R' is precisely $\{(1, 1), (1, 2), (1, 3), \dots, (1, k-1)\}$, which is the unique bounded RC graph for the permutation $w' = s_{k-1} s_{k-2} \cdots s_1$ with one row. This establishes the base case.

For the induction step, we require the following lemmas.

Lemma 4.3.4. *Let R be a bounded RC graph with $\text{ht}(R) = n \geq 2$ such that row n is empty. Then if $\mathcal{Z}(R) = R'$, we have*

$$w_R \searrow_n w_{R'}$$

Proof. Let $w = w_R$ and suppose $\mathbf{c}_n(w) = m$. By construction, the second to last step of Algorithm 3 yields a bounded RC graph $\tilde{R}$ with $|\tilde{R}| = n$ such that if $\tilde{w} = w_{\tilde{R}}$, then

$$\tilde{w}(n) > \tilde{w}(n+1) < \tilde{w}(n+2) < \cdots < \tilde{w}(n+m)$$

and

$$w \xrightarrow{n-1} \tilde{w}$$

via reflections t_{ab} such that $n \leq b \leq n+m$. Let $w' = w_{R'}$. We also have

$$\tilde{w} \xrightarrow{n} \varphi_{n,N}(w')$$

via only reflections t_{nb} such that $b > n+m$. We claim that

$$w \xrightarrow{n} \varphi_{n,N}(w')$$

This can only fail if $\tilde{w}(n) \neq w(n)$ by the observations above. However, the pipe labeled n , by virtue of the fact that we have $(n, 1), \dots, (n, m)$ populated, will always lie to the right of pipes $n+1, n+2, \dots, n+m$ in the wiring diagram for $\tilde{w}$ or any intermediate stage. Inserting into any row that contained a crossing $(n, n+p)$, there must be a valid empty space to the left of the pipe labeled n since we have deleted these crossings. By virtue of the fact that the leftmost is always chosen, no reflection (i, n) will ever be inserted. This ensures that $\tilde{w}(n) = w(n)$, as desired. $\square$

Lemma 4.3.5. *Let (R, n) be a bounded RC graph with $n \geq 2$ such that row n is empty. Then*

$$\mathcal{Z}(\text{trim}(R)) = \text{trim}(\mathcal{Z}(R))$$

Proof. This is almost a trivial observation. In terms of the word of R , $\text{trim}(R, n)$ preserves a suffix. Removing all of the initial roots before trimming is therefore the same as removing the initial roots that still remain after trimming, by the exchange property. Afterwards, in performing the insertion algorithm, there is no dependency on rows with a lower index, the modification only proceeds downward in row number. Therefore, trimming the first row at any point only stops the process earlier, and does not change rows with higher index than 1 in the outcome. $\square$

Definition 4.3.6. For a permutation w with $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq n$ define

$$P_1(w) = \{v : w \searrow_1 v\}, \quad T_n(w) = \{w' : w \searrow_n w', \ell(w') = \ell(w)\}.$$

By Proposition 2.1.6 with $i = n$ (this is the identity used in the proof of Theorem 4.3),

$$(4.3.1) \quad \mathfrak{S}_w(x_1, \dots, x_{n-1}, 0) = \sum_{w' \in T_n(w)} \mathfrak{S}_{w'}(x_1, \dots, x_{n-1}),$$

and by Theorem 4.1 together with Corollary 4.1.6 (or Proposition 2.1.6 with $i = 1, y = 0$),

$$(4.3.2) \quad \mathfrak{S}_w(x_1, \dots, x_n) = \sum_{v \in P_1(w)} x_1^{\ell(w) - \ell(v)} \mathfrak{S}_v(x_2, \dots, x_n).$$

Let u be a permutation with $\mathbf{m}(u) = n$. Let $s = \max\{j > n : u(j) < u(n)\}$. A *transition step* at n replaces u by

$$u^+ = u t_{ns} t_{in} \quad \text{for some } i < n \text{ with } \ell(u t_{ns} t_{in}) = \ell(u t_{ns}) + 1.$$

The Lascoux–Schützenberger transition formula (Macdonald, *Notes on Schubert polynomials*, (4.16)) reads $\mathfrak{S}_u = x_n \mathfrak{S}_{u t_{ns}} + \sum_i \mathfrak{S}_{u t_{ns} t_{in}}$, the sum over all such i .

Lemma 4.3.7. *Let $w = c \cdot \uparrow v$ with $\ell(w) = \ell(c) + \ell(v)$ and $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq n$. Then $\mathbf{m}(v) \leq n-1$. In particular, if $R \in \mathcal{RC}(w, n)^0$ with $n \geq 2$, then $\text{trim}(R) \in \mathcal{RC}(v, n-1)^0$ with $v = w_{\text{trim}R} \in P_1(w)$; and every $v \in P_1(w)$ has $\mathbf{m}(v) \leq n-1$.*

Proof. Let $u = \uparrow v$ and suppose $u(j) > u(j+1)$. Write $u = u''s_j$ with $\ell(u'') = \ell(u) - 1$. Then $w = (cu'')s_j$ and $\ell(cu'') \leq \ell(c) + \ell(u) - 1 < \ell(w)$, so $w(j) > w(j+1)$. Hence every right descent of $\uparrow v$ is a right descent of w , so $\mathbf{m}(\uparrow v) \leq n$, i.e. $\mathbf{m}(v) \leq n - 1$.

For the second statement, the reading word of R is (word of row 1) · (word of rows ≥ 2), which is reduced, so $w = c \cdot \uparrow w_{\text{trim}R}$ with lengths adding, where c is the permutation of row 1; and $w \searrow^1 w_{\text{trim}R}$ by the proof of Theorem 4.1. Row $n - 1$ of $\text{trim}R$ is row n of R , which is empty. The last statement follows from Lemmas 4.1.2 and 4.1.3, which give $w = c \cdot \uparrow v$ with lengths adding for every $v \in P_1(w)$. $\square$

Lemma 4.3.8. *Let $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq n$. If $\mathbf{m}(w) < n$ then $T_n(w) = \{w\}$. Otherwise $T_n(w)$ is the set of permutations w' with $\mathbf{m}(w') < n$ that can be reached from w by a sequence of transition steps at n . Moreover, for a single step $u \mapsto u^+ = u t_{ns} t_{in}$, writing $\zeta = u(n)$ and $\eta = u(s)$:*

- (O1) $u^+(n) = u(i) < \eta < \zeta$; in particular the value in position n strictly decreases at every step;
- (O2) the only position $l < n$ with $u^+(l) \neq u(l)$ is $l = i$, and $u(i) < u^+(i) = \eta < \zeta$.

Proof. (O1) and (O2) are read off from the definition ($\eta < \zeta$ by choice of s , and $u(i) < \eta$ by the cover criterion). Since $\mathbf{m}(u) = n$, the values $u(n+1) < u(n+2) < \dots$ increase, those in positions $n+1, \dots, s$ are $< \zeta$, and those in positions $> s$ are $> \zeta$. So after replacing $u(s)$ by ζ the values in positions $> n$ still increase; thus $\mathbf{m}(u^+) \leq n$. The number of positions $j > n$ with $u^+(j) < u^+(n)$ is at most $s - 1 - n$, which is less than $s - n = \#\{j > n : u(j) < u(n)\}$, so every sequence of steps terminates. Setting $x_n = 0$ in the transition formula and iterating gives $\mathfrak{S}_w(x_1, \dots, x_{n-1}, 0) = \sum \mathfrak{S}_{w'}$ over the end points w' of all step sequences (a priori with multiplicity). Comparing with (4.3.1) and using that Schubert polynomials are linearly independent gives the claim. $\square$

Lemma 4.3.9. *Let $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq n$ and let $w' \neq w''$ be two elements of $T_n(w)$. Then $P_1(w') \cap P_1(w'') = \emptyset$.*

Proof. Step 1: what w' and w'' look like. By Lemma 4.3.8, w' and w'' are end points of two sequences of transition steps starting at w . The choice of s in a step is forced, so the two sequences agree up to some permutation u and then make different choices $i \neq i'$; say $i < i' < n$. Put $\tilde{v} = u t_{ns}$, $\eta = \tilde{v}(n)$, $z = \tilde{v}(i) = u(i)$, $z' = \tilde{v}(i') = u(i')$. Both t_{in} and $t_{i'n}$ are covers of $\tilde{v}$, so $z < \eta$ and $z' < \eta$; and since $i < i' < n$, the cover criterion for t_{in} forbids $z < z' < \eta$. Hence

$$z' < z < \eta.$$

Along the first sequence, right after the branching step position i holds η , position i' holds z' , and position n holds z . By (O1) and (O2), a position $l < n$ is changed at a later step only if its current value is smaller than the current value in position n (which is $\leq z$ from now on), and its new value is then also smaller than z . Therefore

$$(4.3.3) \quad w'(i) = \eta, \quad w'(i') < z.$$

Along the second sequence, right after the branching step position i' holds η , position i holds z , and position n holds $z' < z$. By the same reasoning neither position is ever changed again:

$$(4.3.4) \quad w''(i) = z, \quad w''(i') = \eta.$$

Step 2: what a 1-chain looks like. Fix M with $w', w'' \in S_M$ (the relation $\searrow^1$ does not depend on this choice). Suppose $y \in S_M$ and $y \searrow^1 u'$, and put $Y = \varphi_{1,M}(u')$. By Definitions 2.1.1 and 2.1.4 there are $y = Y_0, Y_1, \dots, Y_q = Y$ with $Y_t = Y_{t-1} t_{1b_t}$ and $\ell(Y_t) = \ell(Y_{t-1}) + 1$. Put $x_t = Y_t(1)$, so $x_0 < x_1 < \dots < x_q$. A position that has been used holds a value smaller than the current value in position 1, so it is never used again. Consequently:

- (F1) for every $l \geq 2$: either $Y(l) = y(l)$, or $l = b_t$ for a unique $t \geq 1$, and then $y(l) = x_t$ and $Y(l) = x_{t-1} \geq x_0 = y(1)$. In particular $Y(l) \leq y(l)$.
- (F2) if $l = b_t$, there is no l_0 with $1 < l_0 < l$ and $x_{t-1} < y(l_0) < x_t$. (The cover criterion says this for Y_{t-1} in place of y ; and $Y_{t-1}(l_0) \neq y(l_0)$ only if $l_0 = b_{t'}$ with $t' < t$, in which case $y(l_0) = x_{t'} \leq x_{t-1}$.)

Step 3: the contradiction. Suppose $u' \in P_1(w') \cap P_1(w'')$ and let $Y = \varphi_{1,M}(u')$. Note $i' \geq 2$. Apply (F1) with $y = w'$: by (4.3.3), $Y(i') \leq w'(i') < z$. Now apply (F1) with $y = w''$: by (4.3.4), $w''(i') = \eta > z > Y(i')$, so $i' = b_t$ is a chain position for w'' , with $x_t = \eta$ and $x_{t-1} = Y(i') < z$.

If $i = 1$, then $x_0 = w''(1) = z$ by (4.3.4), contradicting $x_{t-1} \geq x_0$.

If $i \geq 2$, then $l_0 = i$ satisfies $1 < l_0 < i'$ and $x_{t-1} < w''(l_0) = z < \eta = x_t$, contradicting (F2). $\square$

Lemma 4.3.10. *Let $n \geq 3$, $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq n$, and let u' be a permutation. Then there is at most one $v \in P_1(w)$ with $u' \in T_{n-1}(v)$.*

Proof. By Lemma 4.3.7 every $v \in P_1(w)$ has $\mathbf{m}(v) \leq n-1$, so $T_{n-1}(v)$ makes sense. Set $x_n = 0$ in (4.3.2) and expand each $\mathfrak{S}_v(x_2, \dots, x_{n-1}, 0)$ by (4.3.1):

$$\mathfrak{S}_w(x_1, \dots, x_{n-1}, 0) = \sum_{v \in P_1(w)} \sum_{u' \in T_{n-1}(v)} x_1^{\ell(w) - \ell(v)} \mathfrak{S}_{u'}(x_2, \dots, x_{n-1}).$$

Alternatively, expand by (4.3.1) first and then apply (4.3.2) to each w' (which has $\mathbf{m}(w') \leq n-1$):

$$\mathfrak{S}_w(x_1, \dots, x_{n-1}, 0) = \sum_{w' \in T_n(w)} \sum_{u' \in P_1(w')} x_1^{\ell(w') - \ell(u')} \mathfrak{S}_{u'}(x_2, \dots, x_{n-1}).$$

The polynomials $x_1^a \mathfrak{S}_{u'}(x_2, \dots, x_{n-1})$ ($a \geq 0$, $\mathbf{m}(u') \leq n-2$) are linearly independent. Comparing coefficients and summing over a ,

$$\#\{v \in P_1(w) : u' \in T_{n-1}(v)\} = \#\{w' \in T_n(w) : u' \in P_1(w')\},$$

and the right side is at most 1 by Lemma 4.3.9. $\square$

Lemma 4.3.11. *Let w be a permutation with last descent at most n . Let $\mathcal{RC}(w, n)^0$ be the set of bounded RC graphs R with $\mathbf{ht}(R) = n$ such that $w_R = w$ and row n is empty. Then*

$$\mathcal{Z} : \mathcal{RC}(w, n)^0 \rightarrow \mathcal{RC}_{n-1}$$

is injective.

Proof. Induction on n . For $n = 2$: an element of $\mathcal{RC}(w, 2)^0$ is a single row, and a single row is determined by its permutation (Theorem 4.1 applied to the empty graph), so $\mathcal{RC}(w, 2)^0$ has at most one element.

Let $n \geq 3$ and assume the statement for $n-1$ and every permutation. Let $R, R' \in \mathcal{RC}(w, n)^0$ with $\mathcal{Z}(R) = \mathcal{Z}(R') =: S$. Put $T = \mathbf{trim} R$, $T' = \mathbf{trim} R'$, $v = w_T$, $v' = w_{T'}$.

- (1) By Lemma 4.3.7, $T \in \mathcal{RC}(v, n-1)^0$ and $T' \in \mathcal{RC}(v', n-1)^0$ with $v, v' \in P_1(w)$. So $\mathcal{Z}(T)$, $\mathcal{Z}(T')$ are defined and Lemma 4.3.5 applies: $\mathcal{Z}(T) = \mathbf{trim} S = \mathcal{Z}(T')$.
- (2) Let $u' = w_{\mathbf{trim} S}$. By Lemma 4.3.4, $v \xrightarrow{n-1} u'$ and $v' \xrightarrow{n-1} u'$; by Lemma 4.3.3, $\mathbf{wt}(\mathcal{Z}(T)) = \mathbf{wt}(T)$ and $\mathbf{wt}(\mathcal{Z}(T')) = \mathbf{wt}(T')$, so $\ell(u') = \ell(v) = \ell(v')$. Thus $u' \in T_{n-1}(v) \cap T_{n-1}(v')$.
- (3) By Lemma 4.3.10, $v = v'$.
- (4) Now $T, T' \in \mathcal{RC}(v, n-1)^0$ with $\mathcal{Z}(T) = \mathcal{Z}(T')$, so $T = T'$ by the inductive hypothesis.
- (5) By Theorem 4.1, $R = \text{row}_1(Q_1(v, w)) \cup \uparrow T = R'$. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 4.3. By the previous lemma, it suffices to show that $\mathcal{Z}$ is surjective. We have by the transition formula that if $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq n$, then

$$\mathfrak{S}_w(x_1, \dots, x_{n-1}, 0) = \sum_{\substack{w \xrightarrow{n} w' \\ \ell(w) = \ell(w')}} \mathfrak{S}_{w'}(x_1, \dots, x_{n-1})$$

Note that this sum is without multiplicity, by Lemma 4.3.8. The right hand side is equal to

$$\sum_{\substack{w \xrightarrow{n} w' \\ \ell(w) = \ell(w')}} \sum_{R' \in \mathcal{RC}_{n-1}(w')} x^{\mathbf{wt}(R')}$$

and the left hand side is equal to

$$\sum_{R \in \mathcal{RC}(w, n)^0} x^{\mathbf{wt}(R)}$$

since the only RC graphs that contribute to the left hand side are those with row n empty. This implies that

$$|\mathcal{RC}(w, n)^0| = \sum_{\substack{w \xrightarrow{n} w' \\ \ell(w) = \ell(w')}} |\mathcal{RC}_{n-1}(w')|$$

Now, the set

$$\{\mathcal{Z}(R) \mid R \in \mathcal{RC}(w, n)^0\}$$

has the same cardinality as $\mathcal{RC}(w, n)^0$ by injectivity (Lemma 4.3.11), and is a subset of $\bigcup_{w \searrow w', \ell(w')=\ell(w)}^n \mathcal{RC}_{n-1}(w')$ by Lemmas 4.3.4 and 4.3.3. Since the right hand side has the same cardinality as $\mathcal{RC}(w, n)^0$, we conclude that $\mathcal{Z}$ is surjective, as desired. $\square$

We may extend $\mathcal{Z}$ to an endomorphism $\mathcal{BRC} \rightarrow \mathcal{BRC}$ by defining $\mathcal{Z}(R) = 0$ if the last row of R is not empty. Then we have the following result.

Corollary 4.3.12 (Combinatorial Lascoux-Scützenberger transition formula). *Let w be a permutation with last descent at most n . Then*

$$\mathcal{Z}(\mathcal{S}_w(n)) = \sum_{\substack{w \searrow w' \\ \ell(w)=\ell(w')}} \mathcal{S}_{w'}(n-1)$$

4.4. Definition of the ring product. We first make the maps $\mathbf{trim}^p$ and $\mathbf{clip}^p$ of the introduction precise. Throughout, $\mathcal{Z}^k$ denotes the k -fold iterate of $\mathcal{Z}$, extended to $\mathcal{BRC}$ as above by declaring $\mathcal{Z}(R) = 0$ when the last row of R is nonempty. For $a \geq 0$ write $\mathbf{row}(a) = \{(1, 1), \dots, (1, a)\}$ for the bounded RC graph of height 1 with reading word $s_a s_{a-1} \dots s_1$.

Lemma 4.4.1 (The last row is determined by its weight). *Let R be a bounded RC graph with $\mathbf{ht}(R) = n \geq 1$ and let $a = \mathbf{wt}_n(R)$. Then row n of R is $\{(n, 1), \dots, (n, a)\}$, i.e. its word is $s_{n+a-1} s_{n+a-2} \dots s_n$. In particular $\mathbf{row}(a)$ is the unique bounded RC graph of height 1 with a crossings, and R is determined by $R_{\leq n-1}$ together with $\mathbf{wt}_n(R)$.*

Proof. By Lemma 4.3.7 applied $n-1$ times, $\mathbf{trim}^{n-1}(R)$ is a bounded RC graph of height 1; its underlying set is $\{(1, j) : (n, j) \in R\}$, so it suffices to treat $n = 1$. Let R have height 1 with crossings in columns $j_1 > j_2 > \dots > j_a$. Its reading word $s_{j_1} s_{j_2} \dots s_{j_a}$ is reduced, and $w = w_R$ satisfies $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq 1$, so $w(2) < w(3) < \dots$ and w has code $(a, 0, 0, \dots)$, i.e. $w = s_a s_{a-1} \dots s_1$. This permutation is a cycle with a unique reduced word, so $j_k = a + 1 - k$ for all k . $\square$

Definition 4.4.2. Let R be a bounded RC graph with $\mathbf{ht}(R) = n$ and let $0 \leq p \leq n$. For $0 \leq k \leq n$ write $R_{\leq k} = \{(i, j) \in R : i \leq k\}$.

- (1) $\mathbf{trim}^p(R) = \mathbf{trim}(\mathbf{trim}(\dots \mathbf{trim}(R)))$ (p times) is the bounded RC graph of height $n - p$ with underlying set $\{(i - p, j) : (i, j) \in R, i > p\}$. (Each single trim is again a bounded RC graph by Lemma 4.3.7.)
- (2) Suppose $n \geq 1$. Let $h = \max(n-1, \mathbf{m}(w_{R_{\leq n-1}}))$ and regard $R_{\leq n-1}$ as a bounded RC graph of height h ; its rows $n, \dots, h$ are empty. The *one-row clip* of R is

$$\mathbf{clip}^{n-1}(R) = \mathcal{Z}^{h-n+1}(R_{\leq n-1}) \in \mathcal{BRC}_{n-1}.$$

- (3) Define $\mathbf{clip}^p(R)$ recursively by $\mathbf{clip}^n(R) = R$ and $\mathbf{clip}^p(R) = \mathbf{clip}^p(\mathbf{clip}^{n-1}(R))$ for $p < n$; that is, $\mathbf{clip}^p(R)$ is the result of $n - p$ successive one-row clips.

For the one-row clip to be a single bounded RC graph (rather than 0) the last row must be empty at every intermediate step. This holds because $\mathcal{Z}$ preserves weight vectors (Lemma 4.3.3): if R' has height h and rows $n, \dots, h$ empty, then $\mathcal{Z}(R')$ has height $h-1$ and the same weight, so its rows $n, \dots, h-1$ are empty. Consequently $\mathbf{clip}^p(R)$ is a bounded RC graph of height p with $\mathbf{wt}(\mathbf{clip}^p(R)) = (\mathbf{wt}_1(R), \dots, \mathbf{wt}_p(R))$. In particular $\mathbf{clip}^{n-1}(R) = R_{\leq n-1}$ whenever $\mathbf{m}(w_{R_{\leq n-1}}) \leq n-1$; $\mathbf{clip}^0(R) = \emptyset$ (the empty RC graph of height 0); and $\mathbf{clip}^1(R) = \mathbf{row}(\mathbf{wt}_1(R))$ by Lemma 4.4.1.

Definition 4.4.3. Suppose we have two bounded RC graphs R_1 with $\mathbf{ht}(R_1) = m$ and R_2 with $\mathbf{ht}(R_2) = n$. The product of these is defined by

$$R_1 \boxplus R_2 = \sum_{\substack{\mathbf{clip}^m(R')=R_1 \\ \mathbf{trim}^m(R')=R_2}} R'$$

where R' ranges over bounded RC graphs with $\mathbf{ht}(R') = m + n$.

Associativity of $\boxplus$ rests on two structural identities relating $\mathbf{clip}^p$ and $\mathbf{trim}^p$: a functoriality of $\mathbf{clip}$ under iteration, and a commutativity of $\mathbf{clip}$ with $\mathbf{trim}$.

Lemma 4.4.4. *Let R be a bounded RC graph with $\text{ht}(R) = n$, and let $0 \leq p \leq p + q \leq n$. Then*

$$\text{clip}^p(\text{clip}^{p+q}(R)) = \text{clip}^p(R).$$

Proof. Both sides are the composite of $n - p$ one-row clips applied to R (Definition 4.4.2(3)). $\square$

Lemma 4.4.5 (Commutativity of clip and trim). *Let R be a bounded RC graph with $\text{ht}(R) = p + q + r$. Then*

$$\text{trim}^p(\text{clip}^{p+q}(R)) = \text{clip}^q(\text{trim}^p(R)).$$

Proof. Both sides have height q . Since trim^p is a composite of single trims and clip^{p+q} , clip^q are composites of one-row clips, it suffices to show that a single trim commutes with a one-row clip: for R of height $n \geq 2$,

$$\text{trim}(\text{clip}^{n-1}(R)) = \text{clip}^{n-2}(\text{trim}(R)).$$

Let $h = \max(n - 1, \mathbf{m}(w_{R_{\leq n-1}}))$, so $\text{clip}^{n-1}(R) = \mathcal{Z}^{h-n+1}(R_{\leq n-1})$ with $R_{\leq n-1}$ at height h . Then $\text{trim}(R_{\leq n-1}) = (\text{trim}R)_{\leq n-2}$ at height $h - 1$, and $\mathbf{m}(w_{\text{trim}(R_{\leq n-1})}) \leq h - 1$ by Lemma 4.3.7. Set $h' = \max(n - 2, \mathbf{m}(w_{(\text{trim}R)_{\leq n-2}})) \leq h - 1$, so $\text{clip}^{n-2}(\text{trim}R) = \mathcal{Z}^{h'-n+2}((\text{trim}R)_{\leq n-2})$ at height h' . Since $\mathcal{Z}$ acts on a graph whose permutation has last descent below its height by deleting the empty last row, $\mathcal{Z}^{h-1-h'}$ carries $(\text{trim}R)_{\leq n-2}$ at height $h - 1$ to the same graph at height h' , whence $\text{clip}^{n-2}(\text{trim}R) = \mathcal{Z}^{h-n+1}(\text{trim}(R_{\leq n-1}))$. Lemma 4.3.5 gives $\text{trim}(\mathcal{Z}(R')) = \mathcal{Z}(\text{trim}(R'))$ for any R' with empty last row, and the last row stays empty throughout by weight preservation, so iterating $h - n + 1$ times,

$$\text{trim}(\text{clip}^{n-1}(R)) = \text{trim}(\mathcal{Z}^{h-n+1}(R_{\leq n-1})) = \mathcal{Z}^{h-n+1}(\text{trim}(R_{\leq n-1})) = \text{clip}^{n-2}(\text{trim}(R)),$$

as required. $\square$

The one-row clip erases the last row of R and then rewrites the remaining rows by $\mathcal{Z}$, so a priori $\text{clip}^p(R)$ depends on all of $R_{\leq n-1}$, not only on $R_{\leq p}$. In fact the intermediate rows are irrelevant. To state this, define for a bounded RC graph X with $\text{ht}(X) \geq p$

$$D^p(X) = \mathcal{Z}^{h_X-p}(X_{\leq p}), \quad h_X = \max(p, \mathbf{m}(w_{X_{\leq p}})),$$

where $X_{\leq p}$ is regarded as a bounded RC graph of height h_X . By the weight-preservation argument following Definition 4.4.2, $D^p(X)$ is a bounded RC graph of height p with $\mathbf{wt}(D^p X) = \mathbf{wt}(X)_{\leq p}$; moreover $D^p(X) = D^p(X_{\leq k})$ for every $k \geq p$, and $D^p(X) = \mathcal{Z}^{N-p}(X_{\leq p})$ for every $N \geq h_X$, since $\mathcal{Z}$ deletes the empty last row whenever the height exceeds $\mathbf{m}$.

Lemma 4.4.6. *Let X be a bounded RC graph with $\text{ht}(X) \geq p \geq 1$. Then $\text{trim}(D^p(X)) = D^{p-1}(\text{trim}X)$.*

Proof. Let $h = h_X$. Iterating Lemma 4.3.5 (the last row stays empty at each step by weight preservation),

$$\text{trim}(D^p(X)) = \text{trim}(\mathcal{Z}^{h-p}(X_{\leq p})) = \mathcal{Z}^{h-p}(\text{trim}(X_{\leq p})),$$

and $\text{trim}(X_{\leq p}) = (\text{trim}X)_{\leq p-1}$ regarded at height $h - 1$, which is bounded by Lemma 4.3.7. Hence $h - 1 \geq h_{\text{trim}X}$ and the right side is $D^{p-1}(\text{trim}X)$. $\square$

Lemma 4.4.7 (Locality of clip^p). *Let R be a bounded RC graph with $\text{ht}(R) = n$ and let $0 \leq p \leq n$. Then*

$$\text{clip}^p(R) = D^p(R) = \mathcal{Z}^{h_R-p}(R_{\leq p}).$$

In particular $\text{clip}^p(R)$ depends only on the top p rows of R .

Proof. We show $\text{clip}^p = D^p$ on $\mathcal{RC}_n$ by induction on $n - p$, the case $n = p$ being trivial. For $n > p$, $\text{clip}^p(R) = \text{clip}^p(\text{clip}^{n-1}R) = D^p(\text{clip}^{n-1}R)$ by induction, and $\text{clip}^{n-1}R = \mathcal{Z}^{h-n+1}(R_{\leq n-1})$ with $D^p(R) = D^p(R_{\leq n-1})$. It therefore suffices to prove

$$(4.4.1) \quad D^p(\mathcal{Z}(Y)) = D^p(Y)$$

for every bounded RC graph Y of height $m > p$ whose last row is empty. If $\mathbf{m}(w_Y) < m$, then $\mathcal{Z}(Y)$ is Y with its last row deleted, and (4.4.1) is clear. If $p \leq 1$, both sides of (4.4.1) are determined by their weight $(\mathbf{wt}_1(Y), \dots, \mathbf{wt}_p(Y))$ (Lemmas 4.3.3 and 4.4.1).

Suppose $p \geq 2$ and $\mathbf{m}(w_Y) = m$, and assume (4.4.1) for $p - 1$. By Lemmas 4.4.6 and 4.3.5,

$$\text{trim}(D^p(\mathcal{Z}Y)) = D^{p-1}(\text{trim} \mathcal{Z}Y) = D^{p-1}(\mathcal{Z} \text{trim}Y) = D^{p-1}(\text{trim}Y) = \text{trim}(D^p(Y)),$$

where the third equality is (4.4.1) for $p - 1$ applied to $\text{trim}Y$ (or the trivial case if $\mathfrak{m}(w_{\text{trim}Y}) < m - 1$). Thus rows $2, \dots, p$ of the two sides of (4.4.1) coincide. A bounded RC graph X is determined by $\text{trim}X$ together with w_X : the word of row 1 is the unique strictly decreasing reduced word of $w_X \cdot (\uparrow w_{\text{trim}X})^{-1}$. Consequently (4.4.1) is equivalent to the equality of permutations

$$(4.4.2) \quad w_{D^p(ZY)} = w_{D^p(Y)}.$$

[Identity (4.4.2) for $\mathfrak{m}(w_Y) = m$, $p \geq 2$ remains to be written. It has been verified by computer for all bounded RC graphs of height at most 5 and length at most 5. Two reductions: (a) it suffices to treat Y with rows $p + 2, \dots, m$ empty, since $D^p \circ D^{p+1} = D^p$ at every level implies $D^p \circ D^n = D^p$ by induction on $n - p$; (b) by Proposition 5.1.6, Z is a composite of Little bumps at roots $(m', m' + 1)$ with $m' > p$, and (4.4.1) is equivalent to the statement that $D^p(T)$ is unchanged by any Little bump of $T \in \mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}$ at an inversion (a, b) with $a > p$ (verified for length ≤ 7), i.e. to the confluence of the rewriting system on $\mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}$ generated by such bumps. Note that the one-step statement “erasing rows $p + 1, \dots, m$ commutes with Z ” is false, and $w_{D^p(Y)}$ is not a function of $w_{Y_{\leq p}}$ and $\text{wt}(Y)$ alone; only the fully iterated identity holds.] $\square$

Theorem 4.4. *The product $\sqcup$ is associative and $\mathcal{BRC}$ is a ring when equipped with $\sqcup$.*

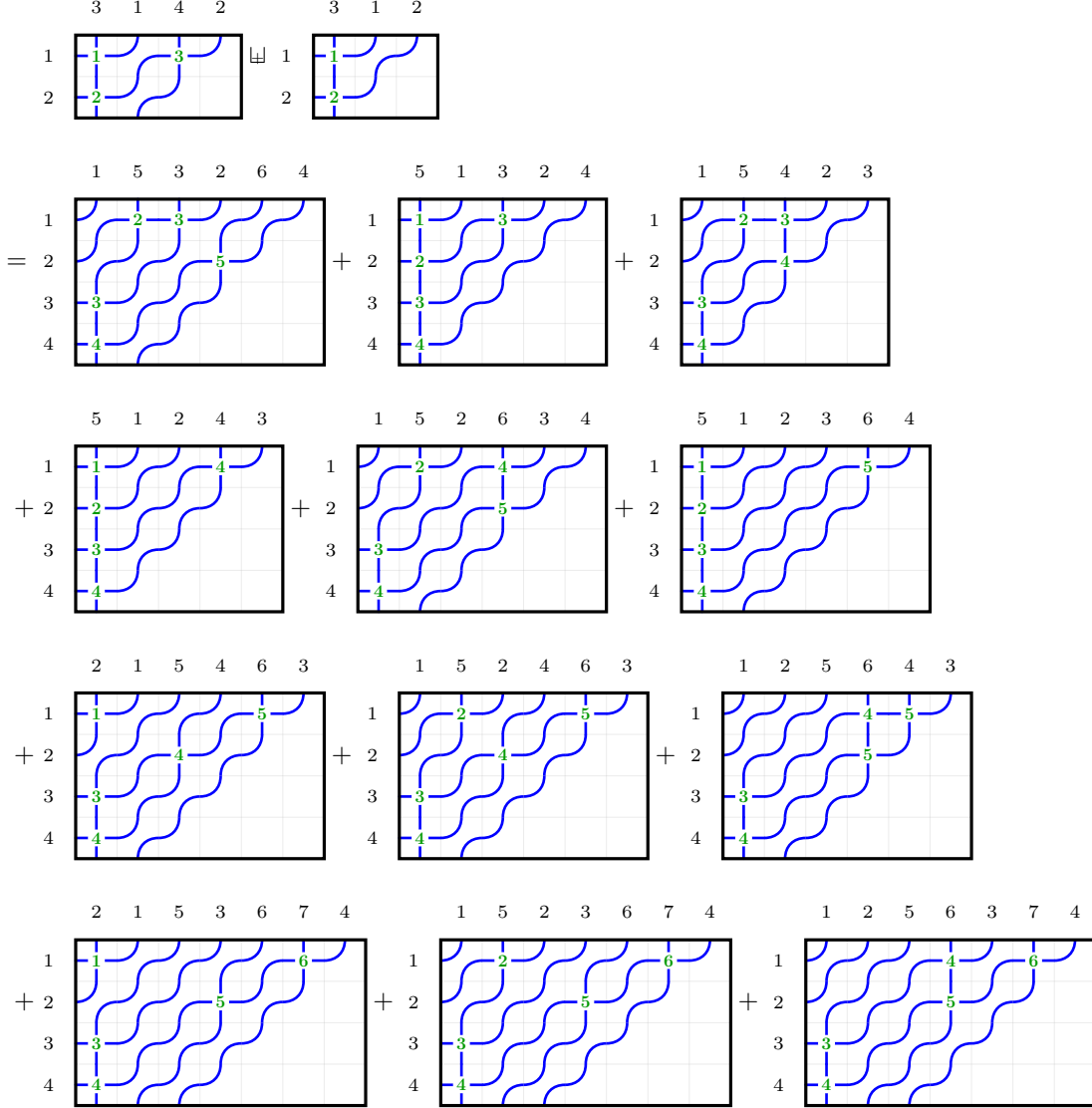
Proof. Let R_1, R_2, R_3 be bounded RC graphs of heights p, q, r respectively, and let R be a bounded RC graph with $\text{ht}(R) = p + q + r$. We claim that R appears as a term in $(R_1 \sqcup R_2) \sqcup R_3$ if and only if it appears as a term in $R_1 \sqcup (R_2 \sqcup R_3)$, and in both cases with multiplicity 1. Unwinding the definition of $\sqcup$ in each bracketing yields the following conditions on R :

	Left bracketing $(R_1 \sqcup R_2) \sqcup R_3$	Right bracketing $R_1 \sqcup (R_2 \sqcup R_3)$
(i)	$\text{clip}^p(\text{clip}^{p+q}(R)) = R_1$	$\text{clip}^p(R) = R_1$
(ii)	$\text{trim}^p(\text{clip}^{p+q}(R)) = R_2$	$\text{clip}^q(\text{trim}^p(R)) = R_2$
(iii)	$\text{trim}^{p+q}(R) = R_3$	$\text{trim}^q(\text{trim}^p(R)) = R_3$

Row (i) is equivalent on both sides by Lemma 4.4.4. Row (ii) is equivalent on both sides by Lemma 4.4.5. Row (iii) is equivalent on both sides because $\text{trim}^{p+q} = \text{trim}^q \circ \text{trim}^p$ by definition of trim . Thus the term R contributes to the same bracketed product on both sides. Since the membership conditions are equalities (not weighted by any combinatorial multiplicity) and R is determined to lie in either product by these three conditions, the multiplicity is 1 in each case. We conclude that $(R_1 \sqcup R_2) \sqcup R_3 = R_1 \sqcup (R_2 \sqcup R_3)$.

To tie up the claim that $\mathcal{BRC}$ is a ring, distributivity is directly imposed by the definition of the product as extending from the definition bilinearly, and the identity element is the empty RC graph of height 0. $\square$

Example 4.4.8. We compute the product of two bounded RC graphs $(R_1, 2) \in \mathcal{BRC}(2413, 2)$ and $(R_2, 2) \in \mathcal{BRC}(231, 2)$:



4.5. Proof of the Littlewood-Richardson rule for the dual Schubert basis. We prove Theorem 1.1 by comparing two expansions of $\mathfrak{S}_w(x_1, \dots, x_{p+q})$: the monomial expansion over $\mathcal{RC}_{p+q}(w)$ (Corollary 4.1.6) and the branching expansion (3.1.1). The bridge is the following description of the fibers of $\mathbf{clip}^p$.

For a permutation u and $p \geq 0$, let $h = \max(p, \mathbf{m}(u))$ and let $\mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u) \subseteq \mathcal{RC}_h(u)$ be the set of RC graphs of u all of whose crossings lie in rows $1, \dots, p$. For $k \geq 1$ and a permutation z with $\mathbf{m}(z) \leq k$ recall $T_k(z) = \{z' : z \searrow^k z', \ell(z') = \ell(z)\}$; by (4.3.1) and linear independence of Schubert polynomials, $T_k(z) = \{z\}$ when $\mathbf{m}(z) < k$. For u' with $\mathbf{m}(u') \leq p$ let $N_p(u, u')$ be the number of chains

$$u = u_h, \quad u_{h-1} \in T_h(u_h), \quad u_{h-2} \in T_{h-1}(u_{h-1}), \quad \dots, \quad u_p \in T_{p+1}(u_{p+1}), \quad u_p = u',$$

so that $N_p(u, u') = \delta_{u, u'}$ when $h = p$.

Lemma 4.5.1. *Let u, p, h be as above. For every u' with $\mathbf{m}(u') \leq p$ and every $U \in \mathcal{RC}_p(u')$,*

$$\#\{T \in \mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u) : \mathcal{Z}^{h-p}(T) = U\} = N_p(u, u').$$

Consequently

$$\sum_{T \in \mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u)} x^{\mathbf{wt}(T)} = \mathfrak{S}_u(x_1, \dots, x_p, 0, \dots, 0) = \sum_{u'} N_p(u, u') \mathfrak{S}_{u'}(x_1, \dots, x_p).$$

Proof. Induct on $h - p$; if $h = p$ then $\mathcal{Z}^0$ is the identity and $\mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u) = \mathcal{RC}_p(u)$. Suppose $h > p$. Every $T \in \mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u)$ has empty last row, so by Theorem 4.3 and Lemma 4.3.3, $\mathcal{Z}$ restricts to a weight-preserving injection from $\mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u)$ into $\bigsqcup_{u_1 \in T_h(u)} \mathcal{RC}_{h-1}(u_1)$ (the length condition $\ell(u_1) = \ell(u)$ is forced by weight preservation). By weight preservation the image consists of graphs whose rows $p+1, \dots, h-1$ are empty, and conversely every such graph $T' \in \mathcal{RC}_{h-1}(u_1)$ is $\mathcal{Z}(T)$ for a unique $T \in \mathcal{RC}_h(u)^0$ by Theorem 4.3, and this T has rows $p+1, \dots, h$ empty by weight preservation, so $T \in \mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u)$. Thus $\mathcal{Z}$ is a bijection from $\mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u)$ onto the set of $T' \in \bigsqcup_{u_1 \in T_h(u)} \mathcal{RC}_{h-1}(u_1)$ with rows $p+1, \dots, h-1$ empty. For such T' with $w_{T'} = u_1$, put $h_1 = \max(p, \mathbf{m}(u_1)) \leq h-1$; the first $h-1-h_1$ applications of $\mathcal{Z}$ to T' delete empty last rows (Algorithm 3), so $\mathcal{Z}^{h-1-p}(T') = \mathcal{Z}^{h_1-p}(T')$ with T' regarded as an element of $\mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u_1)$. Hence

$$\#\{T \in \mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u) : \mathcal{Z}^{h-p}(T) = U\} = \sum_{u_1 \in T_h(u)} \#\{T' \in \mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u_1) : \mathcal{Z}^{h_1-p}(T') = U\} = \sum_{u_1 \in T_h(u)} N_p(u_1, u') = N_p(u, u')$$

by induction. For the second statement, Corollary 4.1.6 gives $\sum_{T \in \mathcal{RC}_h(u)} x^{\mathbf{wt}(T)} = \mathfrak{S}_u(x_1, \dots, x_h)$, and setting $x_{p+1} = \dots = x_h = 0$ kills exactly the terms with a crossing in rows $p+1, \dots, h$; this is the first equality. For the second, sum the fiber count over $U \in \mathcal{RC}_p(u')$ and all u' , using $\mathbf{wt}(\mathcal{Z}^{h-p}(T)) = \mathbf{wt}(T)$ and Corollary 4.1.6 for $\mathcal{RC}_p(u')$. $\square$

Definition 4.5.2. Given RC graphs $U \in \mathcal{RC}_p(u)$ and $V \in \mathcal{RC}_q(v)$ and a permutation w , define

$$d_{U,V}^w = \#\{R \in \mathcal{RC}_{p+q}(w) : \text{clip}^p(R) = U, \text{trim}^p(R) = V\}$$

Proof of Theorem 1.1. Fix $u, v \in S_\infty$ with $\mathbf{m}(u) \leq p$, $\mathbf{m}(v) \leq q$, and fix $U \in \mathcal{RC}_p(u)$, $V \in \mathcal{RC}_q(v)$. By Lemma 3.1.4, $d_{u,v}^w(p, q) = b_{u,v}^w(p, q)$, so we must show $d_{U,V}^w = b_{u,v}^w(p, q)$ for every w with $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq p+q$.

Let $R \in \mathcal{RC}_{p+q}(w)$ and write $R = T \cup \uparrow^p V'$ with $T = R_{\leq p}$ and $V' = \text{trim}^p(R) \in \mathcal{RC}_q$ (Lemma 4.3.7). Reading rows from top to bottom, the word of R is the word of T followed by the word of $\uparrow^p V'$, so

$$w = w_T \cdot \uparrow^p w_{V'}, \quad \text{with} \quad \ell(w) = \ell(w_T) + \ell(w_{V'}).$$

Thus $w_T = u_{v'} := w(\uparrow^p v')^{-1}$ where $v' = w_{V'}$, and $\ell(u_{v'}) = \ell(w) - \ell(v')$. Conversely, for any v' with $\mathbf{m}(v') \leq q$ and $\ell(w(\uparrow^p v')^{-1}) = \ell(w) - \ell(v')$, any $V' \in \mathcal{RC}_q(v')$, and any $T \in \mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u_{v'})$, the union $T \cup \uparrow^p V'$ is a reduced RC graph of w with $p+q$ rows, hence lies in $\mathcal{RC}_{p+q}(w)$. Finally, by Lemma 4.4.7, $\text{clip}^p(T \cup \uparrow^p V') = \mathcal{Z}^{h-p}(T)$ with $h = \max(p, \mathbf{m}(u_{v'}))$.

Applying this with $V' = V$ and Lemma 4.5.1,

$$d_{U,V}^w = \#\{T \in \mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u_v) : \mathcal{Z}^{h-p}(T) = U\} = N_p(u_v, u)$$

if $\ell(u_v) = \ell(w) - \ell(v)$, and $d_{U,V}^w = 0$ otherwise. On the other hand, by Corollary 4.1.6, the decomposition $R = T \cup \uparrow^p V'$, and Lemma 4.5.1,

$$\begin{aligned} \mathfrak{S}_w(x_1, \dots, x_{p+q}) &= \sum_{R \in \mathcal{RC}_{p+q}(w)} x^{\mathbf{wt}(R)} = \sum_{\substack{v': \mathbf{m}(v') \leq q \\ \ell(u_{v'}) = \ell(w) - \ell(v')}} \sum_{V' \in \mathcal{RC}_q(v')} x_{p+1}^{\mathbf{wt}_1(V')} \cdots x_{p+q}^{\mathbf{wt}_q(V')} \sum_{T \in \mathcal{RC}_{\leq p}(u_{v'})} x^{\mathbf{wt}(T)} \\ &= \sum_{\substack{v': \mathbf{m}(v') \leq q \\ \ell(u_{v'}) = \ell(w) - \ell(v')}} \sum_{u'} N_p(u_{v'}, u') \mathfrak{S}_{u'}(x_1, \dots, x_p) \mathfrak{S}_{v'}(x_{p+1}, \dots, x_{p+q}). \end{aligned}$$

Comparing with (3.1.1) and using the linear independence of the products $\mathfrak{S}_{u'}(x_1, \dots, x_p) \mathfrak{S}_{v'}(x_{p+1}, \dots, x_{p+q})$ gives $b_{u,v}^w(p, q) = N_p(u_v, u)$ when $\ell(u_v) = \ell(w) - \ell(v)$ and $b_{u,v}^w(p, q) = 0$ otherwise. Hence $d_{U,V}^w = b_{u,v}^w(p, q) = d_{u,v}^w(p, q)$, which is independent of the choice of U and V and nonnegative. $\square$

We now record the ring-theoretic consequences.

Definition 4.5.3. Recall the map $\alpha : \mathcal{BRC} \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$, $\alpha(R) = \Xi_{w_R}^{\text{ht}(R)}$. (The weight map $\omega(R) = [\mathbf{wt}(R)]$ is additive but not multiplicative: every term of $R_1 \sqcup R_2$ has weight $\mathbf{wt}(R_1)\mathbf{wt}(R_2)$, so $\omega(R_1 \sqcup R_2)$ is a multiple of $\omega(R_1) \sqcup \omega(R_2)$ by the number of terms.) Let $\mathcal{R}$ be the subring of $\mathcal{BRC}$ generated by the single-row RC

graphs $\mathbf{row}(i)$ for $i \geq 0$. Let a be a sequence of elements of a ring indexed by the nonnegative integers. For a permutation w and an integer $n \geq \mathbf{m}(w)$, define a function $\Xi_w^n(a)$ by

$$\Xi_w^n(a) = \sum_{\alpha} d_{\alpha,w}^n a_{\alpha_1} \cdots a_{\alpha_n}$$

where the sum is over all weak compositions α of length n , and $d_{\alpha,w}^n$ is the coefficient of α in $\Xi_w^n \in \mathcal{D}$.

Lemma 4.5.4. *We have that the elements*

$$\Xi_w^n(\mathbf{row})$$

for integers $n \geq 0$ and w that ranges over all permutations in S_{∞} with $n \geq \mathbf{m}(w)$ form a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of $\mathcal{R}$, and $\alpha : \mathcal{R} \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$ is an isomorphism of graded rings.

Proof. By Theorem 1.1, α is multiplicative: for $R_1 \in \mathcal{RC}_p(u)$, $R_2 \in \mathcal{RC}_q(v)$,

$$\alpha(R_1 \sqcup R_2) = \sum_w d_{R_1, R_2}^w \Xi_w^{p+q} = \sum_w d_{u,v}^w(p, q) \Xi_w^{p+q} = \Xi_u^p \sqcup \Xi_v^q = \alpha(R_1) \sqcup \alpha(R_2).$$

Restricting to $\mathcal{R}$ gives a graded ring map $\alpha|_{\mathcal{R}} : \mathcal{R} \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$.

Since $\alpha(\mathbf{row}(i)) = \Xi_{s_i \dots s_1}^1 = [i]$ for all $i \geq 0$, the image of $\alpha|_{\mathcal{R}}$ contains the free generators $[i]$ of $\mathcal{D}$, hence $\alpha|_{\mathcal{R}}$ is surjective. Conversely, by freeness of $\mathcal{D}$, there is a unique graded ring homomorphism

$$\iota : \mathcal{D} \rightarrow \mathcal{R}, \quad \iota([i]) = \mathbf{row}(i).$$

Then $(\alpha|_{\mathcal{R}}) \circ \iota = \text{id}_{\mathcal{D}}$, so $\alpha|_{\mathcal{R}}$ is also injective. Therefore $\alpha : \mathcal{R} \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{D}$ is an isomorphism of graded rings.

Finally, the family $\{\Xi_w^n\}_{n \geq 0, n \geq \mathbf{m}(w)}$ is a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of $\mathcal{D}$ by construction, and $\Xi_w^n(\mathbf{row}) = \iota(\Xi_w^n)$, so

$$\alpha(\Xi_w^n(\mathbf{row})) = \Xi_w^n.$$

Applying the isomorphism ι shows that $\{\Xi_w^n(\mathbf{row})\}$ is a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of $\mathcal{R}$. □

Definition 4.5.5. Let Ω be the $\mathbb{Z}$ -submodule of $\mathcal{BRC}$ generated by the RC graphs $R_1 - R_2$ such that $w_{R_1} = w_{R_2}$ and $\mathbf{ht}(R_1) = \mathbf{ht}(R_2)$.

Theorem 4.5. *The map $\alpha : \mathcal{BRC} \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$ is a surjective homomorphism of rings with kernel Ω ; in particular Ω is a two-sided ideal of $\mathcal{BRC}$. The ring homomorphism $\iota : \mathcal{D} \rightarrow \mathcal{BRC}$ sending $[i] \mapsto \mathbf{row}(i)$ is a right inverse to α , with image $\mathcal{R}$, and $\mathcal{BRC} = \mathcal{R} \oplus \Omega$. Consequently $\mathcal{BRC} \cong \mathcal{D} \ltimes \Omega$ as rings.*

Proof. By Lemma 4.5.4 (whose first paragraph is the multiplicativity of α), α is a ring homomorphism; it is surjective since every Ξ_w^n is $\alpha(R)$ for any $R \in \mathcal{RC}_n(w)$, and $\mathcal{RC}_n(w) \neq \emptyset$ when $\mathbf{m}(w) \leq n$.

The kernel of α is Ω : clearly $\Omega \subseteq \ker \alpha$. Conversely, if $x = \sum_R c_R R \in \ker \alpha$, group the terms by $(w_R, \mathbf{ht}(R))$; then $\alpha(x) = \sum_{(w,n)} (\sum_{R \in \mathcal{RC}_n(w)} c_R) \Xi_w^n = 0$ forces $\sum_{R \in \mathcal{RC}_n(w)} c_R = 0$ for each (w, n) by linear independence of the Ξ_w^n , and an element $\sum_{R \in \mathcal{RC}_n(w)} c_R R$ with $\sum c_R = 0$ lies in Ω . As the kernel of a ring homomorphism, Ω is a two-sided ideal.

By Lemma 4.5.4, ι is a ring isomorphism $\mathcal{D} \rightarrow \mathcal{R}$ with $\alpha \circ \iota = \text{id}$. The split exact sequence $0 \rightarrow \Omega \rightarrow \mathcal{BRC} \xrightarrow{\alpha} \mathcal{D} \rightarrow 0$ with section ι gives $\mathcal{BRC} = \mathcal{R} \oplus \Omega$ as abelian groups, with $\mathcal{R}$ a subring and Ω a two-sided ideal; this is precisely the statement $\mathcal{BRC} \cong \mathcal{D} \ltimes \Omega$. □

5. THE RING OF RC GRAPH CRYSTALS

The key polynomials κ_a (also called *Demazure characters* in type A) form a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of $\mathbb{Z}[x_1, x_2, \dots]$ indexed by weak compositions a . Their origin lies in the work of Demazure [7, 8], who introduced isobaric divided difference operators π_i in order to compute the characters of the B -modules $H^0(X_w, \mathcal{L}_{\lambda})$ associated to Schubert varieties X_w in G/B . In type A , the resulting characters become polynomials in the x_i , and one obtains κ_a for any weak composition a by setting $\kappa_{\lambda} = x^{\lambda}$ when λ is a partition (a dominant weight) and applying the appropriate operator π_i at each descent of a to interpolate between rearrangements of λ .

A purely combinatorial development of key polynomials was carried out by Lascoux and Schützenberger [18], who introduced the *right key* $K_+(T)$ and *left key* $K_-(T)$ of a semistandard Young tableau T and proved that

$$\kappa_a = \sum_T x^{\mathbf{wt}(T)},$$

where the sum runs over semistandard Young tableaux T of shape $\text{sort}(a)$ whose right key $K_+(T)$ is bounded above (entrywise) by the key tableau associated to a . They additionally proved that Schubert polynomials decompose as a positive sum of key polynomials, given a combinatorial proof in terms of compatible sequences and the right-key map by Reiner and Shimozono [30]. The intermediate basis of *Demazure atoms* (the “standard bases” of [18]) was later given an explicit nonnegative monomial expansion by Mason [22] via semi-skyline augmented fillings.

From a representation-theoretic perspective, Kashiwara [16] introduced *Demazure crystals*: for a dominant integral weight λ with crystal $B(\lambda)$ and a Weyl group element w with reduced expression $w = s_{i_1} \cdots s_{i_\ell}$, the Demazure crystal $B_w(\lambda) \subseteq B(\lambda)$ is defined inductively from an extremal weight element by closure under the operators $\{e_{i_k}^n : n \geq 0\}$, and its character coincides with the Demazure character. Littelmann [19] obtained parallel results in the path model. Assaf and Schilling [1], building on the crystal structure on reduced factorizations of Morse and Schilling [24], exhibited an explicit Demazure crystal structure on the set of RC graphs of a permutation w , thereby giving a representation-theoretic proof of Lascoux–Schützenberger key-positivity. It is this Demazure crystal structure on RC graphs that we will repeatedly invoke below.

The nonnegativity of the dual key structure constants $k_{a,b}^c$ of Theorem 5.4 is, in retrospect, a consequence of the theory of *excellent filtrations* for B -modules introduced by Polo [28] and van der Kallen [36], with existence of such filtrations on tensor products of Demazure modules established in general by Mathieu [23]; see also Joseph [15]. Restricting a Demazure module $V_c(\lambda)$ for GL_{p+q} to the Borel of the Levi $GL_p \times GL_q$ yields a B -module with an excellent filtration whose Demazure subquotients account for the $k_{a,b}^c$. This was pointed out by the anonymous user “Henry V” on MathOverflow [13]. While this abstract nonnegativity is classical, no explicit positive combinatorial rule for these coefficients appears in the literature to our knowledge.

5.1. Little bumps and the crystal action on RC graphs.

Definition 5.1.1 (Crystal action on RC graphs, highest weights, extremal weights). Following Morse and Schilling [24], who defined an $A_{\ell-1}$ -crystal structure on reduced factorizations of a permutation w , and the adaptation to RC graphs by Assaf and Schilling [1], we equip $\mathcal{RC}(w)$ with Kashiwara raising and lowering operators e_i, f_i for $i \geq 1$. The operator pair (e_i, f_i) acts only on rows i and $i+1$ of an RC graph R , viewed as adjacent factors in the corresponding reduced factorization.

The action is governed by a bracketing procedure on the column indices appearing in rows i and $i+1$. Process the entries of row i in decreasing order of column index: for each column b in row i , pair it with the smallest column $a > b$ appearing in row $i+1$ that has not yet been paired in an earlier step; if no such a exists, b is left unpaired. Let $R_i(R)$ denote the set of unpaired column indices in row i , and $L_i(R)$ the set of unpaired column indices in row $i+1$.

If $R_i(R)$ is nonempty, $f_i(R)$ is obtained by removing the smallest unpaired entry $b \in R_i(R)$ from row i and inserting an entry into row $i+1$ at the largest column $b' < b$ such that b' does not already appear in row $i+1$; if $R_i(R) = \emptyset$ or no such b' exists, $f_i(R) = \emptyset$. Dually, if $L_i(R)$ is nonempty, $e_i(R)$ is obtained by removing the largest unpaired entry $a \in L_i(R)$ from row $i+1$ and inserting an entry into row i at the smallest column $a' > a$ such that a' does not already appear in row i ; if $L_i(R) = \emptyset$ or no such a' exists, $e_i(R) = \emptyset$.

The *weight* of R as an element of the crystal is simply $\text{wt}(R)$, the row weight itself. A *highest weight* element is an RC graph R with $e_i(R) = \emptyset$ for all $i \geq 1$. Every $R \in \mathcal{RC}(w)$ corresponds to a unique highest weight element $\mathbb{Y}(R)$, which can always be obtained by greedily applying available e_i until none apply. The *Demazure crystal* $\text{Dem}(R)$ generated by a highest weight $\mathbb{Y}(R)$ is the closure of $\{\mathbb{Y}(R)\}$ under the operators $\{f_i^k : i \geq 1, k \geq 0\}$ subject to the Demazure truncation rule of [1]. The *extremal weight* $\text{extwt}(R)$ of R is the weak composition that is the lexicographically smallest weight of any element of $\text{Dem}(R)$.

The significance of this elaborate structure is the following.

Theorem 5.1 ([18, 1]). *If $A \in \mathcal{BRC}$ is such that $\text{extwt}(A) = a$, then*

$$\kappa_a = \sum_{R \in \text{Dem}(A)} x^{\text{wt}(R)}$$

It will be advantageous to have an alternative, crystal-friendly definition of the map $\mathcal{Z}$ for the purposes of proving results about key polynomials.

Definition 5.1.2 (Little bumps). Given a reduced word $a_1 \cdots a_m$ for a permutation w and an index $1 \leq p \leq m$, the *Little bump* $\text{little}_p(a_1 \cdots a_m)$ is defined recursively as follows. If $a_p > 1$, replace a_p with $a_p - 1$, and if $a_p = 1$ then instead replace all a_q with $q \neq p$ with $a_q + 1$. Denote the new word by $a'_1 \cdots a'_m$. If this resulting word is reduced, we are done. Otherwise, there is a unique index $j \neq p$ such that the word obtained by deleting a'_j from the new word is reduced by the deletion property of Coxeter groups. We then define

$$\text{little}_p(a_1 \cdots a_m) = \text{little}_j(a'_1 \cdots a'_m)$$

Definition 5.1.3 (Crystal-friendly transition map). Define a function $\mathcal{L} : \mathcal{BRC}^0(n) \rightarrow \mathcal{BRC}(n+1)$ as follows. Assume $n = \mathbf{m}(w_R)$, and suppose $\mathbf{rt}_R(i, j) = (n, n+1)$, where $i < n$. Set

$$R' = (R \setminus \{(i, j)\}) \cup \{(n, 1)\}$$

Then define

$$\mathcal{L}(R) = (i \xrightarrow{n-1} R') \setminus \{(n, 1)\}$$

which we assign height $n+1$. Then define $\mathcal{Z} : \mathcal{BRC}^0(n) \rightarrow \mathcal{BRC}(n-1)$ by iterating $\mathcal{L}$ and stopping as soon as the result has $\mathbf{m}(w_R) \leq n-1$, then reducing the number of rows to $n-1$.

Proposition 5.1.4. *Let $(R, n) \in \mathcal{BRC}^0(n)$ be a bounded RC graph such that $\mathbf{m}(w_R) = n$. Suppose*

$$\text{word}(R) = a_1 a_2 \cdots a_k$$

and

$$\text{seq}(R) = r_1 r_2 \cdots r_k$$

suppose $\mathbf{rt}_R(i, j) = (n, n+1)$, and let p be the index such that $r_p = i$ and $r_p + j - 1 = a_p$. Then

$$\text{word}(\mathcal{L}(R)) = \text{little}_p(\text{word}(R))$$

Proof. Consider the biword

$$\begin{array}{cccccccc} r_1 & r_2 & \cdots & r_{p-1} & r_p & r_{p+1} & \cdots & r_k \\ a_1 & a_2 & \cdots & a_{p-1} & a_p & a_{p+1} & \cdots & a_k \end{array}$$

The first deletion yields

$$\begin{array}{cccccccc} r_1 & r_2 & \cdots & r_{p-1} & r_{p+1} & \cdots & r_k & n \\ a_1 & a_2 & \cdots & a_{p-1} & a_{p+1} & \cdots & a_k & n \end{array}$$

Necessarily, we must have $a_p > 1$. To see this, note that if we have $a_p = 1$, then we would have $r_p = 1$ by the compatible sequence condition. The only way for position $(1, 1)$ in an RC graph to be the final right descent is if it is the unique right descent. By assumption, that descent would have to be n , so that $n = 1$. In that case, however, it would not be possible for the last row to be empty, which is included in the hypotheses of the proposition.

We must also have that $r_p < a_p$, because there is a sequence of chute moves involving this crossing that moves it to position $(n, 1)$ by [3, Theorem 3.7]. Assume first that $p = k$. Then the insertion algorithm will insert $a_p - 1 = n - 1$ into row r_k . If this word is reduced, then we are done, and this clearly coincides with the Little bump. If it is not reduced, the descent $n - 1$ occurs somewhere to the left, say at position j . The insertion algorithm would delete this letter then try to insert another one. Recursively, this is the same as applying $\mathcal{L}$ to the biword obtained by removing all letters after position j and then reinserting them afterwards. By the inductive hypothesis, this coincides with applying the Little bump at position j , which would indeed be the next step in the recursion of applying the Little bump at position k . Thus, the two coincide by induction. $\square$

We invoke the following theorem of Hamaker and Young.

Theorem 5.2 ([12, Theorem 4.4]). *Let w be a reduced word for a permutation $w \in S_\infty$. Then*

$$Q(w) = Q(\text{little}_p(w))$$

for any valid p , where Q denotes the Edelman-Green recording tableau [9].

Proposition 5.1.5. *We have that*

$$\mathcal{Z} : \mathcal{RC}_n(w)^0 \rightarrow \bigcup_{w \xrightarrow{n} w'} \mathcal{RC}_{n-1}(w')$$

is an isomorphism of crystal graphs.

Proof. The fact that this is a weight-preserving bijection follows directly from repeated application of [20, Lemma 7], which states that the Little bump on the last descent realizes the Lascoux-Schützenberger transition formula. The crystal isomorphism follows from Theorem 5.2. $\square$

Proposition 5.1.6. *We have the equality $\mathcal{Z} = \mathcal{Z}$.*

Proof. Let R be a bounded RC graph, say with permutation w , with r rows and last descent r such that row r is empty. We prove this by induction on $\ell(w)$ as well as on $s - r$, where $s > r$ is the maximal index such that $w(r) > w(s)$. If $s = r + 1$, then the definitions of the two maps are identical.

By the exchange property of Coxeter groups, there is a unique pair (i, j) such that $\mathbf{rt}_R(i, j) = (r, r + 1)$. Set

$$R' = R \setminus \{(i, j)\}$$

and assume that $\mathbf{ht}(R') = r + 1$. By the inductive hypothesis, we have $\mathcal{Z}(R') = \mathcal{Z}(R')$. We have thus established that $\mathcal{Z}$ and $\mathcal{Z}$ induce the same bijection between $\mathcal{RC}(ws_r)^0$ and

$$\bigcup_{ws_r \xrightarrow[r+1]{\searrow} w'} \mathcal{RC}(w')$$

Inspection of both algorithms reveals that the removal of this crossing and the subsequent reinsertion in the first step of both algorithms is precisely the same, and holding this fixed then applying the inductive hypothesis yields the result. $\square$

Corollary 5.1.7 ($\mathcal{Z}$ intertwines with crystal operators). *For any bounded RC graph R and any positive integer i satisfying $1 \leq i \leq \mathbf{ht}(R) - 1$, we have*

$$\mathcal{Z}(e_i(R)) = e_i(\mathcal{Z}(R))$$

and

$$\mathcal{Z}(f_i(R)) = f_i(\mathcal{Z}(R))$$

whenever the left-hand sides are defined.

Proof. This follows from Proposition 5.1.6 and the fact that $\mathcal{Z}$ is a crystal isomorphism by Proposition 5.1.5. $\square$

5.2. The dual key basis and the ring of RC graph crystals.

Definition 5.2.1 (The dual key basis). For a weak composition a of length n , define $\kappa_a^* \in \mathcal{D}_n$ to be the unique element such that $\langle \kappa_a^*, \kappa_b \rangle = \delta_{a,b}$ for all weak compositions b .

Theorem 5.3. *Let c be a weak composition. Then the dual key polynomial κ_c^* is equal to*

$$\kappa_c^* = \sum_{\substack{R = \mathbb{Y}(R) \\ \text{extwt}(R) = c}} \Xi_{w_R}^{\mathbf{ht}(R)}$$

Proof. The statement of the theorem is equivalent to Lascoux and Schützenberger's formula for Schubert polynomials in terms of key polynomials through Theorem 5.1. $\square$

Definition 5.2.2 (The submodule $\Theta \subseteq \mathcal{BRC}$). Let Θ be the $\mathbb{Z}$ -submodule of $\mathcal{BRC}$ generated by the elements $R_1 - R_2$ such that $\mathbb{Y}(R_1) = \mathbb{Y}(R_2)$.

Lemma 5.2.3. Θ is a two-sided ideal of $\mathcal{BRC}$.

Proof. Let R_1, R_2 be bounded RC graphs of height n with $\mathbb{Y}(R_1) = \mathbb{Y}(R_2)$, and let R be a bounded RC graph of height m . Since crystal operators preserve the permutation, $w_{R_1} = w_{R_2}$.

Left ideal. A bounded RC graph R' of height $m + n$ is a term of $R \boxplus R_1$ if and only if $\mathbf{trim}^m(R') = R_1$ and $\mathbf{clip}^m(R') = R$. Writing $R' = T \cup \uparrow^m R_1$ with $T = R'_{\leq m}$, the second condition depends only on T (Lemma 4.4.7), and $T \cup \uparrow^m R_1$ is a bounded RC graph if and only if the word of T followed by the word of $\uparrow^m R_1$ is reduced and the resulting permutation has last descent at most $m + n$; this depends on R_1 only through $w_{R_1} = w_{R_2}$. Hence $T \cup \uparrow^m R_1 \mapsto T \cup \uparrow^m R_2$ is a bijection from the terms of $R \boxplus R_1$ to those of $R \boxplus R_2$. For $i > m$ the operators e_i act on rows $i, i + 1$ only, so $e_i(T \cup \uparrow^m R_1) = T \cup \uparrow^m e_{i-m}(R_1)$, with either side

defined if and only if the other is. Applying the raising operators that carry R_1 to $\mathbb{Y}(R_1)$ and using that the highest weight of a connected component is unique,

$$\mathbb{Y}(T \cup \uparrow^m R_1) = \mathbb{Y}(T \cup \uparrow^m \mathbb{Y}(R_1)) = \mathbb{Y}(T \cup \uparrow^m \mathbb{Y}(R_2)) = \mathbb{Y}(T \cup \uparrow^m R_2).$$

Thus $R \sqcup R_1 - R \sqcup R_2 = \sum_T ((T \cup \uparrow^m R_1) - (T \cup \uparrow^m R_2)) \in \Theta$.

Right ideal. Since R_1 and R_2 lie in the same connected component, it suffices to treat $R_2 = e_i(R_1)$ for some $1 \leq i \leq n-1$ (the case $R_2 = f_i(R_1)$ is symmetric). For R' of height $n+m$ with $\text{trim}^n(R') = R$, the operator e_i ($i \leq n-1$) acts on rows $i, i+1 \leq n$, so $\text{trim}^n(e_i R') = R$ when $e_i R'$ is defined, and $\text{clip}^n(e_i R') = e_i(\text{clip}^n R')$ by Corollary 5.1.7 applied to each $\mathcal{Z}$ step of each one-row clip in Definition 4.4.2 (erasing a last row of index $> n$ commutes with e_i , and $\mathcal{Z}$ is a crystal isomorphism onto its image by Propositions 5.1.5 and 5.1.6, so e_i is defined on $\text{clip}^n R'$ if and only if it is defined on R'). Hence e_i restricts to a bijection from the terms of $R_1 \sqcup R$ onto the terms of $e_i(R_1) \sqcup R$, and corresponding terms R' , $e_i(R')$ have the same highest weight. Thus $R_1 \sqcup R - R_2 \sqcup R \in \Theta$. $\square$

Lemma 5.2.4. *The homomorphism $\alpha : \mathcal{BRC} \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$ factors through the quotient $\mathcal{BRC}/\Theta$.*

Proof. This is because the generators of Θ are all in Ω . $\square$

Definition 5.2.5. For a composition a , define an element $K_a \in \mathcal{BRC}/\Theta$ by

$$K_a = \sum_{\substack{R \in \text{Dem}_a \\ R = \mathbb{Y}(R)}} R$$

Proposition 5.2.6. *The elements $K_a \in \mathcal{BRC}/\Theta$ form an additive basis of a subring isomorphic to $\mathcal{D}$ under the homomorphism $\alpha : \mathcal{BRC}/\Theta \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$, and*

$$\alpha(K_a) = \kappa_a^*$$

Proof. The last statement is simply Theorem 5.3. The K_a actually consist of pairwise disjoint sets of RC graphs, the set of all such is clearly independent. To show that they span a subring, consider the homomorphism $\alpha : \mathcal{BRC}/\Theta \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$. We have that $\alpha(K_a) = \kappa_a^*$, and since these are linearly independent, it follows that the kernel of α intersects trivially with the span of the K_a . Since α is a homomorphism, it follows that α is injective on the span of the K_a , and since

$$\alpha(K_a) \sqcup \alpha(K_b) = \kappa_a^* \sqcup \kappa_b^* = \sum_c k_{ab}^c \kappa_c^* = \sum_c k_{a,b}^c \alpha(K_c),$$

it follows that $K_a \sqcup K_b$ is a linear combination of the K_c , so the span of the K_a is closed under multiplication, so that α is an isomorphism and we are done. $\square$

Theorem 5.4 (LR rule for dual keys). *Let a, b be weak compositions of lengths p and q , and let c be a weak composition of length $p+q$. Define integers $k_{a,b}^c$ by*

$$\kappa_a^* \sqcup \kappa_b^* = \sum_c k_{a,b}^c \kappa_c^*.$$

For any highest-weight RC graph C with $\text{extwt}(C) = c$, let $N(C)$ be the number of RC graphs R with $\mathbb{Y}(R) = C$ such that $\text{clip}^p(R)$ and $\text{trim}^q(R)$ are both highest weights and $\text{extwt}(\text{clip}^p(R)) = a$, $\text{extwt}(\text{trim}^q(R)) = b$. Then $N(C)$ depends only on (a, b, c) , and

$$k_{a,b}^c = N(C);$$

in particular $k_{a,b}^c \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$.

Proof of Theorem 5.4. The coefficient of K_c in $K_a \sqcup K_b$ is the same as the coefficient of κ_c^* in $\kappa_a^* \sqcup \kappa_b^*$, which is $k_{a,b}^c$ by definition. Since each of the summands of K_c that are Demazure crystals of RC graphs are distinct from the summands of any other key element and each other, we need only consider one of the summands to read off the coefficient. The result follows. $\square$

Example 5.2.7 (Computing $\kappa_a^* \sqcup \kappa_b^*$ for $a = (0, 1, 2)$, $b = (0, 1, 0, 2)$). Let $a = (0, 1, 2)$ (a 3-row composition) and $b = (0, 1, 0, 2)$ (a 4-row composition), so $p = 3$, $q = 4$, and $p+q = 7$. We illustrate the coefficient $k_{a,b}^c$ for $c = (0, 0, 0, 1, 2, 0, 3)$.

The permutation w_c whose principal RC graph has Demazure crystal highest weight c is

$$w_c = (1, 2, 3, 5, 7, 4, 10, 6, 8, 9).$$

The key element K_c is the sum of all 7-row RC graphs whose Demazure crystal highest weight equals c . Among these, exactly two satisfy $\text{clip}^3(R) \in \text{Dem}_a$ and $\text{trim}^3(R) \in \text{Dem}_b$:

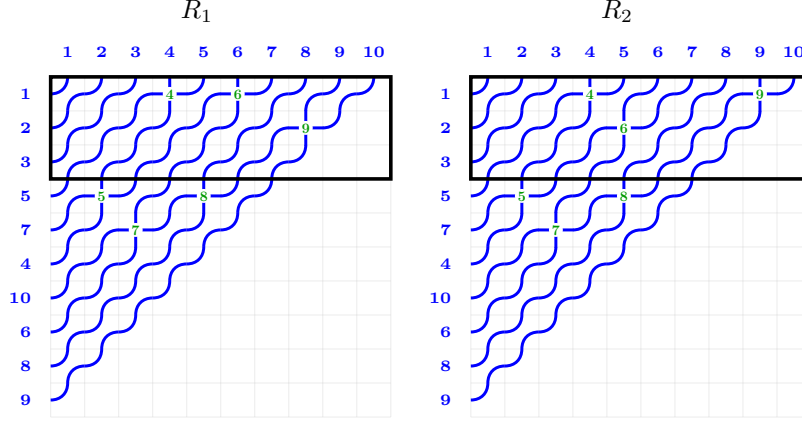


FIGURE 4. The two 7-row RC graphs R_1 (left) and R_2 (right) in Dem_c satisfying $\text{clip}^3(R_i) \in \text{Dem}_a$ and $\text{trim}^3(R_i) \in \text{Dem}_b$. The outlined box marks the top 3 rows (the clip region).

Both graphs have permutation $w_c = (1, 2, 3, 5, 7, 4, 10, 6, 8, 9)$. They differ only in their first two rows: R_1 has row data $[(6,4), (9,), ()]$ in the top three rows, while R_2 has $[(9,4), (6,), ()]$. Applying clip^3 (four one-row clips, which here amount to retaining the top 3 rows and applying $\mathcal{Z}$ until the height is 3; see Lemma 4.4.7) to each yields the same 3-row graph with extremal weight $a = (0, 1, 2)$:

$$\text{clip}^3(R_1) = \text{clip}^3(R_2) =$$

the notation to $P_{\mathfrak{P}}(\mathbf{r})$. The equivalence classes consist of words that are all for the same permutation, so that if we define

$$R \equiv_{\mathfrak{P}} R'$$

to mean that $P_{\mathfrak{P}}(\text{word}(R)) = P_{\mathfrak{P}}(\text{word}(R'))$, then the forest polynomials partition the set of RC graphs for the given permutation. The forest polynomials are indexed in the original work by “indexed forests,” hence the name. These correspond bijectively to weak compositions, so we can define a weak composition $\mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R)$ by associating an indexed forest to this equivalence class as in the article. Define $\mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(a)$ for a composition a to be the set of equivalence classes of RC graphs under this relation such that $\mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R) = a$.

6.1. Indexed forests, forest invariant.

Definition 6.1.1 (Indexed forests and codes). An *indexed forest* F is a pair $(S, T_{\bullet})$ where S is a set of positive integers, called the *support* of F . Writing

$$S = I_1 \cup I_2 \cup \cdots \cup I_k$$

where $I_1, I_2, \dots, I_k$ are the maximal intervals contained in S , we have $T_{\bullet}$ as a sequence of binary trees $T_1, T_2, \dots, T_k$ where T_j has $|I_j|$ internal nodes for each j . The internal nodes of F are denoted by $\text{IN}(F)$. For $v \in \text{IN}(F)$, we denote by $\text{left}(v)$ and $\text{right}(v)$ the left and right children of v respectively, which may not be in $\text{IN}(F)$ if they are leaves, or may be empty.

There is a natural labeling $\lambda_F : \text{IN}(F) \rightarrow S$ sending each internal node, say $v \in T_j$, to the unique element of I_j that is at the same index as $v \in T_j$ in the inorder traversal of T_j .

The function $\rho_F : \text{IN}(F) \rightarrow S$ is defined for an internal node $v \in T_j$ by

$$\rho_F(v) = \begin{cases} \lambda_F(v) & \text{if } \text{left}(v) \notin \text{IN}(F) \\ \lambda_F(\text{left}(v)) & \text{if } \text{left}(v) \in \text{IN}(F). \end{cases}$$

For each indexed forest F , we assign a weak composition $\mathfrak{c}(F)$ by

$$\mathfrak{c}_j(F) = \#\{v \in \text{IN}(F) : \rho_F(v) = j\}$$

Then the *forest polynomial* $\mathfrak{P}_F(x)$ is defined by

$$\mathfrak{P}_F(x) = \sum_{\tau} \prod_{v \in \text{IN}(F)} x_{\tau(v)}$$

where the sum is over all functions $\tau : \text{IN}(F) \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ such that $\tau(v) \leq \rho_F(v)$ for all $v \in \text{IN}(F)$, $\tau(v) \leq \tau(\text{left}(v))$ for all $v \in \text{IN}(F)$ such that $\text{left}(v) \in \text{IN}(F)$, and $\tau(v) < \tau(\text{right}(v))$ for all $v \in \text{IN}(F)$ such that $\text{right}(v) \in \text{IN}(F)$.

It is easiest for our purposes to index forest polynomials by weak compositions rather than indexed forests, so we define $\mathfrak{P}_a(x) = \mathfrak{P}_F(x)$ where F is the unique indexed forest such that $\mathfrak{c}(F) = a$.

Definition 6.1.2 (Injective words, forest invariant). In [27], an alphabet $\overline{\mathbb{Z}}$ is defined as the set of pairs of integers (i, j) in lexicographical order, written with the notation $i^{[j]}$. They define $\text{val}(i^{[j]}) = i$. An *injective word* is a word $w = w_1 w_2 \cdots w_k$ such that $w_i \neq w_j$ for all $i \neq j$. An *LBS (local binary search) labeling* of an indexed forest F is an injective function $\rho : \text{IN}(F) \rightarrow \overline{\mathbb{Z}}$ such that

- (1) $\rho(\text{left}(v)) < \rho(v)$ for all $v \in \text{IN}(F)$ such that $\text{left}(v) \in \text{IN}(F)$.
- (2) $\rho(v) < \rho(\text{right}(v))$ for all $v \in \text{IN}(F)$ such that $\text{right}(v) \in \text{IN}(F)$.
- (3) For all $v \in \text{IN}(F)$, $\text{val}(\rho(v)) = \lambda_F(u)$ for some $u \in \text{IN}(F)$.

Following [26], given any injective word $w = w_1 \cdots w_m$ in $\overline{\mathbb{Z}}$, we associate to it inductively an indexed forest $F(w)$, an LBS labeling $P(w)$ of $F(w)$, and an injective “time-stamp” labeling $Q(w) : \text{IN}(F(w)) \rightarrow \{1, \dots, m\}$ as follows. If $m = 0$, then $F(w)$ is the empty forest. Otherwise write $w = w' a$ with $w' = w_1 \cdots w_{m-1}$, and assume $F' := F(w')$, $P' := P(w')$, and $Q' := Q(w')$ have already been constructed; let S' be the support of F' , and let $S' = I_1 \cup \cdots \cup I_k$ be its decomposition into maximal intervals (listed left to right). For each j , denote by u_j the root of the tree of F' supported on I_j , and set $a_j := P'(u_j)$. We obtain $F(w)$ by adjoining a new internal node u to F' , with attachments determined by $i := \text{val}(a)$:

- If $i \notin S'$, then u is the root of a new tree, with left child u_j when $i - 1 \in I_j$ (otherwise no left child), and right child u_j when $i + 1 \in I_j$ (otherwise no right child).
- If $i \in I_j$, then we compare a with a_j in the order on $\overline{\mathbb{Z}}$:

- if $a > a_j$, then u_j becomes the left child of u ; additionally, if $\max(I_j) + 2 \in S'$ (necessarily $\max(I_j) + 2 = \min(I_{j+1})$), then u_{j+1} becomes the right child of u ;
- if $a < a_j$, then u_j becomes the right child of u ; additionally, if $\min(I_j) - 2 \in S'$ (necessarily $\min(I_j) - 2 = \max(I_{j-1})$), then u_{j-1} becomes the left child of u .

The remaining roots of F' become roots of $F(w)$ unchanged. We then extend P' to $P(w)$ by setting $P(w)(u) := a$, and extend Q' to $Q(w)$ by setting $Q(w)(u) := m$. The pair $(P(w), Q(w))$ is the Ω -insertion of w .

The importance of this algorithm is

Theorem 6.1 ([26, Theorem 5.1]). *The correspondence $w \mapsto (P(w), Q(w))$ is a bijection between the following two sets:*

- (1) *Injective words w with letters in $\overline{\mathbb{Z}}$, and*
- (2) *Pairs (P, Q) such that $P \in \text{LBS}(F)$ and $Q \in \text{Dec}(F)$ for a common indexed forest F .*

Definition 6.1.3 (Injectification, $\equiv_{\mathfrak{P}}$). For a word $\mathbf{r}$ in the alphabet $\mathbb{Z}$, we may canonically turn $\mathbf{r}$ into an injective word in the alphabet $\overline{\mathbb{Z}}$ by assigning superscripts consecutively starting at 1 to break ties between equal letters.

Let $\mathbf{r}_1$ and $\mathbf{r}_2$ be reduced words. Then we say that $\mathbf{r}_1 \equiv_{\mathfrak{P}} \mathbf{r}_2$ if $P(\overline{\mathbf{r}}_1) = P(\overline{\mathbf{r}}_2)$. Naturally, we may apply this to RC graphs as well: for RC graphs R_1 and R_2 , we say that $R_1 \equiv_{\mathfrak{P}} R_2$ if $\text{word}(R_1) \equiv_{\mathfrak{P}} \text{word}(R_2)$. For a permutation w , we denote by $\mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(w)$ the set of equivalence classes of reduced words for w under $\equiv_{\mathfrak{P}}$.

Theorem 6.2 ([26, Theorem 1.4]). *Let $w \in S_{\infty}$. Then we have*

$$\mathfrak{S}_w(x) = \sum_{C \in \mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(w)} \mathfrak{P}_{c_{\mathfrak{P}}(C)}(x)$$

6.2. The dual forest basis and the ring of forest classes of RC graphs.

Definition 6.2.1 (The dual forest basis). For a weak composition a of length n , define $\mathfrak{P}_a^* \in \mathcal{D}_n$ to be the unique element such that $\langle \mathfrak{P}_a^*, \mathfrak{P}_b \rangle = \delta_{a,b}$ for all weak compositions b .

We record the result that the coefficients of $\mathfrak{P}_c^*$ in the monomial-dual basis are exactly the forest expansion coefficients of monomials computed by Nadeau, Spink, and Tewari, and that under the Borel-type isomorphism $H^{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_n) \cong \mathbb{Z}[x_1, \dots, x_n]/\text{QSym}_n^+$ of [4] the same integers compute the cap product against the geometric homology basis $\{[X(F)]\}$ of $H_{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_n)$.

Proposition 6.2.2. *Let a be a weak composition of length n , and let F_a denote the corresponding indexed forest. Let $\{e_{\mathbf{b}}\}_{\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}^n}$ denote the basis of $\mathcal{D}_n$ dual to the monomial basis $\{x^{\mathbf{b}}\}$ of $\mathcal{A}_n$. Then*

$$\mathfrak{P}_a^* = \sum_{\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}^n} \epsilon_{F_a}(\mathbf{b}) e_{\mathbf{b}} \in \mathcal{D}_n,$$

where $\epsilon_{F_a}(\mathbf{b}) \in \{-1, 0, +1\}$ is the path sign of [25, Proposition 10.15].

The same integers admit two further interpretations:

- (1) (Volume polynomial / Postnikov–Stanley-style dual.) The volume polynomial $V_{F_a}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}) \in \mathbb{Q}[\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n]$ of [25, Section 10.5], which is dual to $\mathfrak{P}_{F_a}$ under the divided-power D -pairing of loc. cit., expands as

$$V_{F_a}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}) = \sum_{\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}^n} \epsilon_{F_a}(\mathbf{b}) \frac{\boldsymbol{\lambda}^{\mathbf{b}}}{\mathbf{b}!} \quad ([25, \text{Proposition 10.14}]).$$

Up to the divided-power normalization, $V_{F_a}(\boldsymbol{\lambda})$ and $\mathfrak{P}_a^*$ are the same linear functional on $\mathcal{A}_n$, in exact analogy with the relationship between the Postnikov–Stanley dual Schubert polynomials [29] and our Ξ_u^n noted in the introduction.

- (2) (Geometric Kronecker dual on QFl_n .) Under the Borel isomorphism $\pi_n : \mathcal{A}_n \twoheadrightarrow \mathcal{A}_n/\text{QSym}_n^+ \cdot \mathcal{A}_n \cong H^{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_n)$ of [4, Theorem A and Corollary 12.5], the dual functional $\mathfrak{P}_a^*$ kills the kernel ideal and descends to the Kronecker dual of $[\mathfrak{P}_{F_a}] \in H^{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_n)$ paired against the homology basis $\{[X(F)] : F \in \text{Forest}_n\}$ of [4, Corollary 11.6]. Concretely, for $F_a \in \text{Forest}_n$,

$$\mathfrak{P}_a^* = \pi_n^*([X(F_a)]) \quad \text{in } \mathcal{D}_n,$$

and equivalently

$$\int_{X(F_a)} \overline{x^{\mathbf{b}}} = \epsilon_{F_a}(\mathbf{b}) \quad \text{in } H^\bullet(\mathbf{QFl}_n)$$

for all $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}^n$, where $\overline{x^{\mathbf{b}}} = \pi_n(x^{\mathbf{b}})$. For a with $F_a \notin \text{Forest}_n$ both sides vanish: $\mathfrak{P}_{F_a} \in \text{QSym}_n^+ \cdot \mathcal{A}_n$ by [25, Theorem 9.7], so $\mathfrak{P}_a^*$ vanishes on this submodule.

Proof. The first identity is immediate: applying $\mathfrak{P}_a^*$ to the forest expansion of monomials $x^{\mathbf{b}} = \sum_G \epsilon_G(\mathbf{b}) \mathfrak{P}_G$ [25, Proposition 10.15] gives $\langle \mathfrak{P}_a^*, x^{\mathbf{b}} \rangle = \sum_G \epsilon_G(\mathbf{b}) \langle \mathfrak{P}_a^*, \mathfrak{P}_G \rangle = \epsilon_{F_a}(\mathbf{b})$ by the defining duality $\langle \mathfrak{P}_a^*, \mathfrak{P}_b \rangle = \delta_{a,b}$.

Item (1) is then a direct comparison of [25, Proposition 10.14] with the displayed expansion.

For item (2), the splitting $\mathcal{A}_n = \bigoplus_{F_a \in \text{Forest}_n} \mathbb{Z} \mathfrak{P}_a \oplus \text{QSym}_n^+ \cdot \mathcal{A}_n$ [25, Theorem 9.7] forces $\mathfrak{P}_a^*$ to annihilate the kernel of π_n when $F_a \in \text{Forest}_n$, hence to factor through π_n . The induced functional pairs with $[\mathfrak{P}_b]$ to $\delta_{a,b}$, which is precisely the defining property of $[X(F_a)]$ [4, Theorem 12.12], so $\mathfrak{P}_a^* = \pi_n^*([X(F_a)])$. The second equality of item (2) is then the previous display read modulo $\text{QSym}_n^+ \cdot \mathcal{A}_n$. $\square$

In particular, the algebraic dual basis $\{\mathfrak{P}_a^*\} \subset \mathcal{D}_n$ and the geometric homology basis $\{[X(F)]\} \subset H_\bullet(\mathbf{QFl}_n)$ are not merely Kronecker-dual to the same basis: they are the same linear functional on $\mathcal{A}_n$, viewed once before and once after passing to the Borel quotient. The bialgebra structure on $\mathcal{D}$ and the geometric coproduct on $\bigoplus_n H_\bullet(\mathbf{QFl}_n)$ induced by the variable-splitting comorphism $\iota_{p,q}^*$ of Section 6.3 are correspondingly related: $\pi^* = \bigoplus_n \pi_n^*$ identifies the geometric coproduct with the restriction of the concatenation coproduct on $\mathcal{D}$ to $\bigoplus_n \pi_n^*(H_\bullet(\mathbf{QFl}_n))$.

Theorem 6.3. *We have the following.*

I Let $R \in \mathcal{BRC}$ be a bounded RC graph. Then the forest polynomial $\mathfrak{P}_{\mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R)}$ is equal to

$$\mathfrak{P}_{\mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R)}(x) = \sum_{R' \equiv_{\mathfrak{P}} R} x^{\mathbf{wt}(R')}$$

II Let c be a weak composition. Then the dual forest polynomial $\mathfrak{P}_c^$ is equal to*

$$\mathfrak{P}_c^* = \sum_{[R] \in \mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(c)} \Xi_{w_R}^{\mathbf{ht}(R)}$$

Proof of Theorem 6.3. Part I of this theorem follows from the fact that for any equivalence class of words W that have the same P -LBS, $\mathfrak{P}_{\mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(W)}(x)$ is the sum of the compatible sequences on the words in W ([26, Proposition 5.10]), which are simply the RC graphs in the corresponding equivalence class of RC graphs. Part II follows from Theorem 6.2 and the definition of the dual Schubert basis. $\square$

Guo and Woodruff [11] also published an alternative RC graph formula for forest polynomials.

Proposition 6.2.3. *Let c be a weak composition of length p . Let $\mathcal{RC}_{\mathfrak{P}}(c)$ be the set of RC graphs with $\mathbf{wt}(R) = c$ such that $\text{word}(\mathbb{Y}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R))$ is minimal in lexicographical order among all RC graphs R' such that $\mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R) = \mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R')$.*

$$[c] = \sum_{R \in \mathcal{RC}_{\mathfrak{P}}(c)} \mathfrak{P}_{\mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R)}^*$$

Remark. The coefficients of the expansion of a monomial into forest polynomials, or equivalently the coefficients of the expansion of a dual forest polynomial into weak composition monomials, is given in [26, Proposition 10.15].

Definition 6.2.4 (The submodule $\Gamma \subseteq \mathcal{BRC}$). Let Γ be the $\mathbb{Z}$ -submodule of $\mathcal{BRC}$ generated by the elements $R_1 - R_2$ such that $R_1 \equiv_{\mathfrak{P}} R_2$.

Lemma 6.2.5. Γ is a two-sided ideal of $\mathcal{BRC}$.

Proof. The fact that Γ is a left ideal follows from the fact that the products $R \sqcup R_1$ and $R \sqcup R_2$ have the same first $\mathbf{ht}(R)$ rows, and the rows below are simply shifts of R_1 and R_2 . In terms of the resulting words, the shifted $\text{word}(R_1)$ and $\text{word}(R_2)$ are suffixes of $\text{word}(R \sqcup R_1)$ and $\text{word}(R \sqcup R_2)$. The $\equiv_{\mathfrak{P}}$ equivalence is determined by local swaps of pairs of letters that are related in a shift-invariant [26, Proposition 5.8] and prefix-invariant [26, Lemma 5.9] way, from which the result follows, since the prefixes are identical and the suffixes are related in the same way as $\text{word}(R_1)$ and $\text{word}(R_2)$.

To prove that Γ is a right ideal, assume $\text{word}(R_1)$ and $\text{word}(R_2)$ differ by a single local swap of adjacent letters a and b in the same equivalence class, with a to the left of b in $\text{word}(R_1)$ and to the right of b in $\text{word}(R_2)$. It suffices to consider only the case where R is empty to show that

$$R_1 \sqcup R - R_2 \sqcup R \in \Gamma$$

for any R . According to [26], the local swap of a and b is a commutation move, and we may reduce to the case where a and b are the last two letters of $\text{word}(R_1)$, and that b is the last descent of w_{R_1} . For any empty R , the position a will remain the same. For any term not identical to R_1 , the suffix of the word will be ab' where $b' > b$. For each b' , there will be precisely one matching term with suffix $b'a$ and identical prefix. The local swap of a and b' in the suffix is a valid local swap, so the resulting terms are all in Γ , and we are done. $\square$

Lemma 6.2.6. *The homomorphism $\alpha : \mathcal{BRC} \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$ factors through the quotient $\mathcal{BRC}/\Gamma$.*

Proof. This is because the generators of Γ are all in Ω . $\square$

Definition 6.2.7. For a composition a , define an element $F_a \in \mathcal{BRC}/\Gamma$ by

$$F_a = \sum_{[R] \in \mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(a)} [R]$$

Proposition 6.2.8. *The elements $F_a \in \mathcal{BRC}/\Gamma$ form an additive basis of a subring isomorphic to $\mathcal{D}$ under the homomorphism $\alpha : \mathcal{BRC}/\Gamma \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$, and*

$$\alpha(F_a) = \mathfrak{P}_a^*$$

Proof. As before, the last statement is simply Theorem 6.3. The F_a actually consist of pairwise disjoint sets of RC graphs, the set of all such is clearly independent. To show that they span a subring, consider the homomorphism $\alpha : \mathcal{BRC}/\Gamma \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$. We have that $\alpha(F_a) = \mathfrak{P}_a^*$, and since these are linearly independent, it follows that the kernel of α intersects trivially with the span of the F_a . Since α is a homomorphism, it follows that α is injective on the span of the F_a , and since

$$\alpha(F_a) \sqcup \alpha(F_b) = \mathfrak{P}_a^* \sqcup \mathfrak{P}_b^* = \sum_c f_{ab}^c \mathfrak{P}_c^* = \sum_c f_{a,b}^c \alpha(F_c),$$

it follows that $F_a \sqcup F_b$ is a linear combination of the F_c , so the span of the F_a is closed under multiplication, so that α is an isomorphism and we are done. $\square$

Theorem 6.4 (LR rule for dual forests). *Let a, b be weak compositions of lengths p and q , and let c be a weak composition of length $p + q$. Define integers $f_{a,b}^c$ by*

$$\mathfrak{P}_a^* \sqcup \mathfrak{P}_b^* = \sum_c f_{a,b}^c \mathfrak{P}_c^*.$$

For any $C \in \mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(c)$, let $N(C)$ be the number of $R \in [C]$ such that $\text{clip}^p(R) \in \mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(a)$, $\text{trim}^q(R) \in \mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(b)$, $\text{wt}(\text{clip}^p(R)) = a$, and $\text{wt}(\text{trim}^q(R)) = b$. Then $N(C)$ depends only on (a, b, c) , and

$$f_{a,b}^c = N(C);$$

in particular $f_{a,b}^c \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$.

Proof of Theorem 6.4. The coefficient of F_c in $F_a \sqcup F_b$ is the same as the coefficient of $\mathfrak{P}_c^*$ in $\mathfrak{P}_a^* \sqcup \mathfrak{P}_b^*$, which is $f_{a,b}^c$ by definition. Since each of the summands of F_c that are equivalence classes of RC graphs are distinct from the summands of any other forest element and each other, we need only consider one of the summands to read off the coefficient. The result follows. $\square$

Example 6.2.9 (Computing $\mathfrak{P}_a^* \sqcup \mathfrak{P}_b^*$ for $a = (0, 0, 2, 0, 2)$, $b = (0, 1, 0, 0, 2)$). Let

$$a = (0, 0, 2, 0, 2), \quad b = (0, 1, 0, 0, 2), \quad c = (0, 0, 1, 0, 1, 0, 2, 0, 0, 3).$$

Here $p = q = 5$, so by Theorem 6.4 the coefficient $f_{a,b}^c$ counts the R in a fixed forest class $\mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(c)$ of 10-row RC graphs satisfying

$$\text{clip}^5(R) \in \mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(a), \quad \text{trim}^5(R) \in \mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(b), \quad \text{wt}(\text{clip}^5(R)) = a, \quad \text{wt}(\text{trim}^5(R)) = b.$$

Writing an RC graph as the set of ordered pairs $(i, j) \in \mathbb{Z}_{>0} \times \mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ recording the (row, column) of each crossing, there are exactly two such R , namely

$$\begin{aligned} R_1 &= \{(3, 1), (3, 2), (5, 3), (5, 8), (7, 1), (10, 1), (10, 2)\}, \\ R_2 &= \{(3, 1), (3, 6), (5, 1), (5, 8), (7, 1), (10, 1), (10, 2)\}. \end{aligned}$$

Both have permutation

$$w_{R_1} = w_{R_2} = (1, 2, 4, 3, 6, 5, 9, 7, 8, 13, 10, 11, 12),$$

and they share a common clip/trim pair

$$\text{clip}^5(R_i) = \{(3, 1), (3, 2), (5, 1), (5, 2)\}, \quad \text{trim}^5(R_i) = \{(2, 1), (5, 1), (5, 2)\},$$

with $\text{wt}(\text{clip}^5(R_i)) = a$ and $\text{wt}(\text{trim}^5(R_i)) = b$.

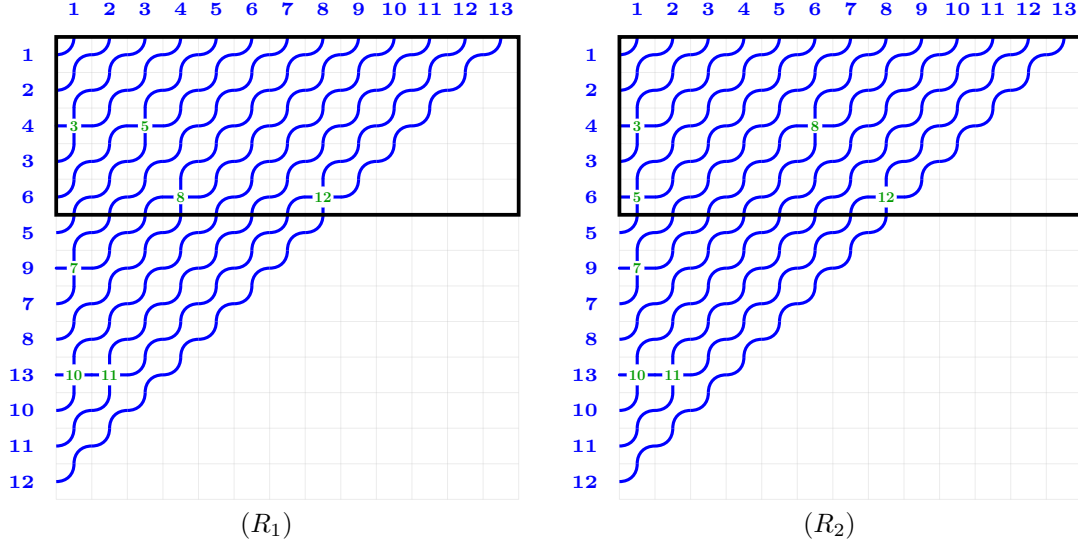


FIGURE 5. The two 10-row witness pipe dreams in the forest class for c .

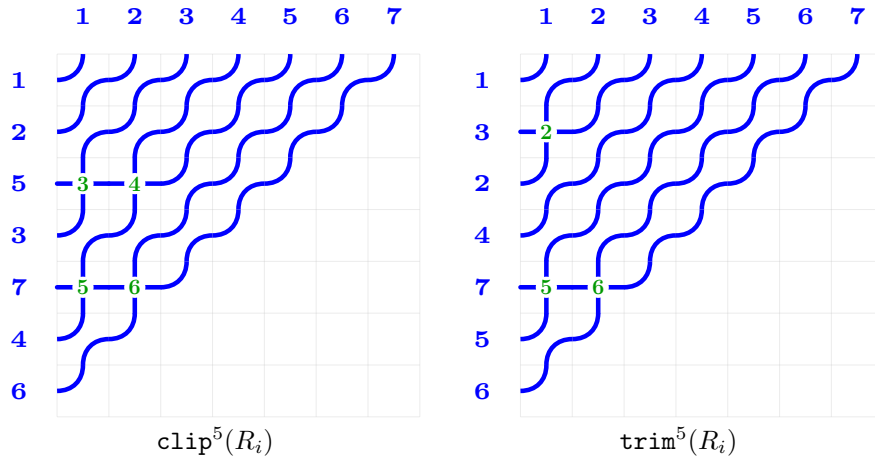


FIGURE 6. Common clip/trim pair for both witnesses R_1, R_2 .

Therefore Theorem 6.4 gives

$$f_{a,b}^c = 2.$$

6.3. Geometric interpretation: branching on the quasisymmetric flag variety. The forest polynomials acquire a geometric meaning through the work of Bergeron, Gagnon, Nadeau, Spink, and Tewari [4], who introduce the *quasisymmetric flag variety* $\mathbf{QFl}_n \subset \mathbf{Fl}_n$, a (reducible) toric complex built as a union of left-translated Richardson varieties indexed by n -leaf planar binary trees. Their main results give a Borel-type presentation

$$H^\bullet(\mathbf{QFl}_n) \cong \mathbb{Z}[x_1, \dots, x_n] / \mathbf{QSym}_n^+,$$

where $\mathbf{QSym}_n^+$ is the ideal of quasisymmetric polynomials with no constant term [4, Theorem A and Corollary 12.5], and identify the forest polynomials $\{\mathfrak{P}_F : F \in \mathbf{Forest}_n\}$ as a free $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of this ring [4, Corollary 12.5], Kronecker dual to the homology basis $\{[X(F)] : F \in \mathbf{Forest}_n\}$ of $H_\bullet(\mathbf{QFl}_n)$ [4, Corollary 11.6, Theorem 12.12]. Under the standard bijection between $\mathbf{Forest}_n$ and weak compositions of length n (compare [26]), the basis $\mathfrak{P}_F$ matches our composition-indexed basis $\mathfrak{P}_a$; we write $[\mathfrak{P}_a] = \pi_n(\mathfrak{P}_a)$ for the corresponding cohomology class.

The dual forest LR rule (Theorem 6.4) admits a geometric reading on $\mathbf{QFl}_n$. The variable-splitting substitution

$$\rho_{p,q} : \mathbb{Z}[x_1, \dots, x_{p+q}] \longrightarrow \mathbb{Z}[x_1, \dots, x_p] \otimes \mathbb{Z}[x_{p+1}, \dots, x_{p+q}]$$

descends to a well-defined ring homomorphism

$$\iota_{p,q}^* : H^\bullet(\mathbf{QFl}_{p+q}) \longrightarrow H^\bullet(\mathbf{QFl}_p) \otimes H^\bullet(\mathbf{QFl}_q).$$

Indeed, for $f \in \mathbf{QSym}_{p+q}^+$ the standard alphabet-sum identity for the $\mathbf{QSym}$ coproduct writes $\rho_{p,q}(f) = \sum f_{(1)}(x_1, \dots, x_p) \otimes f_{(2)}(x_{p+1}, \dots, x_{p+q})$ with each $f_{(1)}, f_{(2)}$ quasisymmetric in its variables; since $\deg f > 0$ and the degrees add, each term has at least one tensor factor in $\mathbf{QSym}^+$, so $\rho_{p,q}(f) \in \mathbf{QSym}_p^+ \otimes \mathbb{Z}[y] + \mathbb{Z}[x] \otimes \mathbf{QSym}_q^+$. The splitting reformulation of Theorem 6.4 then says exactly that, in the forest-polynomial basis,

$$\iota_{p,q}^* [\mathfrak{P}_c] = \sum_{a,b} f_{a,b}^c [\mathfrak{P}_a] \otimes [\mathfrak{P}_b] \quad \text{in } H^\bullet(\mathbf{QFl}_p) \otimes H^\bullet(\mathbf{QFl}_q),$$

and Theorem 6.4 gives an explicit positive cardinality formula for each $f_{a,b}^c$.

The map $\iota_{p,q}^*$ is the natural quasisymmetric-flag analogue of the type-A Levi comorphism $H^\bullet(\mathbf{Fl}_{p+q}) \rightarrow H^\bullet(\mathbf{Fl}_p) \otimes H^\bullet(\mathbf{Fl}_q)$ of [31], and the dual forest LR rule plays for it the role that Theorem 1.1 plays for the Schubert basis. We do not know whether $\iota_{p,q}^*$ is induced by a geometric embedding $\mathbf{QFl}_p \times \mathbf{QFl}_q \hookrightarrow \mathbf{QFl}_{p+q}$ compatible with the Levi inclusion $\mathbf{Fl}_p \times \mathbf{Fl}_q \hookrightarrow \mathbf{Fl}_{p+q}$; the natural concatenation operation $\mathbf{Forest}_p \times \mathbf{Forest}_q \rightarrow \mathbf{Forest}_{p+q}$ on indexed forests, and the resulting matching $X(F) \times X(F') \subset \mathbf{QFl}_{p+q}$ one expects on the toric Richardson side, suggest that such an embedding should exist, but we do not pursue the geometric verification here. At the level of cohomology rings $\iota_{p,q}^*$ is in any case a well-defined ring homomorphism, and Theorem 6.4 is, in this language, a manifestly positive branching Schubert calculus rule on the quasisymmetric flag variety, parallel to the one Theorem 1.1 provides on $\mathbf{Fl}_n$. Dually, the family $\{\iota_{p,q}^*\}_{p,q \geq 0}$ assembles into a graded coproduct on $\bigoplus_n H_\bullet(\mathbf{QFl}_n)$ whose structure constants in the geometric forest basis $\{[X(F)]\}$ are again the $f_{a,b}^c$ of Theorem 6.4.

7. PRODUCT RULE FOR DUAL SLIDE POLYNOMIALS

7.1. Slide polynomials.

Definition 7.1.1. For a word $\mathbf{r} = \mathbf{r}_1 \mathbf{r}_2 \cdots \mathbf{r}_k$, a sequence of positive integers $a_1 a_2 \cdots a_k$ is *compatible* with $\mathbf{r}$ if $a_i \leq \mathbf{r}_i$ for all i , $a_i \leq a_{i+1}$ for all i , and $a_i < a_{i+1}$ if $\mathbf{r}_i < \mathbf{r}_{i+1}$.

Slide polynomials $\mathfrak{F}(\mathbf{r})$ for a word $\mathbf{r}$ are defined by summing the monomials x^a over all compatible sequences a of $\mathbf{r}$.

Assaf and Searles [2] derived an expansion of Schubert polynomials in terms of slide polynomials as follows. A *quasi-Yamanouchi* RC graph is an RC graph R such that if R' is another RC graph with $\text{word}(R) = \text{word}(R')$ and $\text{ht}(R) = \text{ht}(R')$, then $\text{wt}(R) \leq \text{wt}(R')$ in dominance order and $\text{flat}(\text{wt}(R'))$ refines $\text{flat}(\text{wt}(R))$. The set of RC graphs A such that $\text{word}(A) = \text{word}(R)$ and $\text{ht}(A) = \text{ht}(R)$ is a partially ordered set with R as its smallest element. We then define

$$\mathbb{QY}(A) = R$$

Theorem 7.1 ([2, Theorem 3.13]). *For a permutation $w \in S_\infty$, we have the formula*

$$\mathfrak{S}_w(x) = \sum_R \mathfrak{F}_{\mathbf{wt}(R)}(x)$$

where the sum is over all quasi-Yamanouchi RC graphs R for w .

Corollary 7.1.2. *For a weak composition c of length p , we have the formula*

$$\mathfrak{F}_c^* = \sum_{R=\mathbb{QY}(R)} \Xi_{w_R}^p$$

where the sum is over all quasi-Yamanouchi RC graphs R such that $\mathbf{wt}(R) = c$.

Remark. The expansion of dual slides in the weak composition basis is given by the expansion of monomials into slides in [27, Theorem 5.2].

Definition 7.1.3 (The submodule $\Sigma \subseteq \mathcal{BRC}$). Let Σ be the $\mathbb{Z}$ -submodule of $\mathcal{BRC}$ generated by the elements $R_1 - R_2$ such that $\mathbb{QY}(R_1) = \mathbb{QY}(R_2)$.

Lemma 7.1.4. Σ is a two-sided ideal of $\mathcal{BRC}$.

Proof. That Σ is a left ideal follows from the same mechanism used for Θ (Lemma 5.2.3): the terms of $R \boxplus R_1$ and $R \boxplus R_2$ are in bijection $T \cup \uparrow^m R_1 \leftrightarrow T \cup \uparrow^m R_2$, since $w_{R_1} = w_{R_2}$, and the crystal operators e_i , $i > \mathbf{ht}(R)$, act on the trailing block exactly as on R_1, R_2 . The quasi-Yamanouchi map $\mathbb{QY}$ is defined by applying a sequence of crystal raising operators determined by the weight ([2]); hence applying $\mathbb{QY}$ to $R \boxplus R_1$ and to $R \boxplus R_2$ produces graphs whose trailing rows have a common partial quasi-Yamanouchi reduction $R \boxplus \mathbb{QY}(R_1) = R \boxplus \mathbb{QY}(R_2)$, and so $\mathbb{QY}(R \boxplus R_1) = \mathbb{QY}(R \boxplus R_2)$.

That Σ is a right ideal follows from Corollary 5.1.7: multiplication on the right by a fixed R induces an isomorphism of crystal graphs on the relevant subblock, and the $\mathbb{QY}$ images of corresponding terms therefore agree. $\square$

Lemma 7.1.5. *The homomorphism $\alpha : \mathcal{BRC} \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$ factors through the quotient $\mathcal{BRC}/\Sigma$.*

Proof. This is because the generators of Σ are all in Ω : if $\mathbb{QY}(R_1) = \mathbb{QY}(R_2)$ then $w_{R_1} = w_{\mathbb{QY}(R_1)} = w_{\mathbb{QY}(R_2)} = w_{R_2}$ and $\mathbf{ht}(R_1) = \mathbf{ht}(R_2)$, so $\alpha(R_1) = \alpha(R_2)$. $\square$

Definition 7.1.6. For a weak composition a , define an element $\mathcal{F}_a \in \mathcal{BRC}/\Sigma$ by

$$\mathcal{F}_a = \sum_{R:\mathbb{QY}(R)=R, \mathbf{wt}(R)=a} R.$$

Proposition 7.1.7. *The elements $\mathcal{F}_a \in \mathcal{BRC}/\Sigma$ form an additive basis of a subring isomorphic to $\mathcal{D}$ under the homomorphism $\alpha : \mathcal{BRC}/\Sigma \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$, and*

$$\alpha(\mathcal{F}_a) = \mathfrak{F}_a^*.$$

Proof. The last identity is the Corollary above. Distinct $\mathcal{F}_a$ are supported on disjoint sets of quasi-Yamanouchi RC graphs (indexed by their common weight a), so the $\mathcal{F}_a$ are linearly independent in $\mathcal{BRC}/\Sigma$. Considering the homomorphism $\alpha : \mathcal{BRC}/\Sigma \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$, since the $\mathfrak{F}_a^*$ are linearly independent, the kernel of α intersects the span of the $\mathcal{F}_a$ trivially; hence α is injective on $\sum_a \mathbb{Z}\mathcal{F}_a$. Since

$$\alpha(\mathcal{F}_a) \boxplus \alpha(\mathcal{F}_b) = \mathfrak{F}_a^* \boxplus \mathfrak{F}_b^* = \sum_c s_{a,b}^c \mathfrak{F}_c^* = \sum_c s_{a,b}^c \alpha(\mathcal{F}_c),$$

the product $\mathcal{F}_a \boxplus \mathcal{F}_b$ lies in the span of the $\mathcal{F}_c$, so this span is closed under multiplication and the restriction of α is a ring isomorphism. $\square$

Theorem 7.2. *Let a, b be weak compositions of lengths p and q . Write*

$$\mathfrak{F}_a^* \boxplus \mathfrak{F}_b^* = \sum_c s_{a,b}^c \mathfrak{F}_c^*$$

For each c , fix an RC graph C with $\mathbf{wt}(\mathbb{QY}(C)) = c$. Then $s_{a,b}^c$ is the number of distinct RC graphs R with $\mathbf{word}(R) = \mathbf{word}(C)$ with $\mathbf{wt}(\mathbf{clip}^p(R)) = a, \mathbf{wt}(\mathbf{trim}^p(R)) = b$ such that $\mathbf{clip}^p(R), \mathbf{trim}^p(R)$ are quasi-Yamanouchi, and is in particular nonnegative.

Proof. The coefficient of $\mathcal{F}_c$ in $\mathcal{F}_a \sqcup \mathcal{F}_b$ equals the coefficient of $\mathfrak{F}_c^*$ in $\mathfrak{F}_a^* \sqcup \mathfrak{F}_b^*$, namely $s_{a,b}^c$, by Proposition 7.1.7. Expanding the product $\mathcal{F}_a \sqcup \mathcal{F}_b$ via the $(\text{clip}^p, \text{trim}^p)$ -decomposition of $\sqcup$ (Theorem 4.1) and reading off the coefficient of $\mathcal{F}_c$ from a fixed representative C with $\text{wt}(\mathbb{Q}\mathbb{Y}(C)) = c$, the contributing terms are precisely the RC graphs R with $\text{word}(R) = \text{word}(C)$ whose clip and trim have quasi-Yamanouchi weights a and b respectively. $\square$

7.2. A general ideal-quotient Littlewood–Richardson principle. The dual Schubert, dual key, and dual forest LR rules of the previous sections all fit a common template, which we record here.

Theorem 7.3 (General LR principle via ideals of $\mathcal{BRC}$). *Let $\sim$ be an equivalence relation on $\bigsqcup_n \mathcal{RC}_n$ satisfying:*

- (H1) *If $R_1 \sim R_2$ then $\text{ht}(R_1) = \text{ht}(R_2)$ and $w_{R_1} = w_{R_2}$ (in particular $\alpha(R_1) = \alpha(R_2)$).*
- (H2) *$\sim$ is a congruence for $\sqcup$: $R_1 \sim R_2$ implies $R \sqcup R_1 \sim R \sqcup R_2$ and $R_1 \sqcup R \sim R_2 \sqcup R$ for every R .*
- (H3) *clip^p and trim^p descend to $\sim$: if $R_1 \sim R_2$ and $1 \leq p \leq \text{ht}(R_1)$, then $\text{clip}^p(R_1) \sim \text{clip}^p(R_2)$ and $\text{trim}^p(R_1) \sim \text{trim}^p(R_2)$.*
- (H4) *There is an index set J and a function $\lambda : (\mathcal{RC}/\sim) \rightarrow J$ such that, writing $I_\sim = \text{span}_{\mathbb{Z}}\{R_1 - R_2 : R_1 \sim R_2\} \subseteq \mathcal{BRC}$ and*

$$E_\lambda := \sum_{[R]: \lambda([R])=\lambda} [R] \in \mathcal{BRC}/I_\sim,$$

the family $\{\alpha(E_\lambda)\}_{\lambda \in J}$ is a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of $\mathcal{D}$.

Then $I_\sim$ is a two-sided ideal of $\mathcal{BRC}$ contained in $\Omega = \ker \alpha$, the elements $\{E_\lambda\}$ span a subring of $\mathcal{BRC}/I_\sim$ isomorphic to $\mathcal{D}$ via α , and the structure constants $b_{\mu,\nu}^\lambda$ defined by

$$\mathfrak{B}_\mu^* \sqcup \mathfrak{B}_\nu^* = \sum_\lambda b_{\mu,\nu}^\lambda \mathfrak{B}_\lambda^*, \quad \mathfrak{B}_\lambda^* := \alpha(E_\lambda),$$

are nonnegative integers. More precisely, for any function $\text{rep}: \mathcal{RC} \rightarrow \mathcal{RC}$ that sends every element of a $\sim$ -class to a single common representative of that class (that is, $\text{rep}(R) \sim R$ for all R , and $\text{rep}(R) = \text{rep}(S)$ whenever $R \sim S$), we have the positive combinatorial formula

$$b_{\mu,\nu}^\lambda = \#\{R \sim C : \text{clip}^p(R) = \text{rep}(\text{clip}^p(R)), \text{trim}^p(R) = \text{rep}(\text{trim}^p(R)), \\ \lambda([\text{clip}^p(R)]) = \mu, \lambda([\text{trim}^p(R)]) = \nu\}$$

for any fixed C with $\lambda([C]) = \lambda$. The count is independent of the choice of rep .

Proof. By (H1) every generator $R_1 - R_2$ of $I_\sim$ lies in $\Omega = \ker \alpha$, so $I_\sim \subseteq \Omega$ and α descends to a surjective ring homomorphism $\bar{\alpha}: \mathcal{BRC}/I_\sim \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$. By (H2), $I_\sim$ is a two-sided ideal of $\mathcal{BRC}$, so $\mathcal{BRC}/I_\sim$ inherits a ring structure.

By construction of E_λ in (H4), each $\sim$ -class $[R]$ appears in E_λ with multiplicity exactly 1 (when $\lambda([R]) = \lambda$) or 0 (otherwise), and the supports of E_λ and $E_{\lambda'}$ in $\mathcal{BRC}/I_\sim$ are disjoint whenever $\lambda \neq \lambda'$; consequently the coefficient $b_{\mu,\nu}^\lambda$ may be read off from the contribution to a single chosen class $[C]$ with $\lambda([C]) = \lambda$. In particular the $\{E_\lambda\}$ are linearly independent. Under $\bar{\alpha}$ they map to the $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis $\{\mathfrak{B}_\lambda^*\}$ of $\mathcal{D}$ by (H4), so $\bar{\alpha}$ restricts to a $\mathbb{Z}$ -module isomorphism $\bigoplus_\lambda \mathbb{Z}E_\lambda \xrightarrow{\cong} \mathcal{D}$. Since $\bar{\alpha}$ is a ring homomorphism, the span of the E_λ is closed under multiplication and the isomorphism is one of rings. Consequently

$$E_\mu \sqcup E_\nu = \sum_\lambda b_{\mu,\nu}^\lambda E_\lambda \quad \text{in } \mathcal{BRC}/I_\sim.$$

To read off $b_{\mu,\nu}^\lambda$, fix any C with $\lambda([C]) = \lambda$ and let $S_1 = \text{rep}(R_1)$, $S_2 = \text{rep}(R_2)$ be the chosen representatives of the μ - and ν -classes (for any R_1, R_2 in those classes). By Theorem 4.1 the product $\sqcup$ on $\mathcal{BRC}$ admits a $(\text{clip}^p, \text{trim}^p)$ -decomposition: for any S_1, S_2 with $\text{ht}(S_1) = p$, $\text{ht}(S_2) = q$, the set $\{R \in \mathcal{RC}_{p+q} : \text{clip}^p(R) = S_1, \text{trim}^p(R) = S_2\}$ enumerates the summands of $S_1 \sqcup S_2$ with multiplicity one. Projecting to $\mathcal{BRC}/I_\sim$, (H3) ensures that the class of R depends only on the classes of $\text{clip}^p(R)$ and $\text{trim}^p(R)$, so the contribution of $S_1 \sqcup S_2$ to the coefficient of $[C]$ in E_λ is exactly the count of $R \sim C$ for which $\text{clip}^p(R) = S_1$ and $\text{trim}^p(R) = S_2$, i.e. for which $\text{clip}^p(R)$ and $\text{trim}^p(R)$ are themselves fixed points of rep and represent the μ - and ν -classes. This is the stated formula. Being a cardinality, it is nonnegative.

Finally, the count is independent of the choice of rep . The element $E_\lambda \in \mathcal{BRC}/I_\sim$ is defined directly as $\sum_{[R]: \lambda([R])=\lambda} [R]$, with no reference to rep , so the structure constants in $E_\mu E_\nu = \sum_\lambda b_{\mu,\nu}^\lambda E_\lambda$ are intrinsic. To

see that the formula computes the correct value for every valid rep, fix classes $[T_1], [T_2]$ with $\lambda([T_1]) = \mu$, $\lambda([T_2]) = \nu$, and consider, for any $S_1 \in [T_1]$ and $S_2 \in [T_2]$, the count

$$N(S_1, S_2) := \#\{R \sim C : \text{clip}^p(R) = S_1, \text{trim}^p(R) = S_2\}.$$

By the $(\text{clip}^p, \text{trim}^p)$ -decomposition of Theorem 4.1, $N(S_1, S_2)$ equals the coefficient of $[C]$ in the product $[S_1] \sqcup [S_2] \in \mathcal{BRC}/I_\sim$ (using (H2) to make the product well-defined and (H3) to ensure each summand of $S_1 \sqcup S_2$ has $\sim$ -class depending only on $[S_1]$ and $[S_2]$). In particular $N(S_1, S_2)$ depends only on the classes $[T_1], [T_2]$ and on $[C]$, not on the choice of representatives S_1, S_2 . The rep-formula selects, for each such class-pair, the single representative pair $(\text{rep}(T_1), \text{rep}(T_2))$ and counts $N(\text{rep}(T_1), \text{rep}(T_2))$; another valid rep' counts $N(\text{rep}'(T_1), \text{rep}'(T_2))$, and these are equal. Summing over class-pairs yields the same total $b_{\mu, \nu}^\lambda$. $\square$

Remark. In the present paper, Theorem 7.3 is instantiated by

- $\sim$ = equality on $\mathcal{RC}$, with $I_\sim = 0$ and $\lambda([R]) = (w_R, \text{ht}(R))$, recovering Theorem 1.1 (dual Schubert basis);
- $\sim$ = Demazure-crystal equivalence, with $I_\sim = \Theta$ and λ the extremal weight, recovering Theorem 5.4 (dual key basis);
- $\sim \equiv \mathfrak{P}$, with $I_\sim = \Gamma$ and $\lambda = \mathfrak{c}_\mathfrak{P}$, recovering Theorem 6.4 (dual forest basis);
- $\sim$ = “same reduced word and same ht ” on $\mathcal{RC}$, with $\lambda([R]) = \text{wt}(\mathbb{QY}(R))$, recovering Theorem 7.2 (dual slide basis).

The verifications of (H1)–(H4) in each case are precisely the lemmas and propositions of §2, §5, §6, and §7.

NOTATION AND CONVENTIONS

For the reader's convenience we collect here, in one place, the principal symbols used throughout the article. All notation is introduced in context where it is needed; this list is meant as a navigational aid rather than a definition.

Permutations and combinatorial objects.

S_∞ : The group of permutations of $\mathbb{Z}_{>0}$ fixing all but finitely many elements.

$\ell(w)$: The Coxeter length of $w \in S_\infty$.

$\mathfrak{c}(w)$, $\mathfrak{c}^*(w)$: The (right) Lehmer code of w ; the code of w^{-1} .

$\mathfrak{m}(w)$: The position of the last descent of w .

$\mathfrak{d}_\lambda$: The dominant permutation with $\mathfrak{c}^*(\mathfrak{d}_\lambda) = \lambda$.

IndexedForests_n : The set of indexed forests on $[n]$ in the sense of Nadeau–Tewari [26]; matched bijectively with Comp_n via $F \leftrightarrow \mathfrak{c}(F)$, so we use $a \in \text{Comp}_n$ and $F_a \in \text{IndexedForests}_n$ interchangeably.

Forest_n : The subset of IndexedForests_n corresponding to the homology basis $\{[X(F)]\}$ of $H_\bullet(\text{QFl}_n)$ in BGNST [4, Cor. 11.6]; in NST language, those F with $n \notin \text{LT}(F)$.

$\mathcal{RC}_n$: The set of bounded RC graphs with n rows (Definition 4.1.1).

$\mathcal{RC}_n(w)$: The set of $R \in \mathcal{RC}_n$ with $w_R = w$.

$\mathcal{RC}_n^0$: The set of $R \in \mathcal{RC}_n$ whose last row is empty (§4).

w_R : The permutation of an RC graph R .

$\text{ht}(R)$: The number of rows of R .

$\text{wt}(R)$: The row weight composition of R .

$\text{word}(R)$: The reduced word read from R .

Row maps on RC graphs.

$\mathcal{Z}$: The transition map $\mathcal{RC}_n^0 \rightarrow \mathcal{RC}_{n-1}$ of Definition 4.3.1; it realizes the Lascoux–Schützenberger transition formula on the last row.

$\text{trim}^p(R)$: “Truncate”: the RC graph obtained from the last $\text{ht}(R) - p$ rows of R (Definition 4.4.2).

$\text{clip}^p(R)$: “Clip”: the RC graph in $\mathcal{RC}_p$ obtained from R by $\text{ht}(R) - p$ one-row clips (erase the last row, then apply $\mathcal{Z}$ until the height drops by one); depends only on the top p rows of R (Definition 4.4.2, Lemma 4.4.7).

$\uparrow^p$: Shift indices up by p (applied to permutations or letters).

Crystal and forest structures.

e_i, f_i : Crystal raising and lowering operators on RC graphs (Definition 5.1.1).

$\text{Dem}(R)$: The Demazure crystal of R (Assaf–Schilling; Definition 5.1.1).

Dem_a : $\{R : \text{extwt}(R) = a\}$, the set of RC graphs with extremal weight a (§5).

$\text{extwt}(R)$: The extremal weight of $\text{Dem}(R)$, i.e. the weight of its unique lowest weight element (Definition 5.1.1).

$\mathbb{Y}(R)$: The highest-weight representative of R in its Demazure crystal (Definition 5.1.1).

$\mathbb{Y}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R)$: The forest analog of $\mathbb{Y}(R)$: the canonical representative of R in its forest equivalence class, used in the dual forest LR rule (§6).

$P_{\mathfrak{P}}(R)$: The forest invariant of R , an indexed forest (Nadeau–Tewari; §6).

$\mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R) (= \mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R))$: The composition associated to $P_{\mathfrak{P}}(R)$ (§6). The forms $\mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R)$ and $\mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R)$ are used interchangeably.

$\mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(a)$: The set of forest classes of RC graphs with $\mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}} = a$ (§6).

$\equiv_{\mathfrak{P}}$: Forest equivalence: $R \equiv_{\mathfrak{P}} R'$ iff $P_{\mathfrak{P}}(R) = P_{\mathfrak{P}}(R')$ (§6).

$\mathcal{RC}_{\mathfrak{P}}(c)$: The set of $R \in \mathcal{RC}_n$ with $\mathfrak{wt}(R) = c$ such that $\text{word}(\mathbb{Y}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R))$ is lex-minimal among R' with $\mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R') = \mathfrak{c}_{\mathfrak{P}}(R)$ (Theorem 6.3).

The Schubert bialgebra and its dual.

$\mathcal{A}_n$: The polynomial ring $\mathbb{Z}[x_1, \dots, x_n]$ (§2).

$\mathcal{A}$: The Schubert bialgebra $\bigoplus_{n \geq 0} \mathcal{A}_n$, with $\mathcal{A}_m \cdot \mathcal{A}_n = 0$ when $m \neq n > 0$ (§2).

$\mathcal{D}$: The graded dual bialgebra of $\mathcal{A}$ (§3).

$\mathfrak{S}_u^n$: Schubert polynomial in $\mathcal{A}_n$, $\mathfrak{m}(u) \leq n$ (§2).

Ξ_u^n : Element of $\mathcal{D}$ dual to $\mathfrak{S}_u^n$ (§3).

ev : The evaluation map $\mathcal{BRC} \rightarrow \mathcal{A}$ defined by $\text{ev}(R) = x^{\mathfrak{wt}(R)}$ on basis elements (§4).

κ_a, κ_a^* : Key polynomial / its dual; $a \in \text{Comp}_n$ (§5).

$\mathfrak{P}_a, \mathfrak{P}_a^*$: Forest polynomial / its dual; $a \in \text{Comp}_n$ (§6).

$x_a, [a], e_{\mathbf{b}}$: The monomial $x^a = x_1^{a_1} \cdots x_n^{a_n} \in \mathcal{A}_n$; its dual basis element in $\mathcal{D}_n$, written either $[a]$ or $e_{\mathbf{b}}$ depending on context.

$\langle -, - \rangle$: The bialgebra pairing $\mathcal{D} \otimes \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}$ defined by $\langle [a], x^b \rangle = \delta_{a,b}$, equivalently $\langle e_{\mathbf{a}}, x^{\mathbf{b}} \rangle = \delta_{\mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}}$.

Comp_n : The set of weak compositions of length n .

$\Delta, \nabla, \varepsilon$: Coproduct, product, counit on $\mathcal{A}$ (§2).

Δ^* : The dual coproduct on $\mathcal{D}$, dual to the polynomial product on $\mathcal{A}$ (§3).

Structure constants.

$c_{u,v}^w$: Schubert structure constants: $\mathfrak{S}_u \mathfrak{S}_v = \sum c_{u,v}^w \mathfrak{S}_w$.

$d_{u,v}^w(p, q)$: Dual Schubert structure constants of Theorem 1.1.

$k_{a,b}^c$: Dual key structure constants of Theorem 5.4.

$f_{a,b}^c$: Dual forest structure constants of Theorem 6.4.

$s_{a,b}^c$: Dual slide structure constants of Theorem 7.2.

$b_{\mu,\nu}^\lambda$: The general dual LR structure constants of Theorem 7.3.

The ring of RC graphs and its quotients.

$\mathcal{BRC}$: $\bigoplus_{n \geq 0} \mathbb{Z}^{\oplus \mathcal{RC}_n}$, with the product $\boxplus$ (§4).

$\mathcal{BRC}_n$: The graded component $\mathbb{Z}^{\oplus \mathcal{RC}_n}$ of $\mathcal{BRC}$ (RC graphs of height exactly n).

$\mathcal{S}_w(n)$: $\sum_{R: w_R=w, \text{ht}(R)=n} R \in \mathcal{BRC}_n$, the sum of all n -row RC graphs of permutation w ; satisfies $\alpha(\mathcal{S}_w(n)) = \Xi_w^n$ and $\text{ev}(\mathcal{S}_w(n)) = \mathfrak{S}_w^n$ (§4).

K_a : $\sum_{R \in \text{Dem}_a, R=\mathbb{Y}(R)} R \in \mathcal{BRC}/\Theta$, the dual key class sum; $\alpha(K_a) = \kappa_a^*$ (§5).

F_a : $\sum_{[R] \in \mathcal{C}_{\mathfrak{P}}(a)} [R] \in \mathcal{BRC}/\Gamma$, the dual forest class sum; $\alpha(F_a) = \mathfrak{P}_a^*$ (§6).

$\boxplus$: The associative concatenation product on $\mathcal{BRC}$, on $\mathcal{D}$, and on the quotients $\mathcal{BRC}/I_{\sim}$; built from clip^p and trim^p on $\mathcal{BRC}$ (§4.4).

$\alpha : \mathcal{BRC} \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$: Ring homomorphism with $\alpha(R) = \Xi_{w_R}^{\text{ht}(R)}$ (§4).

Ω : $\ker \alpha$, the two-sided ideal of $\mathcal{BRC}$ on which α vanishes (Definition 4.5.5; Theorem 4.5).

Θ : The two-sided ideal generated by $R_1 - R_2$ with $\mathbb{Y}(R_1) = \mathbb{Y}(R_2)$ (Definition 5.2.2); $\mathcal{BRC}/\Theta$ supports the dual key LR rule (Theorem 5.4).

Γ : The two-sided ideal generated by $R_1 - R_2$ with $R_1 \equiv_{\mathfrak{P}} R_2$ (Definition 6.2.4); $\mathcal{BRC}/\Gamma$ supports the dual forest LR rule (Theorem 6.4).

$\mathcal{E}_n$: The elementary basis of $\mathcal{A}_n$ (Theorem 2.2).

Slide polynomials and the general LR template.

$\mathfrak{F}_a(x)$, $\mathfrak{F}_a^*$: Slide polynomial in $\mathcal{A}$ (Assaf–Searles) indexed by a weak composition a ; its dual in $\mathcal{D}$ (§7).

$\text{QY}(R)$: Quasi-Yamanouchi representative of R in its (word, ht) -class; smallest element under the dominance/refinement order on weights (§7).

$\mathcal{RC}_{\text{QY}}(c)$: Set of RC graphs R with $\text{wt}(R) = c$ such that $\text{word}(\text{QY}(R))$ is lex-minimal among R' with $\text{wt}(\text{QY}(R')) = \text{wt}(\text{QY}(R))$ (§7).

Σ : Two-sided ideal of $\mathcal{BRC}$ generated by $R_1 - R_2$ with $\text{QY}(R_1) = \text{QY}(R_2)$ (Lemma 7.1.4).

$\mathcal{F}_a$: The element $\sum_{R=\text{QY}(R), \text{wt}(R)=a} R \in \mathcal{BRC}/\Sigma$, a representative of the slide basis under α (Proposition 7.1.7).

$\sim$: A generic equivalence relation on $\bigsqcup_n \mathcal{RC}_n$ satisfying (H1)–(H4) of Theorem 7.3.

$I_{\sim}$: The two-sided ideal $\text{span}_{\mathbb{Z}}\{R_1 - R_2 : R_1 \sim R_2\} \subseteq \mathcal{BRC}$ (Theorem 7.3).

J, λ : Index set, resp. labeling map $(\mathcal{RC}/\sim) \rightarrow J$ in the general LR template (Theorem 7.3).

E_{λ} : The class sum $\sum_{[R]: \lambda([R])=\lambda} [R] \in \mathcal{BRC}/I_{\sim}$ (Theorem 7.3).

$\mathfrak{B}_{\lambda}^*$, $b_{\mu,\nu}^{\lambda}$: Image $\alpha(E_{\lambda}) \in \mathcal{D}$ and the corresponding structure constants in Theorem 7.3.

Quasisymmetric flag variety (§6.3).

QFl_n : The quasisymmetric flag variety of Bergeron–Gagnon–Nadeau–Spink–Tewari [4], a toric subcomplex of Fl_n stratified by $X(F)$ for $F \in \text{Forest}_n$.

$X(F)$, $[X(F)]$: The toric Richardson variety attached to $F \in \text{Forest}_n$, and its homology class; $\{[X(F)]\}$ is a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of $H_{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_n)$ [4, Cor. 11.6].

$H^{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_n)$, $H_{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_n)$: Cohomology and homology of QFl_n , paired by the integration map $\int_{X(F)}(\cdot)$.

QSym_n^+ : The ideal of quasisymmetric polynomials in $\mathbb{Z}[x_1, \dots, x_n]$ with no constant term; $\text{QSym}_n^+ \cdot \mathcal{A}_n$ is the kernel of the Borel surjection.

π_n : The Borel-type surjection $\mathcal{A}_n \twoheadrightarrow \mathcal{A}_n/(\text{QSym}_n^+ \cdot \mathcal{A}_n) \cong H^{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_n)$ [4, Thm. A and Cor. 12.5].

$[\mathfrak{P}_a]$: The cohomology class $\pi_n(\mathfrak{P}_a) \in H^{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_n)$; under the Borel isomorphism, $\{[\mathfrak{P}_a] : F_a \in \text{Forest}_n\}$ is a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of $H^{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_n)$, Kronecker dual to $\{[X(F_a)]\}$.

$\rho_{p,q}$, $\iota_{p,q}^*$: The variable-splitting substitution $\mathcal{A}_{p+q} \rightarrow \mathcal{A}_p \otimes \mathcal{A}_q$, and the induced ring homomorphism

$$H^{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_{p+q}) \rightarrow H^{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_p) \otimes H^{\bullet}(\text{QFl}_q)$$

(§6.3).

$\epsilon_F(\mathbf{b})$: The path sign of [25, Prop. 10.15]: the coefficient of $\mathfrak{P}_F$ in the forest expansion of $x^{\mathbf{b}}$, valued in $\{-1, 0, +1\}$. By Proposition 6.2.2, $\langle \mathfrak{P}_a^*, x^{\mathbf{b}} \rangle = \epsilon_{F_a}(\mathbf{b})$.

$V_F(\lambda)$: The volume polynomial of [25, §10.5], dual to $\mathfrak{P}_F$ under the divided-power D -pairing; $V_F(\lambda) = \sum_{\mathbf{b}} \epsilon_F(\mathbf{b}) \lambda^{\mathbf{b}}/\mathbf{b}!$.

APPENDIX A. PROOF OF PROPOSITION 2.1.6

We dedicate this section to the otherwise distracting proof of Proposition 2.1.6. Recall from Definition 2.1.2 that $\delta^i = \frac{1}{y_i - y_{i+1}}(1 - s_i)$ acts on the y variables, that $\delta^v \mathfrak{S}_w(x; y) = (-1)^{\ell(v)} \mathfrak{S}_{vw}(x; y)$ whenever $\ell(vw) = \ell(w) - \ell(v)$, and that the skew operators δ_u^w are characterized by the Leibniz formula $\delta^w(pq) = \sum_{u \leq w} \delta_u^w(p) \delta_u^w(q)$.

Proposition A.1 (Special case of Pieri formula [33, Theorem 7.1]). *Suppose $k \geq 1$ and $u, w \in S_\infty$. If $u \xrightarrow{k} w$, then*

$$\delta_u^w \prod_{i=1}^k (x_1 - y_i) = 0$$

If $u \xrightarrow{k} w$, define

$$Q = \{u(i) \mid i \leq k \text{ and } u(i) = w(i)\}$$

then

$$\delta_u^w \prod_{i=1}^k (x_1 - y_i) = (-1)^{\ell(u,w)} \prod_{q \in Q} (x_1 - y_q)$$

Proof. The cited theorem, in the special case $p = k$ (the Molev–Sagan Pieri formula for double Schubert polynomials), is stated for the operators ∂_u^w on the x variables applied to $\prod_{i=1}^k (x_i - y_1)$, with value $\prod_{q \in Q} (x_q - y_1)$. Exchanging the roles of x and y gives $\delta_u^w \prod_{i=1}^k (y_i - x_1) = \prod_{q \in Q} (y_q - x_1)$. Since $\prod_{i=1}^k (y_i - x_1) = (-1)^k \prod_{i=1}^k (x_1 - y_i)$, $\prod_{q \in Q} (y_q - x_1) = (-1)^{|Q|} \prod_{q \in Q} (x_1 - y_q)$, and $|Q| = k - \ell(u, w)$ (the positions $i \leq k$ moved by the $\ell(u, w)$ transpositions witnessing $u \xrightarrow{k} w$ are distinct), the stated sign follows. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 2.1.6. Suppose $v \in S_n$. Since $\ell(vw_0(n)) = \ell(w_0(n)) - \ell(v)$, we have

$$\mathfrak{S}_v(x; y) = (-1)^{\ell(vw_0(n))} \delta^{vw_0(n)}(\mathfrak{S}_{w_0(n)}(x; y))$$

This is equal to

$$(-1)^{\ell(vw_0(n))} \delta^{vw_0(n)} \left(\mathfrak{S}_{s_{n+1-i} \cdots s_1 w_0(n)}(x^{(i)}; y) \prod_{j=1}^{n+1-i} (x_i - y_j) \right)$$

and, applying the Leibniz formula together with $\delta^u \mathfrak{S}_{s_{n+1-i} \cdots s_1 w_0(n)}(x^{(i)}; y) = (-1)^{\ell(u)} \mathfrak{S}_{v'}(x^{(i)}; y)$ for $u = v'w_0(n)s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i}$, is also equal to

$$\sum_{\substack{v' \in S_\infty \\ \ell(v'w_0(n)s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i}) \\ = \ell(w_0(n)s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i}) - \ell(v')}} (-1)^{\ell(vw_0(n)) + \ell(v'w_0(n)s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i})} \mathfrak{S}_{v'}(x^{(i)}; y) \delta_{v'w_0(n)s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i}}^{vw_0(n)} \prod_{j=1}^{n+1-i} (x_i - y_j)$$

By the restricted Pieri formula (Proposition A.1), for this to be nonzero we need $v'w_0(n)s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i} \xrightarrow{n+1-i} vw_0(n)$. We note that $v'w_0(n)s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i} \xrightarrow{n+1-i} vw_0(n)$ if and only if

$$v \xrightarrow{i} v'w_0(n)s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i}w_0(n) = v's_n s_{n-1} \cdots s_i$$

We have that $v's_n \cdots s_i$ is exactly $\varphi_{i,n}(v')$ since $v' \in S_n$, so we require that

$$v \xrightarrow{i} \varphi_{i,n}(v')$$

so the sum is over all v' with $v \xrightarrow{i} v'$.

Applying Proposition A.1, the skew operator contributes a further sign $(-1)^{\ell(v'w_0(n)s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i}, vw_0(n))}$; together with the signs already present this is $(-1)^{2\ell(vw_0(n))} = 1$, so the result is equal to

$$\sum_{v \xrightarrow{i} v'} \mathfrak{S}_{v'}(x^{(i)}; y) \prod_{a \in A(v', v)} (x_i - y_a)$$

where $A(v', v)$ is the set of all $vw_0(n)(j)$ such that $1 \leq j \leq n+1-i$ and $v'w_0(n)s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i}(j) = vw_0(n)(j)$. These values are the same as at the indices that comprise the set of all $1 \leq j \leq n+1-i$ such that

$$v'(n+2 - s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i}(j)) = v(n+2 - j)$$

Applying the $s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i}$ to j , since $1 \leq j \leq n+1-i$ we have that

$$s_1 \cdots s_{n+1-i}(j) = j + 1$$

Hence we need

$$v'(n+2-(j+1)) = v'(n+1-j) = v(n+2-j)$$

Replacing j with $n+2-p$, the indices are the set of all p such that $i < p \leq n+1$ and

$$v'(p-1) = v(p)$$

Thus $A(v', v)$ is the set of all $v(p)$ such that $p > i$ and $v'(p-1) = v(p)$, which is exactly $Q_i(v', v)$, and we are done. $\square$

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